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EYE

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"Cockroaches won... Democracy won! Students' struggle has borne fruit"
COCKROACH JANTA PARTY

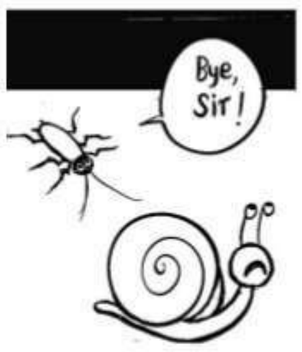
"For BJP workers, country, youth, students more important than any post"
AMIT SHAH, UNION HOME MINISTER

Jantar Mantar is heard, Pradhan is out

Democracy Instapolitics: 2 months old, born online from a CJI jibe, CJP mobilised Gen Z to change a law — and a minister

Protesters celebrate after Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan announced his resignation, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



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OPPOSITION MAY END HOUSE SIEGE, KEEP HEAT ON GOVT OVER EDUCATION REFORMS

NEW ANTI-PAPER LEAK BILL: SPECIAL TASK FORCE TO PROBE CASES IN 2 MONTHS

PROTESTERS WHO MADE JANTAR MANTAR HOME HEAD BACK AFTER 36 DAYS

Will not let youth fall prey to confusion, says Pradhan; Pralhad Joshi gets Education charge

Jatin Anand, Liz Mathew, Sophiya Mathew & Divya A
New Delhi, July 25

BRINGING TO an end the more than month-long student protest in the heart of the Capital that had captivated public attention and heated up politics, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned Saturday, sparking wild celebrations at the Jantar Mantar protest venue.

As the government also accepted its other demands of no legal proceedings against the protesters and compensation for the families of NEET aspirants who ended their lives after the paper leak in May, the Cockroach Janta Party, which spearheaded the protest, called off the stir.

Asking supporters to leave the protest venue and return to their homes, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said Pradhan's resignation, their main demand, demonstrated the power of a united youth movement. "The world bows down, and one who makes it bow is needed," he said. He listed the names of the students who died by suicide and said, "These are the children who have received justice today."

Dharmendra Pradhan announced his resignation in an open letter posted on X

Pradhan's resignation and the end of the protest cleared the decks for the government to return to Parliament Monday with a new Bill to ensure swift and stringent punishment to those involved in exam paper leaks. The draft Bill was cleared by the Union Cabinet Friday, hours after Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in a midnight video post, announced the formation of fast-track courts and a tough new law.

In an open letter announcing his resignation — he posted it on X — Pradhan said, "We

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'We have done it,' Dipke breaks news as CJP calls off protest

Says country's youth will talk about education, employment, the future

Sophiya Mathew & Abhimanyu Hazarika
New Delhi, July 25

FOR A moment, it did not register. Then Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), sank to his knees, overcome by shock and joy, realising that Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had resigned.

Rising to address students and volunteers who had spent 36 days with him at the protest site, Dipke said, "We have done it. We have bloody done it."

Pradhan's resignation had been the central demand of the CJP-led protest. "What did they say? That there are no resignations in this government. For 36 days, every day they asked me this question... These people won't give resignations, everyone told me."

He said Pradhan's resignation demonstrated the power of a united youth movement. "The world bows down, and one who makes it bow is needed," he said, adding that the protest had secured "justice" for students who had died by suicide following the NEET paper leak.

He said attempts to break their resolve had failed. "They

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke addresses the protesters at Jantar Mantar, Saturday. PTI

Triumph and joy at protest Ground Zero; 'We took his resignation, (he) didn't give it'

Tabshir Shams, Pragynesh, Abhimanyu Hazarika, Mishal Mussaddique, Kartikeya Bhattacharyya, Devansh Mittal & Swati Bhasin
New Delhi, July 25

BY 1 pm on Saturday, the loudest sound at Jantar Mantar was not of protesters' chanting, but of warnings.

Again and again, a police announcement van stationed at the intersection of Jai Singh Road and Tolstoy Marg repeated the same message: "There are elements amongst you who are throwing stones at us. Please refrain, and remove these people. We urge you to remain peaceful."

A group of students, who were at Jantar Mantar for more than 10 days, leave the venue after the CJP ended its protest, Saturday. ABHINAV SAHA

On one side of the barricades stood personnel of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) in their battle gear and helmets. On the other stood thousands of protesters.

A handful of young men surged forward. Tear gas followed.

For a few minutes, the intersection disappeared behind

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

What changed in 48 hours? Concerns over Parliament washout, larger stir

Sentiment on Pradhan was not turning positive even after announcements of fast-track courts, harsh Bill to punish culprits

Jatin Anand, Shubhangi Khapre & Ritika Chopra
New Delhi, Mumbai, July 25

JUST 48 hours before Dharmendra Pradhan quit, his resignation was not in the government's mind, top BJP and government sources said.

But the assessment on three specific aspects seem to have prompted the action. One, the protests gained further momentum in Delhi despite police action, and spread across many cities. Two, concerns that a prolonged confrontation could wash out the entire Monsoon Session of Parliament, jeopardising the political capital spent on building support for the contentious delimitation and the women's reservation bills. Three, the government's actions — fast track courts, shifting of higher education secretary, a Bill with harsh measures to prevent paper leaks, and sacking of 47 NTA officials — did not cut ice with protesters.

At the beginning of the week on Monday, a day after activist Sonam Wangchuk was removed from Jantar Mantar and admitted to a hospital, the assessment within the government was that protests would eventually lose steam. NEET as well as other major entrance examinations were after all over, and the academic calendar was largely on track.

While the government closely monitored the agitation, there was little indication

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Happening today

● **THE ARMY WILL** host a wreath-laying ceremony at the Kargil War Memorial in Dras, Ladakh, to mark India's victory over Pakistan in 1999. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Army chief General Dhiraj Seth and Ladakh L-G V K Saxena will be among those attending the ceremony.

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THE WORLD PAGE 12

HOUTHIS FIRE MISSILES AT SAUDI ARABIA, TARGETS OIL SITE

● SENSE OF RELIEF FOR CJP FOUNDER'S PARENTS

At Dipke home, mother marks 'victory', father says he will never join politics

Dipanita Nath
Pune, July 25

"GOING TO take a nap. See you all in a little while."

At 4:32 pm on Saturday, Abhijeet Dipke posted on X two lines that would sound inane on any other day. But this wasn't any other day — just two hours earlier, at 2:18 pm, Dharmendra Pradhan announced he was resigning from his post as Union Education Minister, capping a chapter that began with Dipke launching the Cockroach Janta Party on May 16.

PAGE 1 anchor

Dipke had just finished his studies at Boston University when he heard about Chief Justice of India Surya Kant's May 15 remark appearing to compare unemployed youth to cockroaches. The CJP was born the very next day when he asked on X — "What if all cockroaches come together?" — and in less than a week, it had captured the imagination of lakhs online, particularly on Instagram, where the Jantar Mantar protests would eventually play out in real time.

"I had never imagined he would become so big," his father, Bhagwan Shankar Dipke, told *The Indian Express* on Saturday.

But Dipke wasn't content letting the CJP remain an online entity. On June 6, he returned to India; as he walked out of Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport, Dipke, who is Dalit, held up a copy of the book *Dr B R Ambedkar, My Autobiography*.

Abhijeet Dipke's parents, Bhagwan Shankar and Anita Dipke, at their home in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Saturday

By that time, the CJP already had over 20 million followers on Instagram. What would follow was the protest at Jantar Mantar which, amplified by activist Sonam Wangchuk's indefinite fast, quickly drew thousands from across the country and became a headache for the central government.

With the CJP calling for an end to the protest on Saturday, Bhagwan Shankar and his wife Anita feel a sense of relief. "For two-and-a-half months, the students have been fighting for Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. This is victory," said Anita, from their home in Maharashtra's Aurangabad, now called Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar. "Abhijeet has fought patiently. He was slapped and vilified. He has achieved so much at such a young age."

In the morning, Bhagwan Shankar, who retired as a civil engineer at Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation, went to a temple in the nearby Pandharpur village and prayed for the country.

Anita said she last spoke to Dipke over a video call on Friday. He told her, "Mummy, *thoda* viral *ho gaya*." She said that, initially, she "did not approve of what Abhijeet was doing". "Then, I saw that he was fighting for students," she said. His father chimed in, "Abhijeet will never go into politics."

He added that nobody in their family has been in politics: "Not even a sarpanch."

"My biggest dream for him was the civil services. I used to tell him that, if he cracked the UPSC exam, he would have a secure career," he said.

At the Dipke household, education has always been of paramount importance. Dipke, who has an elder sister, was expected to follow in his father's footsteps and become an engineer. He was a quiet, studious boy and did not give his parents reasons to worry. His father mentioned Abhijeet's passion for cricket: "I had to stop his cricket. With so many cricketers around

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Rajnath: Great Nicobar project will safeguard Indo-Pacific interests

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 25

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh has said the Great Nicobar Island project is a strategic national initiative to safeguard India's maritime and commercial interests in the Indo-Pacific, marking his first response to concerns raised by Congress MP Jairam Ramesh on the mega project.

The Rs 81,000 crore project, Singh said on July 17, will enhance India's ability to sustain presence, move assets, and monitor critical sea lanes of communication. Singh was responding to a June 12 and May 16 correspondence by Ramesh, in which he had appealed to consider expanding existing defence assets on the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, such as INS Baaz at Campbell Bay, among others, and argued that the Great Nicobar Island project in its current form was a "recipe for ecological disaster".

The government has proposed an integrated township, a trans-shipment container port, a solar and gas-based power plant, and a greenfield military and civilian use airport as part of the project. Land has also been earmarked for defence purposes on the western flank of the trans-shipment port site.

Singh said Ramesh's suggestion that India's strategic requirements can adequately be addressed through expansion of existing defence facilities reflects an "incomplete appreciation" of the project and the nature of maritime security in the Indo-Pacific. "The repeated characterisation of the project as just a costly commercial venture overlooks the strategic realities of the region," Singh said. He said the projects at Great Nicobar Island are intended to further India's "commercial resilience" and "bolster national security". "The project—located in the proximity of vital SLOCs (Sea Lanes of Communication) enhances our maritime domain awareness and adds to our outreach — an advantage other military stations further away cannot provide."

Singh also explained that the possibility of developing INS Baaz as a brownfield project was examined, but was not considered suitable as "it would have entailed substantial land reclamation and disturbance to the tribal population, flora and fauna". Therefore, he said, the decision to pursue a greenfield project at Galathea Bay was a considered decision based on strategic, operational, environmental, and social factors.

He sought to rebut Ramesh's charge that environmental and tribal concerns have been disregarded for the project, saying all "statutory approvals" have been granted following appraisal by expert bodies, with stringent safeguards and mitigation steps.

On Saturday, Ramesh stressed the project is "most fundamentally a commercial enterprise" for which strategic rationale is being invented and propagated to build a counter-narrative. This, he said, is being done as evidence that the project will destroy a unique ecosystem mounted. He also rebutted the claims of the greenfield airport at Galathea Bay entailing far lesser environmental, social and operational costs than expansion at INS Baaz, terming it "logically contradictory".

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Pradhan is out

will not let the nation's youth power fall prey to a web of confusion and misinformation."

"To ensure that anti-national forces do not exploit the situation arising at Jantar Mantar and across the country, that national unity remains intact, that no student's future gets tangled in legal complexities, and that our children can focus their time on studying and building their careers – considering all these factors, I have submitted my resignation to the Honourable Prime Minister," he said.

"Looking at the sequence of events over the past 10 days, my heart is deeply distressed. This is not a matter of personal reputation for me. The youth power of India is the true strength of this country," he said.

"From day one, I took responsibility for this and never turned my back on the situation. My resolve was that we would not let any meritorious student's prospects be ruined by the examination mafia, nor allow injustice to happen to any student," he said.

The NEET-UG re-examination results on July 16, Pradhan said, were satisfactory with many meritorious students from underprivileged backgrounds achieving success. During this period, he said "individuals holding responsible positions attempted to create obstacles and mislead several students" which "deeply pained" him.

"I have always had unwavering faith in the strength of our democracy and a deep respect for the aspirations, dreams, and expectations of the youth. They are not just India's future, but the carriers, creators, and architects of a new and developed India (Viksit Bharat)," he said.

According to a source, Pradhan was asked late Friday to put in his papers. On Saturday, following the announcement, the BJP threw its weight behind Pradhan, leader after leader thanking him for his services.

Acknowledging Pradhan's "pivotal role" in reforming the education landscape and successfully implementing the National Education Policy, among other initiatives, BJP president Nitin Nabin, in a post on X, said, "Prioritising larger interests, his decision to step down reflects the highest standards of integrity and selfless service in public life. The party stands firmly with Shri Dharmendra Pradhan Ji in this decision."

Union Home Minister Amit Shah, in a post on X, said, "For BJP workers, the country, our youth, and students are far more important than any position." The resignation of Pradhan from his post, he said, "exemplifies this very principle".

"The Modi government respects the sentiments of the country's youth and is committed to implementing the necessary reforms against paper leaks. The decisions taken by Modi ji to ensure strict punishment for those guilty of paper leaks are commendable. I am fully confident that these steps will ensure complete justice for the students who succeeded in the NEET examination," Shah said.

Later in the evening, Rashtrapati Bhavan announced that Pralhad Joshi, Minister of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, and New and Renewable Energy, had also been assigned charge of Education.

"The President of India, as advised by the Prime Minister, has accepted the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan from the Union Council of Ministers, with immediate effect, under clause (2) of Article 75 of the Constitution of India," Rashtrapati Bhavan said.

"Further, as advised by the Prime Minister, the President has directed that Pralhad Joshi, Cabinet Minister, be assigned the charge of the Ministry of Education, in addition to his existing portfolio," it said.

Joshi, who is the Lok Sabha MP from Dharwad in Karnataka, was in his constituency when he was told that he was also being given charge of the Education Ministry. He took an evening flight from Hubli and returned to New Delhi.

In a post on X, Joshi said Pradhan "has had an illustrious political career spanning decades. His commitment to the development of the nation will always be remembered".

"His tenure witnessed the successful implementation of NEP 2020 along with over 100 big and small reforms in the field of education. Placing larger interest above everything else, Shri Pradhan Ji's decision to step down does not in any way stop in contributing to the nation's development," Joshi said, adding, "Our paths will cross again in the line of development of the nation."

— With HARIKISHAN SHARMA

What changed? Concerns over House washout, larger stir

Pradhan's resignation was under consideration. Senior Education Ministry officials met the Prime Minister's Office and the Ministry of Home Affairs on July 22-23 to assess the situation, sources said. Pradhan continued with his official engagements, chairing meetings with states on school education on both days.

By Thursday evening, however, the government's calculations had begun to shift. The Prime Minister has been in direct control, signalling his intent to address every concern of the youth, and his personal appeals were continuously gauged to see if they resonated among students, a BJP MP said.

During this period too, not only did the crowds at Jantar Mantar continue to swell, smaller protests broke out across many state capitals and other big cities. In Mumbai, for instance, despite prohibitory orders and FIRs naming nearly 300 protesters, the turnout at each successive demonstration grew larger.

All measures to contain the fallout including the harsh Bill cleared by Cabinet on Friday to punish those indulging in paper leaks, did not seem to ease the protests, sources in the government said. The government first offered a discussion in Parliament, then transferred Higher Education Secretary Vineet Joshi, and later announced the removal of five NTA officials while promising a wider overhaul of the examination body.

None of these steps eased the protests, and the government concluded that a bigger political signal was needed. "It seemed the sentiment with regard to the Education Minister was not turning positive even after the draft of the new proposed law was cleared by the Cabinet. There were not many choices," a senior BJP source said.

Adding to the concerns was Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's sit-in just outside the Prime Minister's residence, which, sources said, reinforced the perception within the ruling leadership it was losing control of the political narrative. This heightened fears the Monsoon Session could be washed out, an outcome the government was keen to avoid given the Bills lined up for passage, particularly on delimitation and women's reservation, for which it had worked hard for months.

The speed with which the decision was taken, sources said, was reflected in Pradhan's own schedule. As late as Friday evening, he attended a briefing to prepare for Parliament questions relating to his ministry. "If he knew he was no longer going to be the minister, would he have sat through a detailed briefing on answering questions?" said a source familiar with the meeting. There was "absolutely no indication" at the time that a resignation was imminent, the source said.

In public, the party and the government argued throughout that the demand for Pradhan's resignation was political. Party leaders were apprehensive it would come across as a moral victory for the Opposition, especially Rahul Gandhi.

But the mood within the party was shifting. At least two Cabinet ministers *The Indian Express* spoke with said Pradhan may have to forego the education portfolio. Some state leaders called his continuation "untenable". "Both the government and the BJP could not afford to antagonise the youth and women," a senior party leader said.

With the Cockroach Janta Party threatening a larger national protest if its demands were not met, there were concerns things could go out of hand. "Many opposition parties, especially the Congress, the Aam Aadmi Party and the Samajwadi Party, had sent their members to the protest on one pretext or another. Had protests continued, it had the potential of becoming larger and more complex with the aid of experienced political hands. That has been nipped now," another senior BJP source said.

Highly placed BJP sources said the decision to seek Pradhan's resignation would help shift the focus back to Parliament from Monday. "The central leadership of the BJP was keen to end the stalemate to get Parliament working. With important Bills on women, delimitation and education, they believed business in Parliament would help them recover the loss of face and consolidate themselves through their passage," the source said.

Protest Ground Zero

drifting smoke. Protest volunteers ran through the crowd, urging people to step back. Ashutosh Ranka of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) climbed onto the police announcement vehicle, asking demonstrators to remain calm.

And then, around 2.20 pm, another message began moving through the crowd.

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had resigned.

At first, people looked at one another, unsure whether to believe the news of victory. Their own phones were not working — Internet jammers had been activated around the protest site — and they could not immediately check the news.

Then someone shouted. Then another. Shouts of triumph and joy.

Within seconds, disbelief gave way to celebration.

Water bottles became makeshift fountains as people sprayed one another. Protesters climbed onto each other's shoulders. Music crackled from the speakers.

It seemed the joy could not be controlled: every few seconds, ripples of hooting and chants of "*Hum jeet gaye*" passed through the crowd. In the throng, screaming in joy, were students in their uniforms bunking school, college mates in groups, young professionals who had waited for a Saturday to travel to the protest site, and parents with young children.

A journalist, speaking into a microphone, officiously announced what people already knew: "Dharmendra Pradhan has given his resignation."

Immediately, a voice immediately rose from the crowd. "*Istifa liya hai, diya nahin hai*," it corrected the journalist. "We have taken his resignation. He did not give it."

The one-liner raced through the gathering, striking a chord, and repeated from one group to another.

Near the main protest stage, actor Sudhir Sangwan, known for Maamla Legal Hai, drew laughter when he announced that "Melodi" sweets would soon be distributed.

He then made a request to the police. "Please remove the jammers," he said, so people could upload photographs of themselves waving the Tricolour.

Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the CJP, briefly dropped to his knees before standing to address the crowd. "We have done it. We have bloody done it," he said.

Mallika, a homemaker from Gurgaon who had come to the protest with her 11-year-old son, said she was surprised it took the government so long to act.

"It's a shame it took so long," she said, and congratulated the GenZ protesters for refusing to give up and leave.

Some distance from the protest site, at the Janpath intersection, entrepreneur Neha and Lady Shri Ram College graduate Manisha, who were attending the protest for the first time, watched the scenes around them. "They (the protesters) have really achieved something that nobody has done before," Neha said.

Manisha laughed. "You're lucky," she told her friend. "You came (to the protest), and he (Pradhan) resigned."

An 18-year-old student who gave his name as Aman said, "This protest is the beginning. Other corrupt ministers must be forced to resign as well to enforce accountability."

A parent from Dehradun said they had come to support their child and other protesters at Jantar Mantar. "The resignation of Pradhan was necessary for students to get back to studying," the parent said.

All around, a sea of people danced in the streets, waved the Tricolour, and held up portraits of Bhagat Singh and Babasaheb Ambedkar. There were repeated cries of "*Inquilab Zindabad*", "*Jai Bhim*", and "*Bharat Mata ki Jai*".

People shot reels on the *Rang De Basanti* song and danced to '*India Wale*' and '*Chak de India*'. Some clicked selfies, some sang along. A large group of protesters stood still as the National Anthem was sung.

A generation long blamed for not being political enough appeared to have finally proved itself, using a grammar of politics and resistance that was inspired by previous generations, but which was still completely novel in form and delivery.

By evening, even after the organisers had announced that the government had accepted all their demands and the agitation had been withdrawn, the crowd lingered.

The police announcement van now broadcast a different message: "The Metro has been opened. We urge you to return home. Your demands have been met." Outside Janpath Metro Gate No. 2, volunteers handed out water bottles and slices of pizza.

As the site slowly emptied out, a group of volunteers continued to work, cleaning the piled-up trash. Twenty-six-year-old Tushar Mehra said he would not leave until the area was clean. "We created this... Cleaning it is also our responsibility."

Real Creator IAS Edition https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F

We have done it: CJP

were sitting in the rain... Police cut off the water supply, still you sat. They closed the police station, still you sat. They made many attempts to break your courage. But your courage can't be broken," he said.

"When Hindu and Muslim rise above politics, when we talk about issues, then the nation will do well. This country's youth will talk about education. This country's youth will talk about the future. (They) will talk about employment," he said.

Dipke, who had returned to India from the United States to lead the agitation, said the movement had disproved those who had argued that the government could not be forced to act.

"Many people said, 'Do you think you will go to India? Will a revolution come to India?' It has come," he said. "The youth of this country have shown that if they come together, they can make anyone bow."

He told the crowds: "Don't make me a hero because of Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. The country has been ruined because one person has been made a hero."

Also addressing the Chief Justice of India, Dipke said, "Justice Surya Kant, thank you so much for calling us cockroaches. If you didn't say it then I wouldn't have come back to India" — the CJI has clarified that his remarks about cockroaches during a court hearing was only in the context of those who had entered the legal profession using fake degrees and that he was not referring to all youth for whom he had great respect.

Away from Jantar Mantar, the CJP and the government reached an understanding after Pradhan resigned. The CJP agreed to call off the protest after the government agreed not to pursue legal action against the protesters and compensate the families of NEET aspirants who ended their lives, and look at the CJP's five-point charter on examination reforms.

At a press conference with Union Ministers JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh at the Constitution Club of India, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said, "Cockroach Janta Party declares that we withdraw the agitation in good faith, with the understanding that the agreed-upon terms will be executed within the agreed-upon timelines."

Ashutosh Ranka, also a CJP spokesperson, said: "All our demands have been accepted, so we request the protesters to withdraw immediately and return home peacefully. We will inform you of our future strategy or any other issues. But we request the protesters to withdraw immediately."

Nadda and Singh shook hands with Das and Ranka. Nadda said the government had considered the demands raised by the CJP and accepted them. "The five-point charter you gave me is related to reforms in education examinations. We will think deeply about it, and after talking to your delegation, we will try to do whatever we can," he said.

"So these were their demands. I think the government has sympathetically considered all the demands they had made and has also accepted them," he said.

A key point of discussion was the police action and cases registered during the agitation. Nadda said the government would provide the protesters with copies of the FIRs and assured them that no retaliatory action would be taken.

On compensation for the families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide, Nadda said the government was sympathetic to their plight and would provide compensation in accordance with the applicable rules. "Whatever maximum will be possible will be given to them," he said.

Dipke mother marks 'victory', father says he will never join politics

us in our country, what future did a middle-class boy have?"

Dipke completed his schooling at Saraswati Bhuvan College in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, and then enrolled at Sinhagad Institute in Pune for a degree in engineering. "*Hamara ristedar vagairah, koi bhi nahin* Pune *mein. Sirf padhai ke liye usko bheja tha* Pune *mein* (We have no relatives in Pune. It was only for his education that we sent him to Pune)," said Bhagwan Shankar.

But Dipke's heart was not in engineering. "He wanted to study journalism. Being a civil engineer, I had knowledge of medical and engineering courses and colleges, but journalism was an entirely unknown territory," said Bhagwan Shankar. Dipke enrolled at Tilak Maharashtra Vidyapeeth in Pune to study journalism and graduated in 2021, while simultaneously working for the Aam Aadmi Party's social media platforms and as a communications advisor for the Delhi government's education department.

"When he told me that he wanted to pursue further studies in Public Relations, I was close to retirement. I took an education loan and Abhijeet left to complete his post-graduation in Public Relations at Boston University's College of Communication," said Bhagwan Shankar. "I am still paying off his education loan."

28 years on tentative list, Sarnath now a UNESCO World Heritage Site

Bhupendra Pandey & Divya A
Lucknow, New Delhi, July 25

SARNATH, THE ancient site where Lord Buddha delivered his first sermon after attaining enlightenment, has been inscribed on UNESCO's World Heritage List, becoming India's 45th and Uttar Pradesh's fourth World Heritage Site.

The announcement came Saturday during the 48th session of the UNESCO World Heritage Committee held in Busan, South Korea.

Sarnath, one of the holiest sites of Buddhism, has recorded its significance on the global platform for heritage recognition. The state government stated this would strengthen Uttar Pradesh's Buddhist Circuit on the international tourism and cultural heritage map.

According to the UP Tourism Department, Sarnath was included in UNESCO's tentative list on July 3, 1998. Twenty-eight years on, it has been officially designated a World Heritage Site. Until now, the state's three World Heritage Sites were the Taj Mahal, Agra Fort and Fatehpur Sikri — all in the Agra region.

Sarnath is the sacred land where Lord Buddha, after attaining enlightenment, delivered his first sermon to humanity and set in motion the 'Dharmachakra Pravartan'. Counted among the holy pilgrimage sites of Buddhism, Sarnath is described in ancient Buddhist scriptures such as Rishipattan.

Sarnath has become India's 45th and Uttar Pradesh's fourth site to be added to the UNESCO World Heritage List. AP

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

Months ahead of its nomination, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) had replaced the existing plaque at the site — to "correct" its recorded history — replacing the names of colonial rulers to credit the local royal family with discovering the site.

The Indian Express had reported in September 2025 about a proposal to change the perception that credited British archaeologists and officers for preserving the site.

"After an extensive study of authentic documents and primary historical evidence, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), New Delhi, has acknowledged that the site of Sarnath in Varanasi first came to light during the digging carried out on the orders of Babu Jagat Singh," said Pradeep Narayan Singh, a descendant of Jagat Singh, in a statement released in March.

"Sarnath has a close association with Lord Buddha, whose timeless message of wisdom, compassion and harmony inspires the world," said Prime Minister Narendra Modi in a post on X, and "This recognition celebrates India's profound civilisational and spiritual heritage."

Conservation architect Abha Narain Lambah, who played a key role in preparing Sarnath's UNESCO nomination, said, "Sarnath's identity is not limited only to its monuments." According to her, "For nearly 2,500 years, the Buddhist pilgrimage tradition has remained alive here, and it is this integrated cultural and spiritual heritage that makes Sarnath uniquely deserving of the World Heritage status."

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CJP'S 'SANSAD CHALO' MARCH ON JULY 20

'Force gradient' adopted for crowd control not as per standards, training, says RAF

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 25

THE CHIEF of Rapid Action Force (RAF) is learnt to have told all the personnel that the "force gradient" adopted for crowd control during CJP's Sansad Chalo march on June 20 was not in accordance with prescribed standards and RAF training, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The observation came after an internal review flagged serious operational lapses when protesters were marching towards Parliament, with three persons receiving pellet gun injuries.

In the context of policing, a force gradient refers to the different levels of force that police may use depending on the threat or resistance they face.

The directions were issued by Inspector General (RAF) Seema Dhundhia when she held a video conference meeting on July 22 with company commanders and commandants deployed in Delhi.

"The meeting reviewed the role, deployment and conduct of RAF personnel during the protest at Jantar Mantar and the Sansad Chalo march. A series of corrective measures were laid down for future law and order duties," a source said.

As per sources, Dhundhia told officers that no proper and timely briefing of their personnel was conducted before they were deployed around Jantar Mantar and Parliament on July 20. Maintaining that Sector Headquarters had not received timely information on the actual deployment, location and operational activities of the companies, she directed that future reports must include the same in regard to each company.

The RAF, a specialised unit of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), was raised in 1992 to deal with riots and other public disturbance.

A student, Sahil, injured in alleged police pellet firing in New Delhi. ANI

According to sources, Dhundhia also directed that the personnel, who have recently been transferred from special operations zones, including Jammu and Kashmir, should not immediately be deployed in crowd control management duties in Delhi. "Dhundia emphasised that personnel transferred from the special operations zone such as Jammu & Kashmir, or other operational areas, possess a different work environment and operational perspective, but sectors such as Delhi, Bihar, Assam and Maharashtra require a distinct and balanced approach to crowd control and public order management," the source said.

"Officers were instructed that force must be used only to the extent necessary, in a judicious, fair, balanced and sensitive manner. They were also told that before using force, personnel should issue necessary warnings and use graded crowd-control measures such as lathicharge, tear smoke and other approved methods only according to the situation," the source added.

According to senior officers, the RAF's role had been appreciated at the sector level, but the internal assessment showed "serious shortcomings" in several aspects of the deployment that required immediate correction. A key concern raised during the review was the alleged lack of proper briefing before deployment. "Commandants were told to ensure that every personnel is clearly briefed on their role, responsibility, crowd control strategy, use of equipment, safety gear and weapons before being sent for duty," the source said.

"Some personnel deployed during the protest were seen in social media videos and mobile footage performing duty without body protectors and helmets. All the senior officers were directed that all personnel must be fully equipped with prescribed safety gear before every deployment. Particular emphasis was placed on helmets, visors, protective equipment and the serviceability of gear," the source added.

Until further orders, PAG, Anti-Riot Gun, Electric Shock Weapon and Electric Shield would not be issued to personnel deployed in the present Delhi situation, sources said.

"No personnel should be deployed for crowd control or operational duties unless they have undergone RAF conversion training. If personnel have to be sent on duty due to shortage of manpower, they must be briefed in detail and made fully sensitive to crowd-control requirements," the source said. "Personnel should not respond to provocation, abusive language or personal remarks, and must maintain restraint, patience and professional conduct in all situations.," the source added.

When asked, DG (CRPF) General Gyanendra Pratap Singh said, "Now, since protest has been called off, and once assembled people disperse, we would make a professional post event assessment, like we do after every major assignment."

'A gifted athlete': Army officer's son's life cut short as car falls into drain

Pragynesh
New Delhi, July 25

The damaged vehicle near the Nangal Dewat area in New Delhi on Friday; (above) deceased Yashvendra Singh. PTI & EXPRESS

ABOUT 10 days ago, Yashvendra Singh, 20, landed in Delhi from the United States, where he studied at Indiana University's Kelley School of Business. Son of an Indian Army Brigadier, posted in Kolkata, Yashvendra was living in the Capital briefly with his maternal grandfather, who was undergoing cancer treatment.

"His maternal grandfather was living at an Army guest house in Hauz Khas and he was staying there with him," said a family member, adding that his parents were living in Kolkata due to his father's posting.

He was later going to visit his paternal grandfather in Dehradun where he intended to stay for a longer break, according to his family members.

On Friday morning, Yashvendra was driving his friend's car, with her sitting by his side — they were visiting her home in South Delhi's Vasant Kunj, according to police. The duo studied at the same university in the US where they met and became friends. Police said they spent the previous night at another friend's house.

The road in the area was slippery due to rain, according to officers. Yashvendra allegedly lost control of the wheel at a sharp turn. The car allegedly struck a tree, before it veered off the road, overturned and plunged into a drain near a red light at Nangal Dewat. The 20-year-old student died and the woman, who was travelling with him, was injured.

"He was rushed for medical treatment but later succumbed to the injuries," said an officer.

With an athlete's build and sharp cheekbones, Yashvendra had been studying at the Indiana University for over two years now. He passed his Class 12 exams from Sanskriti School in Delhi in 2024. He was a national-level basketball player and a gold-medallist.

In a condolence message, the school said, "The Sanskriti School community is deeply saddened by the untimely passing of our beloved alumnus, national-level basketball player and a gold medalist, Yashvendra Singh, from the Batch of 2024, a gifted athlete whose passion for the sport, unwavering determination, and warm spirit; left an indelible mark on our school. As a student, he embodied the values of teamwork, discipline, and perseverance. Whether on the basketball court or within the school community, he inspired those around him through his commitment, humility, and sportsmanship. Though his journey was far too short, the memories he created will remain with us always."

On Saturday, around 11 am, Yashvendra's father waited for his son's body at the mortuary of the Safdarjung Hospital. With a swarm of media personnel outside, he refused to come out. "Yashvendra's elder brother also studies in the United States. His father is a decorated officer, who participated in Operation Vijay in 1999 and Operation Parakram in 2002. The family hails from Bulandshahr in Uttar Pradesh," said another family member.

A couple of Yashvendra's childhood friends, who had known him since Class 8, were also standing in a corner opposite the mortuary. "He told us that he had come, but we didn't get a chance to meet him. Last time we could speak before this was a year ago," one of them said.

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA), under whose jurisdiction the Nallah lies, in a statement, responded to the accident, saying, "It is clarified that a toe wall is already provided along the nallah. Further, a proposal for construction of an Reinforced Cement Concrete box drain at the location is already under process and is at an advanced stage. DDA had taken up the matter with the Traffic Police on March 23, seeking the requisite NOC for installation of speed breakers on Nangal Dewat Road to address accidents caused by over-speeding vehicles.

However, on July 21, the Traffic Police informed that the proposal for installation of speed breakers at the said location was not found feasible from the traffic management point of view." It also claimed that police told the authorities that the car was speeding.

TIMELINE OF THE PROTEST

Celebratory mood gripped the protest site. PRAVEEN KHANNA

MAY 15: During a courtroom hearing, CJI Surya Kant said that "parasites" are attacking the system. "There are youngsters like cockroaches, who don't get any employment and don't have any place in the profession. Some of them become media, some of them become social media, some of them become RTI activists, some of them become other activists, and they start attacking everyone." He, subsequently, issued a clarification saying he made the remarks only in the context of those who had gained entry into the legal profession using fake degrees and not all youth for whom he had great respect.

MAY 16: A day later, Abhijeet Dipke starts the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) as a satirical online platform.

JUNE 6: First gathering at Jantar Mantar after Dipke returns from the US. His comrades, supporters of CJP, students, and aspirants of competitive examinations gather, demand resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

JUNE 7-19: CJP organises periodic sit-ins, digital campaigns.

JUNE 20: CJP returns to Jantar Mantar for extended dharna.

JUNE 21: Dipke appeals to NEET aspirants to join the protest after finishing the re-examination.

JUNE 22-27: CJP continues sit-in. But protest is not yet a national issue.

JUNE 28: Sonam Wangchuk arrives at the protest site. He begins hunger strike, along with six students of the Left student organisation AISA.

JULY 1-17: Support builds up gradually. Activists, Opposition leaders, civil society personalities visit Jantar Mantar to express solidarity with the protesters.

JULY 18: Police swoop on protest site early morning, take away Wangchuk to hospital forcibly on Day 21 of his fast. Dipke announces he will continue Wangchuk's fast at Jantar Mantar.

JULY 19: By evening, thousands begin to gather at Jantar Mantar for a planned protest march to Parliament on the first day of the Monsoon Session on July 20.

JULY 20: Over 50,000 protesters take over the entire New Delhi police district. Police respond with lathicharge, tear gas, and allegedly pellet guns. More than 100 protesters and police personnel are injured. Protest continues.

JULY 21-25: Protesters occupy Jantar Mantar and streets around the site. Opposition leaders and several prominent personalities extend support.

JULY 21: Congress leaders led by Rahul Gandhi protest on the street outside Prime Minister's residence. Detained by police.

JULY 22-25: Delhi Metro shuts down over a dozen stations in the vicinity of the protest site.

JULY 23-24: Prime Minister Narendra Modi delivers late-night address to students, promises tough new law to deter paper leaks. Wangchuk breaks his fast in the presence of Union Ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh.

JULY 24: Nadda and Singh meet Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka of the CJP. CJP remains firm on its demand for Pradhan's resignation. Gives government 24 hours to decide. Late at night, Prime Minister delivers a second address on social media.

JULY 25: As crowds continue to increase at Jantar Mantar, police lathicharge and teargas protesters. In the afternoon, Pradhan resigns.

Protesters near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Saturday. GAJENDRA YADAV

'Made lifetime memories': Those injured during stir mark big win

Tabshir Shams, Mishal Mussaddique & Reva Thakkar
New Delhi, July 25

Violence erupted at the site on Saturday. PTI

Security officer fires tear gas shells near Jantar Mantar. PTI

IRSHAD SHAIKH, 25, was discharged from the Lady Hardinge Hospital in Delhi on Friday after suffering what he described as "multiple pellet injuries" during the 'Sansad Chalo' march on July 20. Even as he had to undergo several complicated procedures in the last few days, he "felt elated" on Saturday when the news of Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as Union Education Minister broke. "This was a fight for all of us, and all of us won," he told *The Indian Express*.

Even as they were still recovering, many people like Shaikh, who suffered injuries during the course of the protest at Jantar Mantar against NEET paper leak and other issues, celebrated Pradhan's exit and acceptance of the Cockroach Janta Party's other demands.

A national flag pinned to his backpack and a jhola swinging in his hand, Ajeet, 30, a teacher from West Delhi's Paschim Vihar, said he had been at the protest site ever since CJP founder kicked off the demonstrations on June 6. He was injured in eyes and legs during the protest but he had no afterthoughts about his participation — he was leaving with lifelong friends, he said. "As the saying goes — *Jhukti hai duniya, jhukane wala chahiye* (The world bends, it just needs someone to bend it).This had to happen. We have been called anti-national, accused of getting foreign funding. How will those who made these allegations justify the claims? If anything wrong happens to the students again, we shall gather here once more," he said with a wide smile.

Another youth, Ujjwal, who was also injured in the protest, walked beside him. "We came here separately... but we're leaving with lifelong friends," he said. "So many memories — songs we sang together, nights spent sleeping on the footpath in this heat and humidity, standing in long queues just to use a bathroom."

Vijay Rawat, 20, a B Ed student, suffered back injury during the July 20 protest march. He is yet to recover fully but his spirits were high on Saturday. He made way through the streets in the area near Jantar Mantar, congratulating everyone he met. "This is your victory," he said, shaking hands with another protester as they connected over their "protest injuries".

Suresh Yadav, a Gurgaon-based chef, was injured when security personnel resorted to use of tear gas on July 22. On Saturday, he sat in one of the makeshift tents, with his leg bandaged. , "It is a step in the correct direction," he said on Pradhan's resignation.

FACES OF THE PROTEST

SONAM WANGCHUK: The activist carried out a 26-day hunger fast, voicing CJP's demands. On July 18 — the 21st day of his hunger strike — he was forcibly removed from the Jantar Mantar by police and taken to Safdarjung Hospital. He broke his fast on July 24.

SAURAV DAS: A journalist by profession, Das serves as the chief CJP spokesperson. He made critical announcements and played the role of a negotiator with the government.

ASHUTOSH RANKA: As the national CJP spokesperson, the IIT Kanpur graduate met with Union Minister J P Nadda to submit a formal list of demands.

ABHIJEET DIPKE: A Boston University public relations graduate, Dipke founded the CJP in May in response to the CJI's "cockroach" remark. He mobilised youth across India to seek Pradhan's resignation.

PHOTOS: PTI, GAJENDRA YADAV

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COCKROACH JANTA PARTY CALLS OFF PROTEST

'Today, we won': Protesters pack up, head home after 36 days at Jantar Mantar

Drishti Jain, Abhimanyu Hazarika, Mishal Mussaddique & Reva Thakkar
New Delhi, July 25

FOR 36 days, Jantar Mantar was home to thousands of students, volunteers and protesters. On Friday, after Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned and the Centre accepted key demands of the CJP, many finally began packing up to head home.

For UPSC aspirant Vidya Bhushan Kumar (30), Pradhan's resignation made the weeks away from home worthwhile. He had been at the protest site since July 20, when the Sansad Chalo march of the protesters turned violent.

In Gaya, where he teaches schoolchildren and UPSC aspirants, Kumar had been preparing for what he says will be his final UPSC attempt in 2027. Since June 20, he had been sleeping under a tent near the stage at Jantar Mantar, making one trip a day to Gurdwara Bangla Sahib to use the washroom.

"I had appeared for UPSC Mains examination in 2017 and 2018 from Delhi, but had to return to Gaya due to financial constraints... Coming here, my goal was to make the government accountable. If a paper has leaked, the government should admit it and take responsibility... If you are mixing 20% ethanol in petrol, admit that."

"In Bihar, I was preparing for the examination for the post of AEDO (assistant education developmental officer) last month. My exam centre was Aurangabad... I spent my hard-earned money to travel there and while I was returning, I came to know that the question paper had leaked and that the exam had got cancelled," he added.

"I thought of going home many times," he said. "But what would I return to? A broken education system?"

Kumar said his friends back home had mocked him for staying put at Jantar Mantar. "Today they know why."

Near him sat Devashish Near (20), a NEET aspirant from Bareilly in UP. It was his first attempt this year, which got cancelled. After taking the re-test on June 21, he took a train to Delhi and has been at the protest site since then.

"In the first exam, I would have got around 560, but in the re-test, I only managed 410... My parents told me that if we don't raise our voice now, it will be buried deep down, and that's why I'm here."

"Today we won," he said, adding that he will now return home and begin preparing for another attempt at NEET.

Jantar Mantar also drew people who were not appearing for any competitive examinations. Ajitha K (76) travelled from Kozhikode three days ago. "I came to feel the excitement here," she said, adding that protesters have been stopping to thank her for staying put despite the massive crowd and the heat.

Gurgaon-based homemaker Malika has come with her 11-year-old son.

"I want to thank GenZ. It is a shame that it (resignation) took so long. I brought my son, a Gen Alpha, to support his elder brothers and sisters."

"This is not about any government or party, this is about accountability... people have to admit when they are wrong," she added.

Md Naved Khan, who has studied up to Class 12, cannot forget the July 20 police action. Injured during the clashes, he received four stitches before returning to help rebuild the stage at Jantar Mantar.

"The policeman who hit me wore a mask. Two hours after I was taken to the hospital, I returned here."

At the medical camp run by volunteers at the site, NEET aspirant Krishna Biswas (19) spent his days assisting doctors with dressing wounds and distributing medicines. He is now hopeful that reforms will follow in the education centre.

Among those celebrating was Sooraj Elamon (26), a PhD scholar at Jamia Millia Islamia and Delhi State president of the Students' Federation of India (SFI), who has been at the protest since Day 1. "This is a true reflection of what a student movement can lead to," he said.

As evening fell, the protest site slowly changed. Many volunteers were seen urging people to clear the venue. One of them was Maanvir (28) from Madhya Pradesh, who had been at Jantar Mantar since the protest started.

As he kept making announcements repeatedly on a loudspeaker, urging people to leave, streams of protesters walked out of the project site carrying backpacks, rolled-up bedding, placards and flags.

Metro services had restarted, roads had reopened and security personnel were leaving the area.

It was time to go home.

(Clockwise from above) Protesters celebrate after the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan; Janpath after the protest concluded and the crowd swells outside Janpath Metro station. TASHI TOBGYAL & GAJENDRA YADAV

Police personnel leave Jantar Mantar late Saturday. ABHINAV SAHA

HOPE FOR THE FUTURE

'These children are courageous': Parents rally behind students as demands met

Tabshir Shams & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 25

WHEN A 12-year-old girl from West Bengal insisted for days that she wanted to visit Jantar Mantar alone in Delhi to attend the protest being held by the CJP against NEET exam paper leak, among other issues, her parents had little choice but to succumb to her wishes, and come to the Capital. Keshav, her father, said he was worried about bringing her to the protest after violence unfolded during the 'Chalo Sansad' march on July 20.

On Saturday, as they stood amid a sea of humanity at Jantar Mantar, the girl's mother held her daughter's hand tightly as the crowd moved around them. Standing near the stage, even Keshav ensured he had not lost sight of her at any point. Speaking of the concerns related to the education system, he said, "There needs to be a solution. I have been wondering for quite some days what the solution is. I think the answer I have come to is, apart from the resignation of the Education Minister... systemic reforms."

Around noon, the protest site hummed with a mix of youthful energy and elderly wisdom. While the protest has been led largely by GenZ, roughly 1,000 people in the gathering were from an older generation — parents, professionals, retired personnel and families who had come from across the country to stand with the young protesters. Some stood beside their children and others stood in solidarity with a generation they said had found the courage to challenge the government. The site had taken on the character of a self-organised community.

Main stage being dismantled at the protest site. ABHINAV SAHA

Pradeep Tyagi (70) and his wife Anita Tyagi (66), who live in the Capital, could not believe when the news broke that Dharmendra Pradhan had resigned as the Union Education Minister — a key demand of the CJP protest. "Something we thought impossible had happened. So we rushed here... at Jantar Mantar. I was a Delhi University student, so I have gotten beaten with lathis many times during my days. Now it's our children's turn to fight for their children's future, and we are there to support them," said Anita. She added that her son is an engineer, who has been coming to the protest for many days.

Paramjeet, 46, who runs a car mechanic shop in Karol Bagh, came to Jantar Mantar with his wife, Parmeet, and their two daughters, aged 12 and 19. They walked in a queue — the mother with a phone in her hand recording everything, leading; the father a few steps behind; their daughters holding tightly to their mother's hands. They pause at every cluster of activity, taking it all in — people making posters, playing UNO board game, and raising slogans.

Paramjeet said, "It's high time people wake up."

A few metres away, two retired Air Force personnel from Ghaziabad stood among the students. "I came here for these students. They are like my children," said one of them. "If they can compel (Prime Minister Narendra) Modi to release a video at 12 in the night... *Inn bacchon mein dum toh hein*. (These children are courageous)."

For Neeta (45), a scientist from Gurgaon, the young protesters served as a stark reminder of "the failures of her own generation". She had been at the protest on June 20, when she said she was subjected to tear gas, and had returned on Saturday. "Our generation did nothing... This generation has a brain of its own," she said.

What struck her most, she said, was the "positive vibe" at the protest site. "From demonetisation to Ram Mandir chanda chori to inflation, every important issue is being raised here," she said.

Priyank, a surgeon in his 40s, said, "My daughter, a medical student in Rishikesh, was protesting there, while I am here."

He further added that the movement had broken what he saw as a "long-standing fear" of the government among the people. "This government has silenced people for quite a long time now. But the fear of the government is gone," he said.

A little further away, near the medical camp, Sushil, 73, who travelled from Bengaluru, said, "I feel proud of this generation. Democracy is still alive."

"Prioritising the national interest above all, Dharmendra Pradhan submitted his resignation. This decision reflects his unwavering commitment to ethical values, dignity, and principles in public life"

REKHA GUPTA, DELHI CM.

"Long live the power of youth... This is a major victory for democracy, congratulations to Gen Z, Dharmendra Pradhan ultimately had to resign, your struggles have paid off"

ARVIND KEJRIWAL, AAP CHIEF AND FORMER DELHI CM.

REMAINS OF THE DAY

Amid celebrations, volunteers at work, cleaning, silently

Drishti Jain & Swati Bhasin
New Delhi, July 25

AS BOLLYWOOD songs blared, supporters hugged each other, clicked selfies and danced to celebrate Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation on Saturday, hundreds of volunteers at Jantar Mantar quietly formed a human chain, slipped on gloves and began cleaning the protest site people had occupied for over a month.

Outside Gate 2 of the Jantar Mantar Metro station, which was opened after the protest was withdrawn by the CJP, a volunteer in a green reflective jacket called out to those celebrating – "We all know how to clean. Could you please step inside (the human chain)?"

Within minutes, the human chain stretched across the road, as volunteers swept the streets and put litter into black garbage bags even as a pungent smell lingered in the air.

Akansha (30) has left her two-year-old daughter at home to join the clean-up.

"My husband is supportive but I had to fight with my family to come here... I am not a GenZ, but a Millennial. But my daughter will be entering the education system now. I am here to support her," she said.

"My husband was asking, did I fight with the family to only come here and clean? I said 'we have created this, we need to clean up'," she added.

Nearby, corporate professional Hemant Chanda (24), originally from Hyderabad and now working in Delhi, has picked up a broom. "I feel very happy, though it's the first step... We need to do many more things... I can clean and that's what I am doing," he said.

A few metres away, Kushwant Arya (29), is also on a cleaning spree. A Gurgaon resident who has cleared the JEE and now works as a director for a US-based company, said, "This is my second weekend here... Feeling good... there is still hope that this country has the potential to change."

Volunteers clean the protest site before leaving on Saturday night. ABHINAV SAHA

Elsewhere, many others continued to volunteer before leaving the protest site.

Avatar Singh (44), who heads the India unit of the Five Rivers Foundation, said his organisation has been running a first aid camp since July 20, deploying nearly 20 doctors every day.

"We are happy with what has happened, but much more needs to be done. Students are the future and their voices need to be heard," he said.

His team, he added, stayed put at the protest site through the tense July 20 Sansad Chalo march, helping protesters and keeping unruly elements away.

Since it was the weekend, people like Soumya Khanna (38), who works at a corporate firm, could find time to come to the protest site. "I could not find time this week, as I have a full-time job... So, I came when I could, and began helping," Khanna said with a smile as she picked up trash. "This is how I can contribute."

Pranjul Upadhyay (22), who works in Noida, said he joined "for the sake of my brother's future" who is a student.

"Protests like this serve a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. I, too, have a full-time job... but tried to come as soon as I could," he said, as he held his garbage bag in one hand and looked at the people celebrating.

"If we don't help, who will?" said Ajit Kumar (23), who has been at the protest site with his brothers Nandkishor (24) and Karan Kumar (20) since July 19.

The brothers hail from Bihar's Bhagalpur. Nandkishor said he has been trying to get a government job for the last three years. "Our state has witnessed so many paper leaks. I have another exam on July 28. We will leave tonight... But this has been our home for a week...," he said.

To ensure that the humidity did not bring down the spirits, volunteers like Ashok Rathore (32) kept moving their hand-held fans as people moved past.

Hailing from Jaisalmer, Rathore said he has been eyeing a government job for the last five years. "You have to address the rot within the system. Changing ministers can't help alone... While heads roll, the consequences should be bigger...," he said.

"Otherwise, if a new king comes, the new king will also become corrupt...," he added.

"Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation is yet another blow to the arrogant Modi government, which was forced to bite the dust earlier when the three black farm laws were forced to be withdrawn. It's a huge victory for crores of youth in the country"

DEVENDER YADAV, DELHI PRADESH CONGRESS COMMITTEE CHIEF.

Police arrest six over Guwahati demonstration

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 25

At least six people have been arrested in connection with a demonstration held in Guwahati in solidarity with the protests at Jantar Mantar, while over two dozen people were detained while on their way to attend another protest on Saturday.

A protest, called by the Students' Federation of India (SFI), had been held at Guwahati's designated protest site in Chachal, attended by a few hundred protesters, and had taken place largely without incident.

On Friday, a few people were detained in connection with a case registered at Dispur police station under 10 sections of the BNS containing charges including "acts endangering sovereignty, unity and integrity of India", promoting enmity between different groups, criminal conspiracy, and assault or criminal force to deter a public servant from doing their job.

An official at the Dispur police station stated that six people had been arrested and placed in police remand over Friday and Saturday.

NEET PAPER LEAK PROTESTS

Clashes in Bihar: Tejashwi claims youth fired at, cops say used tear gas

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, July 25

BIHAR ERUPTED in protests for the third consecutive day Saturday over the alleged NEET paper leak and recent police action against student demonstrators, as a statewide bandh called by student organisations and Left parties turned violent across several districts, leaving police personnel injured, public property damaged and dozens detained.

The agitation, demanding accountability in the alleged examination scandal and the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, saw clashes between protesters and police in Patna, Siwan, Chhapra and other districts, while demonstrations elsewhere remained largely controlled and disciplined.

A confrontation was reported from Siwan, where a protest at Gandhi Maidan turned violent after demonstrators allegedly hurled stones and water bottles at police personnel.

Bihar Assembly Leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav alleged on X that police had opened fire on students, claiming even AK-47 rifles were used. *The Indian Express* has not independently verified this claim.

In his post, he said: "When a person accused of seven murders becomes the Chief Minister, this is how the police end up firing at innocent students who are protesting in a democracy. Action must be taken against the officials responsible".

Police, however, said officers had used tear gas and limited force to restore order.

Siwan Superintendent of Police (SP) Puran Kumar Jha said multiple groups had converged at Gandhi Maidan despite only one having permission to protest. "Only one group had permission to protest. The other groups later reached Gandhi Maidan where clashes broke out among themselves. Police had to fire six to seven rounds of tear gas and use mild force. FIRs will be registered and strict action will be taken against those responsible," he said. Several police personnel also reportedly suffered minor injuries.

Stones lie scattered on the road after clashes between police and protesters in Patna on Saturday. ANI

In Patna, clashes broke out around the Gandhi Maidan area as protesters allegedly pelted stones at police, overturned two police vans and damaged a traffic police booth and other vehicles. Police responded with tear gas and a baton charge to disperse the crowd.

SSP Kartikeya Sharma said police had used "limited force" and the situation had been brought under control. Police alleged some of those involved in the vandalism and provoking the crowd had come from outside the city. Patna Police had previously said 22 FIRs had been registered and around 60 people arrested in connection with the violence during previous days' protests.

On Saturday, Janshakti Janata Dal president Tej Pratap Yadav, who joined the protest carrying the Tricolour, was also detained and later released.

Kolkata rally violence: Govt invokes Goonda Act

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 25

WEST BENGAL Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari said the state had, for the first time, invoked its newly enacted anti-goonda law against those accused of orchestrating violence during Friday's NEET protest, warning they would face punishment "their next three generations will remember".

Making a statement in the Assembly on Saturday, Adhikari said around 70 people identified from the Dharmatala rally were "not students" and had no connection with the agitation over the alleged NEET paper leak.

According to police, Md Afroz, resident of Metiaburz has been arrested from Andal, and nine others have been detained so far.

Condemning the attacks on journalists during the protest, he said the West Bengal Public Safety and Control of Anti-social Activities Act, 2026, - popularly known as the Goonda Act, had been invoked to ensure exemplary punishment for those responsible.

"I censure the attack on our journalist friends on behalf of the entire House. An attack on journalists is unacceptable. We will take such action under the Goonda Act that these goons and even their next three generations will remember it. This is precisely why this law was enacted," the chief minister said.

Adhikari alleged that as the procession reached Esplanade, shoes and water bottles were hurled first at policemen and then at journalists covering the demonstration.

"They wanted the police to resort to lathicharge and tear gas. They wanted a spectacle. But Kolkata Police did not provide them that opportunity. The restraint shown by the force deserves appreciation," he said.

"They have nothing to do with the student movement. They are not students, nor are they members of the organisation that called the programme. They came only to create disorder," he alleged.

The CM, who visited injured journalists at SSKM Hospital on Friday, said the attack on the media was an issue that "had to be placed before the House".

Seven complaints have been registered in connection with the violence.

How Wangchuk mobilised a stir that took on a life of its own

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, July 25

ACTIVIST SONAM Wangchuk's decision to end his fast in the presence of Union Ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh may have come under the scanner, but those who have been a part of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) movement acknowledge that his role was crucial in mobilising those who generally sit on the fence when it comes to political issues.

On May 23, two weeks before Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke landed in New Delhi from the US, environmentalist and educationist Wangchuk extended support to the viral "cockroach" movement. Wangchuk described himself as an "honorary cockroach" and said the government should engage with the concerns of the youth rather than suppressing their digital expression.

At the time, Wangchuk was among the many in civil society who were extending their support to the online movement. No one knew that in two months the activist would play a crucial role in galvanising thousands of students to join the protest.

One of the crucial moments for the movement was on June 28 when Wangchuk and some AISA activists announced they will start an indefinite hunger strike at Delhi's Jantar Mantar.

"What Wangchuk Sir did for us was help us reach out to those who did not take the protest seriously. When such young people saw that a man as old as Wangchuk Sir had gone on a hunger strike for them, there was more support for the movement. But this support didn't translate into crowds in the first few days," said a CJP volunteer who was present at Jantar Mantar from Day 1 of the movement.

Sonam Wangchuk ended his fast early Friday morning

There were days when 50-100 people came to the protest site. "On many days, we did press briefings to ensure that the local media covered the protest because we didn't want it to end," said an AISA leader from Jawaharlal Nehru University.

AISA's role

Students of JNU, especially those belonging to AISA, kept the movement going on days when the crowd was lean. AISA is affiliated to the CPI(M-L), whose leader N Sai Balaji, a former JNUSU president, played an important role in mobilising students from JNU and other universities in Delhi.

The turning point

It was Wangchuk's removal from the protest site on July 18 that proved to be the turning point of the movement. As visuals of the activist being forcibly taken away by police went viral, the crowds at Jantar Mantar started swelling. It was also the weekend, so people found time and reached the protest site in groups.

The call by the CJP to march in protest saw massive crowds fill up the streets in and around Jantar Mantar. Even those who had never attended a protest started reaching the protest site.

The draw for the youth and the 'Gen Z' was that if a man close to 60 years can fast in protest for more than 20 days, those for whom he is fighting should also be in attendance.

Then came July 20, the day of the 'Sansad Chalo' march, when videos of students being teargassed and lathicharged by police started doing the rounds on social media. The protest at Jantar Mantar suddenly became a nationwide movement.

After Monday, the protest took on a life of its own. The overwhelming response from the youth convinced the CJP leaders that the protest will culminate in Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation.

After Monday's clashes, the protest became all about Gen Z versus the government and Pradhan. Even Wangchuk's letter to the protesters taking a softer line on Pradhan's resignation had no bearing on the movement. When he ended his fast early Friday (July 24), the protesters stayed put at Jantar Mantar. They had just one demand: "Pradhan must go."

While Wangchuk's fast galvanised a massive youth movement in Delhi and across the country, the protest against paper leaks became bigger than any leader, forcing the government to give in to the demands, including the exit of the Education Minister.

एफ.सी.आर.आई.
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Opp may end House siege, keep heat on Centre over education reforms

Manoj C G & Asad Rehman
New Delhi, July 25

WITH A beleaguered Dharmendra Pradhan resigning as the Union Education Minister, which was one of the central demands of the protesting students and youth as well as the Opposition parties, the signals emanating from a visibly elated INDIA bloc Saturday was that they would call off their siege of Parliament Monday, but will continue to raise issues related to reforms in the education sector and alleged police high-handedness against the protesters.

Pradhan's resignation has come as a shot in the arm for the Opposition, which was reeling under splits and floor-crossings at the beginning of the Monsoon Session. Within a week, the narrative, Opposition leaders say, has swung completely and the government has been pushed to the back foot. But the Opposition, particularly the Congress, is keen not to be seen as rushing forward to take credit for Pradhan's exit or the government's "capitulation". In fact, the Congress leadership, led by LoP in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, made it a point to give the credit for Pradhan's resignation to the students and youth without taking the name of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

The Opposition had been in disarray since April when they unitedly forced the defeat of the 131st Constitution Amendment Bill which was brought by the government to advance the roll-out of the women quota law and increase the LS seats. Since then, 37 LS and Rajya Sabha MPs from four non-NDA parties have defected to the ruling BJP-led coalition — making it the largest floor crossing from the Opposition to the Treasury benches in Parliament since the enactment of the anti-defection law in 1985.

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi with students in New Delhi on Saturday. ANIL SHARMA

With the government seemingly preparing to bring back the same constitutional amendment Bill, that test still awaits the Opposition. But as on Saturday, the mood in the Opposition camp appeared celebratory. Interestingly, the Congress leadership was preparing for a long-drawn fight believing that the government is unlikely to seek the resignation of Pradhan.

Asked whether the Opposition would take part in the discussion on an amended Bill that the government is set to bring in Parliament Monday, which provides for more stringent punishment for those involved in exam paper leaks, senior Congress leader K C Venugopal said, "Certainly, now that a key demand has been met... we (Opposition parties) will hold a positive discussion regarding the Bill aimed at establishing a flawless educational system. We will deliberate on it in the meeting and reach a decision."

Congress sources said the party leadership's assessment was that the students' protests were a reflection of the "underlying angst" among the youth over unemployment. "While the protest is over, the party will have to find ways to bring that simmering discontent onto the surface," a senior party leader said.

"This protest, the deeper reason it has happened, is that the Indian system, job creation system, education system, institutional system, media system have been destroyed. It has ceased to exist. There are consequences to this. We are now facing a time of serious economic crisis and in times of serious economic crisis, we need that system. So the government should be aware that what has happened here is just one step in a very deep problem," Gandhi said at a press conference.

"The government needs to start listening to what the people of India are saying. This is a warning to them from the students of India and warning from the Opposition. That you cannot run India the way you have been running. This is not your personal fiefdom. That is not something that belongs to you, this belongs to the people of India..." He said the student protesters had two more demands — action against police personnel who assaulted them and an "apology" from the PM.

And it was not just the Congress. Cutting across ideological lines, the Opposition parties celebrated Pradhan's resignation.

SP president Akhilesh Yadav said, "The lesson to be learnt from this movement is that no exam paper should ever be leaked. The young generation and the youth created such slogans and posters that emerged without any explicit support or allegiance to any political party — yet, every single youth connected with them... This is a major victory for the youth."

AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal called it a "big win for democracy". "Big congratulations to the youths and Gen Z, your efforts have led to Pradhan resigning from his post..."

DMK chief M K Stalin said: "The farmers of India did it first. The youth have done it today. Congratulations to the youth of India..."

5-10 yrs in jail, Rs 50L-10 cr fine: Anti-paper leak Bill set to be introduced in House next week

Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 25

THE UNION government is set to bring an amendment Bill in Parliament next week to increase the punishment for individuals involved in unfair means, including leaks of question papers of public exams, from imprisonment of three to five years to five to 10 years, while also increasing the fine from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 50 lakh, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The introduction of the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Act, 2026 by Minister of State for Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions Jitendra Singh was on Saturday included in the list of business of the Lok Sabha on July 27 (Monday), a day after the Union Cabinet approved it.

The Bill seeks to increase the punishment for organised crime of unfair means in public examinations from imprisonment of at least five years to at least seven years and the fine from at least Rs 1 crore to at least Rs 10 crore. The draft amendment Bill also provides for a "Special Task Force" to be set up to investigate the cases of unfair means under the Act, with a timeline of two months for the investigation. For

For trial of cases, the Bill provides for setting up of special fast-track courts

the trial of the cases, the Bill provides for the setting up of special fast-track courts.

"For the purposes of providing a speedy trial on a day-to-day basis, every state government and Union Territory administration shall, in consultation with the Chief Justice of the concerned High Court, by notification, designate a Court of Session to be a Special Fast Track Court to try offences under this Act," the Bill says.

It adds that the trial should be completed within three months of filing the charge-sheet. Cases pending in courts would be transferred to the fast-track courts upon commencement of the Act, it says.

The Bill was approved by the Cabinet hours after Prime Minister Narendra Modi made an announcement to the effect in response to the students' protest against the leak of the NEET-UG question paper in May.

In the statement of objects and reasons, Jitendra Singh wrote that the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 was enacted to prevent people from resorting to unfair means in public exams.

"The said Act, being a pan-Indian legislation, aims at effectively deterring persons, organised groups and institutions from indulging in unfair means thereby committing offences, adversely impacting the sanctity of public examinations..."

"In recent years, there have been some incidents of question paper leakages and malpractices in examinations conducted by public examination authorities, which tend to affect the transparency and fairness of the public examinations system. Hence, in order to further strengthen the fairness, to enhance the credibility of the public examinations system and to facilitate speedy trial and ensure time-bound investigations of offences under the said Act, it is necessary to make amendments in the said Act," he wrote.

The Act covers all examinations conducted by the Union Public Service Commission, the Staff Selection Commission, the Railway Recruitment Board, the Institute of Banking Personnel Selection and the National Testing Agency, which conducts the NEET exam.

3 protests, 3 retreats: What it says about Modi-led govt's limits

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 25

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN'S resignation under pressure from students and the youth marks more than a ministerial fall. It is the third time in 12 years that the Modi government has been forced to retreat following mass mobilisation. This is also the second time a minister in the government has stepped down under public pressure, if one includes M J Akbar's resignation in the wake of the #MeToo movement.

Each episode says something important about how this regime understands power, legitimacy and dissent. The pattern is striking: the government resists as long as it can, dismisses the moral force of protest for as long as possible, and moves only when the political cost of standing firm begins to outweigh the cost of surrender.

CAA-NRC

The first major instance came during the agitation against the CAA, when the government publicly began to soften on the proposed NRC project. Technically, it was never a formal rollback of a Cabinet decision as no nationwide NRC notification had been issued. But politically, the message was unmistakable. When the PM said the government had not decided on NRC, even though Union Home Minister Amit Shah had repeatedly spoken of a nationwide exercise and had used the infamous "chronology" phrase to signal the government's intent, it amounted to a retreat. The project was effectively put in cold storage.

Farmer protests

The second moment came with the farmers' protests, where the government held out for nearly a year before finally conceding defeat and repealing the three farm laws. Here too, the pattern was similar, but the scale was larger. When Modi eventually announced the withdrawal of the laws and apologised to farmers after a year, it was a rare admission that the state had been compelled to step back not by persuasion but by pressure.

Paper leak protests

This protest has become the third such moment. What is different this time is not just the issue, but the social composition of the movement and its mode of mobilisation. The protests were not led by a fixed ideological organisation or by one recognisable command structure. They were organic, decentralised, and deliberately leader-light.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

'Resignation a united victory of students, Rahul Gandhi & Opp'

AS UNION Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned Saturday after weeks of protests by students and youths as well as Opposition parties over the exam paper leaks, All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary (organisation) and Lok Sabha MP **K C Venugopal**, speaks with **Manoj C G** on Pradhan's resignation and the Opposition's next course of action, among other issues. Excerpts:

EXPRESS interview

K C VENUGOPAL
LOK SABHA MP & AICC GENERAL SECRETARY (ORGANISATION)

Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation was one of the main demands of the protesting students and the Opposition. What is next for the Opposition?

His resignation is a capitulation of the Narendra Modi government before the unwavering fighting spirit of India's youth and students. Modi had to back down and bend his knees. It is also a resounding victory for the united struggle led by Rahul Gandhi and the Opposition, standing in solidarity with the country's youth and students.

This was not about politics, caste, religion, or region. The people of India — students, parents, and the entire nation — embraced this cause, transforming it into a collective struggle. The students stepped forward, setting aside all other considerations, because they saw how an arrogant, defiant and corrupt government was destroying the future of the youth and how that government was acting so irresponsibly in the face of protests.

Until last night, Dharmendra Pradhan remained defiant. At one point, there was a thought of perhaps offering a change of portfolio, but our stance remained firm from start to end. We insisted on his resignation as he was responsible for the situation as well as an investigation into the police officers who mercilessly beat students, withdrawal of cases against the protesting students and announcement of compensation for those students who lost their lives. This is also a victory of the five-day-long struggle waged in Parliament.

Congress had put forward 3 demands: Pradhan's resignation, action against policemen, and an apology from PM Narendra Modi. While the main demand has been accepted, 2 remain. Will you allow House to function Monday?

We have called a meeting of all Opposition parties on Monday morning. A decision will be taken collectively at that meeting. It is not going to be a decision of the Congress alone.

So who gets credit for forcing the resignation — the CJP or the Opposition?

We do not intend to claim any credit whatsoever. I view this as a victory for the people, their triumph against a government's arrogance and defiance, and against a corrupt, state-sponsored tyranny. It is a victory for the students and the youth. We simply stood behind them.

But Rahul Gandhi has been waging a relentless battle for students raising this issue, not just recently, but continuously over the past several months, culminating in protests held outside the Prime Minister's residence and at the Mahatma Gandhi memorial in Delhi. The five-day struggle we waged inside Parliament, the protests we held outside, and Rahul Gandhi's actions taken just yesterday and today... expose their deceitful tactics. Those who want to evaluate all that will evaluate... we don't need to claim credit for it. The students themselves are the ones evaluating the situation. That is precisely why the injured students went to meet Rahul Gandhi.

The rise, fall of Pradhan: BJP's trusted organiser undone by NEET leak

Sujit Bisoyi & Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 25

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN (57), who resigned amid pressure over NEET paper leak on Saturday, had, over the past few years, emerged as one of the BJP's most durable central leaders: an organiser first, a minister second, and a political manager who has remained close to the party's top decision-makers.

He is also among the few Odias who have made a mark in national politics and wield influence across India. Born on June 26, 1969 into a political family, Pradhan was deeply involved in the RSS's socio-cultural activities since childhood. His father Debendra Pradhan, a doctor, was a prominent BJP leader in Odisha, who became the Union minister in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government.

Starting as an ABVP activist when he was a higher secondary student in Talcher College in his home town, he became president of the college's student union in 1985, state secretary of the ABVP in 1993 and its national secretary in 1995. Pradhan, who pursued his master's degree in anthropology from Utkal University in Bhubaneswar, Odisha's premier institution for higher education, contested the student union election in 1990 but lost to Arun Sahoo, currently a senior Biju Janata Dal (BJD) leader.

Following his father's footsteps, he joined the BJP in 1998 and became an MLA for the first

Dharmendra Pradhan is among the few Odias who made a mark in national politics and wield influence across India. FILE

time in 2000 from the Pallahara seat in the BJD-BJP coalition government. As an MLA, he was conferred with the Utkalmani Gopabandhu Pratibha Sanman, the best legislator award of the Odisha Assembly.

Pradhan was given the education portfolio in 2021, which he continued to hold in the NDA government's third term. After a 15-year gap, Pradhan returned to direct electoral politics in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, winning from the Sambalpur seat with a massive mandate. During his stint in education, his role expanded from administrator to political combatant. The biggest setback his tenure saw was the repeated blow to public confidence in national exams, with the ministry facing scrutiny over paper leak allegations, cancellation and reworking of tests, and opposition criticism.

BJP leaders hail Pradhan for contributions as minister

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 25

THE BJP threw its weight firmly behind Dharmendra Pradhan minutes after he announced his resignation on Saturday. From BJP president Nitin Nabin to his Cabinet and party colleagues, Pradhan's tumultuous tenure was hailed as a significant one across party ranks.

"...Prioritising larger interests, his decision to step down reflects the highest standards of integrity and selfless service in public life. The party stands firmly with Shri Dharmendra Pradhan Ji in this decision. I extend my best wishes for his future endeavours," Nabin said in a post on X. "For BJP workers, the country, our youth, and students are far more important than any position. Today, the resignation of Union Education Minister... exemplifies this very principle", Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on X in Hindi. "His efforts toward making the examination system more inclusive and student-centric have been noteworthy..."

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said: "This resignation is a testimony of the fact that for Prime Minister Shri @narendramodi and our government, safeguarding the future of our students and youth is of paramount importance." MoS Department of Personnel and Training and PMO Dr Jitendra Singh acknowledged Pradhan's "deep and enduring connect with students and public life".

1.25 billion reasons why '*Hum honge kaamyab*' @Jantar Mantar

FIRST PERSON

Shalini Langer
New Delhi, July 25

NUMBER IN a roll call, rank on a marksheet, biometric in a database, fine print in a 'Special Intensive Revision'. The system is designed to make you feel like a cockroach, scurrying around, fighting, surviving, one in 1.25 billion.

Till you are one in 1.25 billion.

Saturday I became that – part of a mass thought to be as inconsequential as dust, as unnoticed as air that, to paraphrase Maya Angelou, rose; that, to paraphrase Faiz Ahmad Faiz, sent a throne up in the air like cotton.

When you live in Delhi, Jantar Mantar becomes a place you often hear about, most commonly in news reports, or notice while driving past, but seldom visit. Vaguely you know that it is an observatory, tracing the movement of the Sun, Moon and planets. A generation that has the universe in the palm of its hands has even less time for it.

This past week changed that, as all roads in Delhi and from beyond led to Jantar Mantar, to mark presence at a protest that was launched by the Cockroach Janta Party but soon became, as one participant told me Saturday, "what you wanted it to be". A protest for a fairer system, for a better life, for a responsive government, for the right not to play nice, for the chance to be good.

And to do it together, across caste, class, religion and gender — all the ways they told you it could not be done.

So I drop in too, after days of planning, a lot sceptical and not-a-little sheepish about my "protest tourism". Hitching an auto-rickshaw to the Jantar Mantar road, past the teeming masses in Connaught Place heading the same way, it is hard not to feel there is something in the air.

I reach, and am overwhelmed: Who are these people clambering atop trees and barricades, raising slogans, holding up posters, making reels, and above all just laughing? Who are these girls holding their own – and alone – and standing out, not reflexively shrinking? Who are these youngsters not afraid to sweat out on the streets, or take on a few lathis? Where are those screens we thought they could not take their eyes away from? And who are these people just keen to help, with water, fans, food, even as sentiments swell and threaten to sweep away everything this protest has built?

A wave does come, and another, as next to the stage, a commotion seems to start from the other end of the lane. Scared people scamper, the word stampede crossing our collective

Protesters celebrate Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

minds. My panicked thoughts go to my daughter, with friends, on the other side of the protest. Then, suddenly, my husband and I are swamped by gas that fills our eyes, our nostrils, our throats, sucking the air around us, doubling us over.

This is it, I think. All the things that one should do when hit by tear gas slip away.

Again come those helping hands, quickly ushering us and others into an alley, holding out water bottles to wash eyes and faces, telling us not to rub them. Seconds later, come other offers. Across a gate, volunteers hand out more bottles of water, along with masks to wear and to pass along.

Another round of tear gas goes off just then, and the gates open to let in those of us huddling around it. We are told to move quietly and swiftly; it is a church building. "You should not hang outside on the grounds... it's too dangerous." We stumble into the dark, collapse into pews, shifting to accommodate as more of us come in.

The sounds of the chaos outside drift in every time the doors open. The walls reverberate as another round of tear gas is fired. One, two, three...10, it is hard to understand what is happening. My husband and I look at one another, and the same thought is on our minds — this is too much like a bad story, where people hiding out in a building are easy targets for any group with violence on its mind.

We dial our phones furiously. We shout at our daughter to head home. "No, just because that side is calm does not mean it will stay that way. Leave, just go." We next call up the son headed to the protest site, his third visit, this time to volunteer with the cleaning squad. "Scaring us is just what they want," he argues. "No, just turn around, come another day," I plead.

The volunteers, most of them the same age as the young protesters outside, tell us not to panic. To wait it out. "We have more water, snacks if you need." A doctor steps up in case someone wants medical attention, four nurses are called from a building nearby, a youth who comes in breathless has his blood pressure taken.

Wait a few more minutes, just 30, just 20, just 10, the volunteers keep saying. Looking on, dazed still at having come closer to the might of the government than we ever have, gathered from across the country – Muzaffarnagar to Jamia Nagar — we are not going anywhere.

Then comes out a keyboard. "Who wants to sing?" asks a volunteer. One girl steps forward, then two. They start with "Hum honge kaamyab (We shall overcome)", and all join in, clapping. They build up to "Teri he zameen (Hey God, you are all there is)", and the line "khuda mere tu bakhsheesh kar" gets the loudest chorus in this House of Jesus.

One whisper suddenly breaks through the sound: "Has the resignation come?" A query if anyone from the media is around stops with me. I place a call, the person doesn't know. Then I get a reply from another: yes, it has happened. As I turn around to deliver the news, there is a cry of joy, spontaneous slogans of "Inquilab Zindabad!" The volunteers urge us to maintain the sanctity of the place, and no one questions it.

The walls are again reverberating, this time with cheers and music. As we stream out finally, from the back door, into a day that is suddenly sunny, we hear what they are saying: "Kranti aa gayi (The revolution is here)!"

Elections are won with votes, respect earned through public service: V-P

Vice President and Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 25

HIGHLIGHTING THE role of public service, Vice President C P Radhakrishnan on Saturday told a group of new Rajya Sabha MPs that while elections are won with votes, respect is earned through public service.

Inaugurating a two-day orientation programme for the newly-elected MPs, the Rajya Sabha Chairman underscored the need for commitment to the people and the Constitution.

"Debates, discussions or even disruptions, it must always lead to a decision," he said.

"C P Radhakrishnan noted that while elections are won by votes, respect is earned through public service. He urged members to remember that every question asked, every law enacted, every policy framed, and every debate participated in has the potential to transform lives," as per a statement. Deputy Chairman Harivansh said they had the "right to hold government accountable, offer constructive criticism, guide the government onto the right path..." it said.

EXPRESS exclusive

As Delhi protest resonates, can Kishor upstage BJP in Bankipur?

Santosh Singh & Yuvraj Singh
Patna, July 25

"Among a hundred drunken elephants, we need a camel." That is how a general store owner near Kadam Kuan sums up the mood ahead of the July 30 Assembly bypoll in Patna's Bankipur. Requesting anonymity, he says his family has voted for BJP for years but plans to back Jan Suraaj Party founder Prashant Kishor this time.

"We are traditional BJP voters, but this time we have a much better choice in Kishor," he says.

The shopkeeper points to the student protests in Delhi, saying their impact has resonated in Patna as well. His son, a coaching student, was caught near Dak Bungalow Chowk when students gathered in large numbers to protest alleged systemic failures in education, an issue highlighted by activist Sonam Wangchuk and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

Bringing to an end the more than month-long student protest in the heart of Delhi that had captivated public attention and heated up politics, Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned Saturday.

"This (the Delhi protests) shows BJP is failing to address issues related to the youth and students," he says, adding that the party's decision to field first-time candidate Neeraj Kumar Sinha has disappointed many voters.

The Bankipur bypoll was necessitated after five-time MLA Nitin Nabin was elected to Rajya Sabha after his elevation as BJP president. RJD has fielded Rekha Gupta, runners-up in the previous two Assembly polls.

RAHUL SHARMA

JSP founder Prashant Kishor appeared to move beyond caste arithmetic and framed the bypoll as a referendum on BJP leadership.

Not everyone, however, appears ready to abandon the BJP.

Among upper-caste Kayastha voters, who have traditionally backed the party, there is considerable support, though some acknowledge unease over changing political equations.

Sujit Sinha, a retired teacher, recalls watching former Kumhrar MLA Arun Sinha campaign for Neeraj Sinha near Patna Junction. "A voter asked him whether BJP couldn't find a better candidate," he says, referring to Neeraj Sinha and the party's previous pick Abhishek Kumar Sinha withdrawing from the race citing "family reasons".

BJP has fielded Kayastha candidates in Bankipur for three decades: Naveen Kishore Sinha between 1995 and 2005, followed by Nitin Nabin from 2005 until this year. Kayasthas account for around 14% of electorate, alongside an almost equal share of OBC Banias, with Yadavs, Rajputs, Brahmins, Dalits and Muslims making up the rest.

Kishor, however, appears intent on moving the campaign beyond caste arithmetic.

At a rally in Daldali-Seelampur Hazra locality Wednesday, he framed the election as a referendum on BJP leadership. "If you want to register your protest against PM Narendra Modi, this is your best chance. If you want to remove Samrat Choudhary as CM, this is your best chance. And if you want to respond to BJP's arrogance of believing it can win regardless of whom it fields, this is your chance," he says.

Kishor has also sought to counter BJP's religious messaging with his own softer symbolism. "Our flag is yellow, the colour associated with Lord Vishnu. It is not saffron. It is the colour of turmeric, used during sacred rituals," he says.

After the rally, he walks for over a kilometre through lanes, waving at residents watching from balconies.

Among those following the procession is cattle rearer Arvind Mahto. "I used to vote for RJD, but PK is our clear choice now," he says. Sunil Kumar Singh, who works for a private firm in Delhi but whose family lives in Bankipur, echoes the sentiment. "My family has always voted for BJP, but this time we are voting for Kishor. The only question is whether he can cross the finish line."

Elsewhere in the constituency, Neeraj Sinha is relying on the party's organisational strength. Campaigning through S P Verma Road, Exhibition Road, Rajapur, Bakarganj and Kadam Kuan — several localities covered by Kishor earlier in the day — he repeatedly reminds voters of his grassroots credentials. "BJP has given a ticket to a simple booth worker like me. You have always supported us, and I seek your blessings once again," he tells small gatherings.

BJP has deployed several senior leaders, including Patna Sahib MP Ravi Shankar Prasad and Danapur MLA Ram Kripal Yadav, besides 20 senior functionaries, to reinforce its campaign. Party leaders dismiss the "PK factor", insisting the only question is BJP's victory margin.

RJD's Rekha Gupta is attracting far less attention than the Opposition had hoped.

Campaigning largely away from the media spotlight, Gupta is appealing to voters to give her a chance. Belonging to the OBC Bania community, she is banking on support from sections of Banias, Yadavs and Muslims.

Yet even among these groups, there are signs that traditional voting patterns may not hold. A Yadav voter in Mandiri says, "Enough of caste. We see Kishor as a better choice than both the BJP and RJD."

However, a section of voters remain unconvinced by Kishor's first electoral test. Rajesh Sinha, a CA from Boring Road, says, "Kishor is undoubtedly intelligent, but strategy and governance are different things. Nabin built trust here over many years, and his endorsement of Neeraj Sinha carries weight."

Near Gandhi Maidan, food stall owner Amit Kumar offers a similar assessment. "Everyone is talking about Kishor because this is his first election. There is curiosity, but curiosity does not always translate into votes. I think Neeraj Sinha may benefit from the fact that BJP is in power at the Centre."

However, among younger voters, the verdict remains open.

Shruti Kumari, a law student on Boring Canal Road, says, "People my age know Kishor through social media and interviews. He seems thoughtful, but we will vote for whoever we think can actually solve our issues."

Aryan Singh, 22-year-old student, says, "PK is more visible, especially online. But BJP has a strong organisation on ground. I will decide only in the last few days of campaigning."

Ramadoss quits politics, ends era that reshaped TN reservation debate

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, July 25

PMK founder Dr S Ramadoss

EVERY POLITICAL movement eventually confronts the same question: what remains after the founder decides to stop speaking? On Saturday, as he turned 88, PMK founder Dr S Ramadoss attempted to answer that question with unusual simplicity.

"I am retiring from politics," he told party workers gathered at Saraswathi College near Tindivanam. "From today, I will not speak about politics or interfere in political matters. Anbumani will take care of politics. His wife will also support him. Those who come to meet me should not discuss politics with me."

The declaration formally transfers the political movement he built over four decades to his son, PMK president Dr Anbumani Ramadoss. Citing recurring vertigo, Ramadoss asked visitors to enquire only about his health — not politics.

Ramadoss leaves behind far more than a political party. He leaves behind one of the most consequential — and contested — social movements modern Tamil Nadu has produced.

Long before he became a politician, Ramadoss was a village doctor in Villupuram whose inexpensive medical practice earned him local recognition. In 1980, he founded the Vanniyar Sangam, seeking greater educational and employment opportunities for one of Tamil Nadu's largest and most politically consolidated Most Backward Class (MBC) communities.

That movement would fundamentally reshape Tamil Nadu's reservation politics.

Through the 1980s, the Vanniyar agitation demanded separate reservation in education and government employment. It also developed an unmistakable style of protest. Roads across northern TN were blocked not with barricades but with freshly cut government-owned roadside trees. Villages stopped highways at their own boundaries. A week-long blockade in September 1987 paralysed large parts of northern TN.

After DMK returned to power in 1989, the existing Backward Class category was divided into Backward Classes and Most Backward Classes. Vanniyars were placed within the newly created MBC category, securing a separate 20% reservation. From that social movement emerged PMK in 1989.

PMK once emerged as an indispensable alliance partner capable of influencing governments across ideological divides. It won 20 seats in 2001 and remained an important force in coalition politics for years.

The party suffered setbacks in the 2009, 2011, 2014 and 2016 elections, lost all seats in 2016, returned with five MLAs in 2021 only through alliance with AIADMK, and today commands roughly 4% vote share. LS elections reflected a similar decline: no MPs in 2009, one in 2014 and none thereafter.

Yet numbers alone cannot explain Ramadoss' political legacy. His career was built upon social justice rhetoric while remaining inseparable from history of caste violence that came to define PMK in the public imagination.

The 2012 Dharmapuri riots after an inter-caste marriage remain among TN's darkest caste conflicts. Critics long accused PMK of encouraging caste mobilisation under the language of community rights. His supporters remember the architect of reservation. His critics remember politics of exclusion.

Punjab AAP hits reset in seats before polls, sparks ticket struggle

Raakhi Jagga
Ludhiana, July 25

SEVEN MONTHS ahead of 2027 Punjab Assembly elections, the ruling AAP appears to be recalibrating its organisational structure by appointing new constituency in-charges or promoting alternative leaders alongside its sitting MLAs.

While AAP has made no official announcement linking these changes to ticket distribution, the emergence of such parallel power centres has triggered speculations in several constituencies.

The latest example is Bathinda Rural, where retired SDM Gopal Singh was appointed as AAP's constituency in-charge earlier this month. The seat is represented by AAP MLA Amit Rattan Kotfatta, arrested in an alleged bribery case in February 2023 and granted bail in May in a case for which the trial is still underway.

Kotfatta said, "This is the fourth constituency in-charge appointed by the party in the past three years. It is the party's decision."

In Bathinda Urban, represented by AAP MLA Jagrup Singh Gill, another prominent party face, Amarjeet Mehta, president of the PCA, has increasingly become visible. Gill had openly criticised his party over ticket distribution in recent local body elections, alleging the party had favoured Mehta, whose son Padamjeet became the Bathinda mayor.

In Sangrur, represented by AAP MLA Narinder Kaur Bharaj, AAP leader Gurmail Singh Gharachon has emerged as an influential face. Gharachon had lost Sangrur LS bypoll in June 2022.

In Samana, represented by party MLA Chetan Singh Jauramajra, former state minister and senior leader of Shiromani Akali Dal (Punar Surjit) Surjit Singh Rakhra joined AAP in May. Since then, AAP workers say two parallel centres have emerged, with both Jauramajra and Rakhra holding separate public programmes.

In Patiala Rural, represented by state health minister Balbir Singh, Patiala Deputy Mayor Jagdeep Jagga has put up posters across the city asking voters to elect him from the seat in 2027.

An AAP insider cautioned against reading too much into these appointments at this stage. "There can be many other instances where either ticket aspirants are trying their luck or it is an indication from the party it may change the candidate. A final decision is far away. It's too premature to decide which candidates will get tickets."

TEDx to LinkedIn, gurukuls to social media: Meet temple trust's new 'guidance' panel

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, July 25

(From left) Swami Govind Dev Giri; Mahant Dinendra Das; Parmanand Giri; Swami Vasudevanand Saraswati; Vishwaprasanna Tirtha Maharaj and Acharya Mithlesh Nandani Sharan

AMID THE ongoing donation controversy, the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has turned to old and trusted names for the nine-member 'Dharmik Committee' set up to "guide" religious and spiritual activities at the Ram temple.

The nine represent both the traditional and contemporary — from a saint who delivers TEDx talks and maintains a LinkedIn presence, to representatives of prominent ashrams and mutts in Ayodhya, to Vedic scholars, a yoga master and successors to leaders of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, as well as those who have been associated with the trust since its inception.

Of the nine members announced by the trust at its July 22 meeting, five are already trustees, trust treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri is the panel president, and one of the members is his close aide.

The trust hopes the move will help reinforce public confidence, particularly among Ayodhya's saints and residents, that rituals and spiritual traditions remain central to the temple's functioning, even as it handles the donation row.

Originally from Beed in Maharashtra, Govind Dev Giri, 77, has been the treasurer of the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust since its inception in 2020, and is also the vice president of the Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi Trust, Mathura. A disciple of Pandurang Shastri Athavale, he is known to be a Vedic scholar and founded the Maharishi Vedavyas Pratishthan in the early 1990s, which now runs a network of Vedic schools and gurukuls across the country, including in Manipur.

The five seers in the panel from Ayodhya include Kamal Nayan Das of the Maniram Das Chhawani Ashram, which had played a significant role during the Ram temple movement. It was at this chhawani that the July 22 meeting was held.

The head of the chhawani, Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, is president of the trust. Given the advanced age of Nritya Gopal and failing health, Kamal Nayan, seen as his successor, often represents him at meetings and manages the chhawani.

Another panel member is Ayodhya-based seer Dinendra Das of Nirmohi Akhara, one of the litigants in the Ram Janmabhoomi title dispute before the Supreme Court. Dinendra is a member of the Ram temple trust, and has consistently maintained — and ensured — that rituals at the shrine follow the Ramanandi Vaishnav tradition.

His appointment strengthens Dinendra's hand at a time when there are reports of a divide within the akhara, with some members seeking to replace him.

A third seer from Ayodhya is Acharya Mithlesh Nandani Sharan, the Mahant of Hanumant Niwas Mandir. A Sanskrit scholar and an alumnus of Sampurnanand Sanskrit Vishwavidyalaya, Varanasi, Acharya Mithilesh is known for his public discourses, including on TEDx Youth, and his knowledge of Sanatan Dharma, Vedic literature, and Indian philosophy.

His disciples talk about Acharya Mithilesh's focus on youth, which is why he often addresses Youth Parliament as well as appears on religious and cultural forums across the country and on social media platforms. Acharya Mithilesh also played a key role in training young priests when the Ram temple was inaugurated, and is believed to have been one of the seers whose opinion was taken in selection of the Ram idol.

The other two Ayodhya-based seers belong to ashrams who follow the Ramanandi sect i.e. are worshipers of Ram as the avatar of Lord Vishnu and Sita and Hanuman. While Swami Ramanand Das is the Mahant of Ram Katha Kunj Ashram, Swami Rajkumar Das belongs to Ram Vallabh Kunj, and both are popular kathavachaks or narrators of the Ramayana.

The three seers from outside Ayodhya, like Govind Giri, are not new to Ram temple functioning either, and have been founder members of the trust. While Swami Vasudevanand Saraswati belongs to Jyotirmath in Uttrakhand; Swami Vishwa Prasanna Tirtha is from Pejawar Mutt in Udupi, and a scholar of the Vedas; and Swami Parmanand Maharaj belongs to the Mawai Dham near Rae Bareli.

Lucknow: 'Unsanctioned' portions of building where blaze killed 15 demolished

Express News Service
Lucknow, July 25

OVER A month after a fire on June 22 tore through a two-storey building in Lucknow, killing 15 people, the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA) on Saturday began demolishing portions of the structure built in alleged violation of the approved building plan.

The action on the building, located in the city's Aliganj neighbourhood, came after a 15-day deadline issued to the owner to remove the unauthorised construction expired without compliance.

On Saturday morning, LDA officials, accompanied by district administration personnel and police, launched an operation to raze the sections identified as being built in violation of the sanctioned plan.

"The owner had begun demolishing the building himself after being served a notice. He was given 15 days to complete the work, but the deadline expired today, so the LDA has stepped in to carry out the demolition," said Dhruv Kumar, SHO of Aliganj Police Station.

Preliminary findings indicate the building had been sanctioned for residential use but was allegedly being used for commercial activities, officials said.

Kumar said heavy earthmoving equipment had been deployed for the operation. As a precaution, authorities closed the adjoining road to traffic and suspended electricity supply in the area to ensure the demolition could be carried out safely.

According to police, records obtained from the LDA show that the land on which the building stands is jointly owned by Virendra Prasad Shukla and his brother, Surendra Shukla.

Four people have so far been arrested in the case.

● BJP HAS DEPLOYED SAINI TO PROJECT HARYANA AS PROOF THAT A 'DOUBLE-ENGINE' GOVERNMENT CAN REVIVE PUNJAB'S FORTUNES

Why Nayab Saini is BJP's biggest asset in Punjab Assembly election campaign

NORTHERN LIGHTS

BY MANRAJ GREWAL SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON THE POLITICS AND IDEAS SHAPING NORTH INDIA

AS PUNJAB begins its long march to the Assembly elections, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini is becoming an increasingly familiar face across the state.

Sporting a saffron turban during his visits, he has emerged as one of the BJP's most visible campaigners in Punjab. Whether making unscheduled stopovers, as he did at a college to mark Shaheed Udham Singh's anniversary, or addressing gatherings big and small, Saini's message is remarkably consistent: Punjab and Haryana share a common history, and Punjab, too, can benefit from a BJP government.

Political observers point to Saini's caste. The Saini community, a farming and landowning Other Backward Class (OBC) group, has a significant presence in parts of Punjab, particularly in the Doaba and Puadh regions. And while Saini makes it a point to thank Prime Minister Narendra Modi for his historic decision to set up the National Commission for Backward Classes, caste arithmetic alone does not explain why the BJP has invested so heavily in projecting him.

Compelling narrative

The more compelling reason is that Saini embodies the BJP's larger political message. He is the CM of a neighbouring state where the party has transformed itself from a marginal player into the dominant political force. From winning just four seats in the 90-member Haryana Assembly in 2009, the BJP returned to power for a record third consecutive term in 2024 with a vote share of around 40%. Haryana is the party's most compelling "double-engine government" success story in North India. Saini showcases not merely a leader but a model.

That message carries greater weight because of who Saini is. An earthy politician from a farming family, he speaks Puadhi, the Punjabi dialect spoken around Chandigarh, Ambala and adjoining parts of Punjab, allowing him to connect effortlessly with the Punjab electorate. His easy manner and rustic humour only add to his appeal, especially among the youth.

During one of his visits to Punjab, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini is seen wearing a saffron turban.

A reversal in fortunes

In many ways, Saini also represents a striking reversal in the fortunes of Punjab and Haryana.

For decades after the reorganisation of Punjab in 1966, Haryana was dubbed the poorer cousin of Punjab. The Green Revolution first took root in Punjab. It was Punjab Agricultural University, Ludhiana, that hosted Norman Borlaug, who developed the high-yielding wheat varieties. Meanwhile, Dr M S Swaminathan converted Rakhra village in Patiala into a vast seed farm that propelled the Green Revolution in the state. Punjab emerged as the food basket of India, leaving Haryana far behind for almost three decades.

Then history took an unexpected turn. Punjab was wracked by militancy between the late 1970s and early 1990s, which stalled its shift towards industry. Meanwhile, Haryana capitalised on its proximity to the national capital. Gurgaon became one of the fastest-growing urban centres in the country, attracting multinational companies, financial services, and manufacturing. Industrial hubs such as Manesar and Faridabad reinforced that growth, transforming Haryana's economy from predominantly agrarian to one driven increasingly by industry and services.

As per the latest reports of the NITI Aayog and the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM), Haryana's per capita income is roughly ₹3,95,618, over 52 per cent higher than Punjab's per capita income of approximately ₹2,79,398.

Haryana aggressively pursued administrative reforms, digitised governance, invested in rural infrastructure and promoted diversification by giving MSP on 24 crops. Two-time CM Manohar Lal Khattar frequently claimed that Haryana had the country's most robust direct benefit transfer system. Even today, the BJP continues to experiment organisationally. This week, it introduced weekly "tiffin meetings", where party workers and leaders gather over home-cooked meals to strengthen grassroots engagement.

Saini is not simply campaigning in Punjab; he is presenting Haryana as evidence that sustained BJP rule can transform a state.

The symbolism extends beyond politics. Saini enjoys cordial relations with influential religious organisations in Punjab, including the Radha Soami Satsang Beas, a dera that enjoys one of the largest followings in the region, and Divya Jyoti Jagrati Sansthan. At his official residence, Kabir Kutir, visitors are greeted by a photograph of the Golden Temple in the dining room. Asked about it, Saini explains: "My mother Kulwant Kaur is from Punjab. We have always revered the Gurus."

When the BJP sends Saini to Punjab, it is attempting to sell the idea that the state which once looked up to Punjab has, over the past three decades, forged a different developmental trajectory, and that Punjab can follow a similar path under BJP rule.

Whether Punjab's voters accept that proposition remains to be seen. But for the BJP, Haryana seems to have become the strongest argument it can make in Punjab.

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SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

HEAD CONSTABLE MALKEET RAM
60 BN BSF
01.11.1954 – 26.07.2003

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Malkeet Ram on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counterpart firing in Jammu area and later succumbed to his injuries.

CONSTABLE RAJESH KUMAR SAHOO
12 BN BSF
03.02.1976 – 26.07.2003

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Rajesh Kumar Sahoo on his Balidan Diwas. On 24th July 2003, he sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting militants in area of Thuru, Jammu and later succumbed to his injuries at Command hospital, Udhampur on 26th July 2003.

CONSTABLE MAHAVIR SINGH
115 BN BSF
12.06.1967 – 26.07.1996

CONSTABLE NARESH KUMAR
38 BN BSF
07.06.1969 – 26.07.1996

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constables Mahavir Singh and Naresh Kumar on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal injuries in Counterpart firing in area of FDL Usha, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

HC SHISHU PAL SINGH, THE DAG HAMMARSKJÖLD MEDAL & PMG
97 BN BSF
10.06.1977 – 26.07.2022

HC SANWALA RAM VISHNOI, THE DAG HAMMARSKJÖLD MEDAL & PMG
65 BN BSF
01.02.1980 – 26.07.2022

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Head Constables Shishu Pal Singh, and Sanwala Ram Vishnoi on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting with a violent mob in Democratic Republic of Congo. They fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. Both Jawans were part of INDFPU. Their sacrifice has been aptly recognized by United Nations and by GOI by awarding them with prestigious The Dag Hammarskjöld Medal and PMG (posthumously) respectively.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

Veer Balidani Naik Anand Prasad
2 Bn
3-2-1949 To 26-7-1992

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Naik Anand Prasad of 2 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating militants during an ambush in Banihal, Jammu & Kashmir on 26 July 1992. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Hari Charan Mondal
12 Bn
14-5-1972 To 26-7-1996

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Hari Charan Mondal of 12 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured while bravely combating Maoists in Andhra Pradesh on 26 July 1996. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Rampravesh Pal
121 Bn
30-1-1970 To 26-7-1999

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Rampravesh Pal of 121 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during an operation in Manipur on 26 July 1999.#CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Ved Prakash
28 Bn
1-1-1950 To 26-7-2002

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Ved Prakash of 28 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being seriously injured while bravely combating militants during an operation in Kulgam, Jammu & Kashmir on 26 July 2002. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Sub Inspector Naresh Kumar
111 Bn
10-3-1954 To 26-7-2009

Veer Balidani Constable Jayanta Roy
111 Bn
23-4-1969 To 26-7-2009

Veer Balidani Constable Ajit kumar
111 Bn
15-4-1983 To 26-7-2009

Veer Balidani Constable Lallu Singh
111 Bn
13-10-1977 To 26-7-2009

Veer Balidani Constable Sunil Kumar
111 Bn
20-12-1979 To 26-7-2009

Veer Balidani Constable R.V. Dighole
111 Bn
4-6-1970 To 26-7-2009

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to six bravehearts of 111 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during an ambush in Dantewada, Chhattisgarh on 26 July 2009. #CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Ashish Kumar Tiwari 202 Bn
14-6-1986 To 26-7-2010

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Ashish Kumar Tiwari of 202 CoBRA Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during an operation in West Medinipur, West Bengal on 26 July 2010. For his exceptional courage and conspicuous gallantry, he was posthumously awarded the Shaurya Chakra. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

CENTRAL INDUSTRIAL SECURITY FORCE

INSP/FIRE M. M. DINAKAR
FSTI HYDERABAD
26-07-2004

CT/GD R. K. MANDAL
ONGC AGARTALA
26-07-2002

CT/GD BRESH KUMAR
ONGC AGARTALA
26-07-2002

CISF proudly remembers the supreme sacrifice of these brave-hearts. On this day, Inspector/Fire M. M. Dinakar laid down his life at the altar of duty while saving the people from severe flood at Nalbari, Assam. Constable R. K. Mandal and Constable Bresh Kumar laid down their lives at the altar of duty while fighting with militants at ONGC Agartala. Their courage and bravery would remain an abiding source of inspiration for the force. The force will remain eternally indebted to them for their noblest deeds.

Shri Kishore Kunal, AC (GD)

SI (GD) Pratap Singh

Constable (GD) Amit Kumar Tiwari

Constable (Dvr) Gyalju Sherpa

'Sashastra Seema Bal' solemnly remembers the supreme sacrifice of the bravehearts Shri Kishore Kunal, AC(GD), SI(GD) Pratap Singh, CT(GD) Amit Kumar Tiwari and CT(Dvr) Gyalju Sherpa of 15th Battalion, SSB, Bongaigaon, who laid down their lives in the service of the Nation. On this day, sixteen years ago, these bravehearts attained martyrdom while bravely countering an insurgent ambush at Kuhighat Forest Beat House, Bongaigaon, Assam. In recognition of their exceptional courage and supreme sacrifice, these bravehearts were posthumously awarded the Parakram Padak in the year 2021. Their indomitable courage, unwavering devotion to duty and selfless sacrifice continue to inspire generations of SSB personnel and fellow countrymen.

SASHASTRA SEEMA BAL

UJVN LIMITED
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprise)
H. O. "UJJAWAL" MAHARANI BAGH, GMS ROAD, DEHRADUN - 248006, CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866
Tele.: 0135-2763508, 2763888, Fax: 0135-2763507, website: www.ujvnl.com

No. 620 Date: 25.07.2026

Time Extension Notice-1

Due to unavoidable circumstance the Office of the Executive Engineer (E&M) Madhmaheshwar SHP, UJVN Ltd., Guptkashi, hereby extends the date of bids invitation for NIT as per details given below:

NIT No. 03/EE(E&M-SHP)/Madhmaheshwar/2026-27 for Servicing, Overhauling, Calibration and Testing of HT/LT Breaker of Madhmaheshwar SHP (3x5MW) Guptkashi, Uttarakhand "located in Tehsil Ukhimath District-Rudraprayag".

Last Date for submission of Bid Date & Time: 04.08.2026 upto 15:00 Hrs
Date of opening of tender: 06.08.2026 at 15:00 Hrs
For fuller & further details, kindly visit " www.ujvnl.com".

Executive Engineer (E&M)(MM-SHP)

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

Woman in Delhi-bound train held with gold bars worth over Rs 7 cr

Express News Service
Lucknow, July 25

THE DIRECTORATE of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has arrested a woman travelling in a Delhi-bound train from West Bengal with 4.98 kg gold bars allegedly smuggled from Bangladesh worth around Rs 7.11 crore. She was arrested at Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Junction in Uttar Pradesh's Chandauli district.

A senior DRI official told *The Indian Express* that they had got intelligence about a woman carrying smuggled gold in big quantity travelling from Cooch Behar in West Bengal to New Delhi on the Brahmaputra Express on Wednesday. The DRI team conducted a search and she was found in an AC coach as the train reached Chandauli, the official said.

A woman member of the team conducted a search and found 13 gold bars weighing about 1.5 kg concealed in a cloth waist belt. A subsequent search of her handbag recovered 29 more gold bars weighing about 3.48 kg. In total, 42 foreign-origin gold bars were seized under the provisions of the Customs Act, the official said.

She was detained late Wednesday night and formally arrested under the provisions of the Customs Act on Thursday. On Friday, she was produced before the Special Chief Judicial Magistrate, Varanasi which remanded her to 14-day judicial custody, said the official.

The official claimed that in the interrogation, the woman revealed she is a regular carrier of gold bars smuggled from Bangladesh and into Indian territory through Cooch Behar district. She was to deliver it to a client each in Varanasi and Delhi, the official claimed and they were informed that the DRI has got vital inputs about the syndicate involved in the smuggling of gold, and efforts are on to trace other members of the gang.

'Safeguard essential': Top court on withholding children's Aadhaar details under APAAR scheme

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 25

THE SUPREME Court has asked the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to implement on a pan-India basis the Orissa High Court's direction that parents be provided with the option to refuse consent to sharing Aadhaar details of their children for creation of Automated Permanent Academic Account Registry (APAAR) ID or to opt out of the scheme.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana also directed that any personal information collected pursuant to the APAAR Scheme should not be disclosed or shared with any private entity or third party except in accordance with law.

The July 20 order which was made available on Saturday said, "Having considered the attending circumstances and the submissions advanced on behalf of the petitioners, we are inclined to adopt the approach taken by the High Court of Orissa at Cuttack in Rohit Anand Das vs State of Odisha...wherein the state authorities were directed to consider suitably amending the model consent form prescribed under the APAAR Scheme so as to expressly provide an option enabling parents or guardians to withhold or refuse consent."

The bench said it is "of the considered view that such a safeguard is essential to ensure that the requirement of consent is meaningful and informed. Accordingly, we direct that the directions contained in paragraph 19 of the aforesaid judgment shall be given effect to on a pan-India basis by the concerned authorities implementing the APAAR Scheme".

Paragraph 19 of the December 12, 2025 judgment of the Orissa HC asked authorities "to consider amendment of the model consent form to include an opt out/refusal of consent option therein".

The SC order came on petitions by some parents challenging the constitutional validity of the scheme.

The petitioners contended that the scheme "effectively operates as a State-run surveillance mechanism within the education sector by enabling the long-term tracking, profiling and monitoring of children's educational trajectories". They said that "the extensive collection and retention of such data creates the potential for its use beyond the educational sphere, thereby raising serious concerns relating to informational privacy and data protection".

The court also termed "misconceived" the concerns regarding the possible misuse of the personal information of those who voluntarily opted to enroll under the APAAR Scheme. "Merely because the collection of such information is undertaken pursuant to an administrative scheme and not under a statutory mandate does not absolve the authorities of their obligations in relation to the protection of personal data," it said.

The SC said "any collection, processing, storage, retention, sharing or use of personal information under the APAAR Scheme shall, therefore, be strictly governed by the provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, and the obligations cast thereunder upon data fiduciaries to ensure the lawful, secure and purpose-limited processing of personal data."

आयुर्वेद शिक्षण एवं अनुसंधान संस्थान (आईटीआरए),
InstituteofTeaching andResearch in Ayurveda (ITRA),
आयुष मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार
Ministry of Ayush Govt.of India
आयुर्वेद परिसर, जामनगर-361 008
Ayurveda Campus, Jamnagar – 361 008
वार्षिक दर अनुबंध सूचना: **2026-27**
Annual Rate Contract NOTICE : 2026-27

वर्ष 2026-27 के लिए आईटीआरए के अंतर्गत कार्यरत प्रयोगशालाओं के लिए प्रयोगशाला रसायन/कांच के बर्तन/किट/अभिकर्मकों की आपूर्ति करने के लिए पंजीकृत/अधिकृत विक्रेताओं से वार्षिक दर अनुबंध के लिए सीलबंद लिफाफा आमंत्रित किया जाता है। कंपनी के अधिकृत विक्रेता प्रमाणपत्र और सभी करों आदि को छोड़कर दर सूची सीलबंद लिफाफे में "प्रयोगशाला रसायन/कांच के बर्तन/किट/अभिकर्मक 2026-27" लिखकर दिनांक **18/08/2026 तक पहुँच जानी चाहिए। प्रयोगशाला रसायन/कांच के बर्तन/किट/अभिकर्मकों के लिए वार्षिक दर अनुबंधके लिए** अनुसूची ए एवं बी **और नियम और शर्तें आवश्यक विवरण के साथ itra.ac.in वेबसाइट पर उपलब्ध हैं। संस्थान स्वीकृति/अस्वीकृति का अधिकार सुरक्षित रखता है।**
संपर्क: 0288 2552014.

Sealed envelope for Annual Rate Contract are invited from registered/ authorized parties to supply laboratory chemicals/glassware/ kits/ reagents for laboratories functional under ITRA, for the year 2026-27. Company authorized dealer certificate and Rate list excluding all taxes etc. in sealed envelope superscribed "Laboratory chemicals/glassware/ kits/ reagents 2026-27" should reach latest by **Dt. 18/08/2026**. Terms and conditions for Annual Rate Contract and **SCHEDULE A & B** for laboratory chemicals/glassware/ kits/ reagents with required details are available on website itra.ac.in. The institute reserves the right for acceptance/rejection.
Contact: 0288 2552014.

इतरा/मा&पीआर/जाम/जुलाई-03 **निदेशक**
ITRA/M&PR/JAM/JUL-03 DIRECTOR

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग, परिमण्डल-अलीगढ़।
पता :-धनीपुर ब्लाक रोड़, निकट केनरा बैंक ट्रेनिंग सेन्टर, धनीपुर अलीगढ़।
पत्रांक-705/ग्रा०अ०वि०/निविदा/कासगंज / पत्रा०सं० लेखा-03/अनु०लि0/2026-27 दिनांक 20.07.2026

ई-निविदा (द्वितीय कॉल)

1-महामहिम राज्यपाल, उत्तर प्रदेश, की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग, अलीगढ़ परिमण्डल अलीगढ़ द्वारा प्रतिशत दर पर इलैक्ट्रानिक प्रणाली के माध्यम से योग्य एवं अनुमोदित ठेकेदारों जो कि यू०पी०आर०ई०डी० में मार्ग निर्माण कार्य हेतु उपयुक्त श्रेणी ए एवं बी में पंजीकृत है, से निम्नलिखित कार्य की निविदा आमंत्रित करते है।
2-कार्य का नाम तालिका के अनुसार

क्र० सं०	जनपद का नाम	विधान सभा/लोक सभा का नाम	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की स्वीकृत लागत (रू० लाख में) जी०एस० टी० सहित	निविदा की जमानत धनराशि (रू० लाख में)	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य जी०एस०टी० सहित (रूपये में)	कार्य जटु को सम्मिलित करते हुये कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1	कासगंज	अमौंपुर/एटा	विकास खण्ड सोरो तहसील कासगंज के ग्राम तुमरिया रेलवे अण्डर पास से नगला चिन्ती तक नव निर्माण कार्य।	98.78	2.00	3500.00	9 Month

3- बिड डाक्यूमेन्ट की बेबसाईट पर उपलब्धता का दिनांक 28.07.2026
4- ई-प्रोक्यूरमेन्ट के माध्यम से निविदा डालने की अन्तिम तिथि एवं समय 13.08.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे तक।
5- ई- प्रोक्यूरमेन्ट के माध्यम से निविदाये खोलने की तिथि एवं समय 13.08.2026 को अपरान्ह 12:30 बजे ।
6- शासन के निदेर्शानुसार कार्य-कुशलता / Competitive Price Efficiency के रूप में 5 प्रतिशत धनराशि की कटौती भुगतान के समय की जायेगी।
7- नियोक्ता को आई०टी०बी० के प्रस्तर-10 के अनुसार अतिरिक्त जानकारी / शुद्धिपत्र ऑनलाइन जारी करने का अधिकार है जो किसी भी समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशित नही किया जायेगा। अतः निविदा प्रक्रिया में भाग लेने वाले समस्त निविदादाताओं को सुझाव दिया जाता है कि वे ई-निविदा पोर्टल को नियमित रूप से देखते रहें।

(दुष्यंत प्रताप) अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,
ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग,
परिमण्डल-अलीगढ़।

UPID-254123 Date 24/07/2026
www.upidadv.gov.nic.in

HIMACHAL PRADESH
JAL SHAKTI VIBHAG
SHORT NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

Online bids on items rate basis are invited by the Executive Engineer, Jal Shakti Division, Shillai on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh, in electronic tendering system in two covers for the under mentioned work from the contractors/firms of appropriate class enlisted with Himachal Pradesh Jal Shakti Vibhag.

Sr. No	Description	E/ Cost	E/Money	Time	Cost of Form
1	Providing LIS for Sharli Guddi in GP Sharli Tehsil Kamroo Distt Sirmour (HP) Under NABARD (SH:- Providing, laying, jointing & testing in tranches of galvanized steel welded pipe and laying and jointing of GI pipe and HDPE pipe line of various dia. in distribution system and Providing and fixing 94 Nos. outlet assembly at various Nodes) Job-2	1,63,57,351/-	240000/-	9 Months	5000/-
2	Name of work:- BSP/2024/95 (R/O) Repair & Maintenance of GWSS Kota, GWSS Harlog, GWSS Daher Harijan Basti, GWSS Bagna & GWSS Pab in G.P. Kota Pab Tehsil Kamroo Distt. Sirmour (UNDER BASP) (SH:- C/O 6 Nos. RCC intake at different locations and laying, jointing & replacement of GI pipe line for Repair and maintenance of distribution system at various RDs).	11,11,348/-	22,250/-	5 Months	500/-
3	R/M of LWSS to NC/PC Kando Dugana in G.P. Dugana tehsil Kamroo Distt. Sirmour (H.P.) (SH:- Replacement of one No. WASP pump Model D-60/10 coupled with 30 HP existing Motor).	540000/-	10800/-	2 Months	350/-

1. Tender documents and other instructions can be downloaded or viewed online from the portal http://hptenders.gov.in by the firms/individual registered on the website which is free of cost.
1. As the bids are to be submitted online are required to be encrypted and digitally signed, the bidders are advised to obtain Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) from suitable venders or from any authorized agency at the earliest.
2. **Key dates will be as under:-**

1	Date of Online publication	24/07/2026 AT 5:00 PM
2	Downloading of e-tender Documents	From 24/07/2026 at 5:00 PM up to 9:00 AM on 05/08/2026
3	Date of submission of e-tendering	From 24/07/2026 at 5:00 PM up to 9:00 AM on 05/08/2026
4	Physical submission of earnest money deposit and cost of tender documents	Up-to 11:00 AM on 05/08/2026
4	Date of opening of Cover-1 (Eligibility criteria) and Cover-2 (Technical bid)	05/08/2026 at 12:30 PM
5	Date of Opening of Financial Bids Cover-2	Shall be intimated separately.

Note:- Other Tender information may be checked online portal website: www.hpetender.com
HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
Jal Shakti Division Shillai
No. 2175/2026-2027/HP

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Follow us on X @SCRailwayindia
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website : www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE

On Behalf of the President of India, Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer, Hyderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad Invites Open Tenders for the Following Works Through E-Procurement **Upto 11:30 Hours of Dated : 18.08.2026**

Sl No. 1, Tender No.: Y-SG-36-2026-27-15 Tender Dated : 23.07.2026, **Name of the work :** Hyderabad Division: SC-MUE Section Malkajgiri - Signalling and Telecommunication arrangements in connection with Doubling of Malkajgiri- Moula-ali Gate Cabin & (2) Malkajgiri - Signalling arrangement in connection with Malkajgiri Yard Remodeling Provision of Down Loop Line and 02 additional lines. **Tender Value :** Rs. 20,47,35,308.03. **EMD:** Rs. 40,94,700.00

For Bid Document and other details login to **https://www.ireps.gov.in.** Any Corrigenda will be issued online only

Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer/ Hyderabad

Tender Notice No. 17/2026. Dt. 24.07.2026 Supply Of Stores Items. E-Procurement Tender Notice

The Following Tenders Have Been Floated Online. Tenders Are Requested To Visit The Website **www. ireps.gov.in** And Submit Their Offers Online. The Tender Description, Qty, EMD, SD May Be Seen In Website. Offers Manually Will Not Accepted. Offers By Post Will Not Be Entertained. Tender Closing is 14.30 Hrs Of the Tender "For All Indigenous Offers, EMD Will Be Accepted Only Via Online System as Available On **www.ireps.gov.in.**"

Tender no	Brief Description
29261524	Overhauling kit for control portion (BP/CP)of CCB 2.0
29261526	Overhauling kit for control portion ER (787776-1994)
29261243	Bull Gear for WAG-9 loco 107 Teeth
29261362	Yaw Damper for WAG9 locos.
30261428	Lower Spring Beam Arrangement
33261007	Rubber pad
66265716	Procurement of spares for Track Machines.
45261065	V deep 6 grooved Axle pully as per RDSO
33261424	Secondary Vertical Damper
45261052	24V 290AH Batteries.
25264616	IOH Replacement kit for new 22 CB loco
75261428	Laminated Sheet.
33261413	Set of High Tensile Quality Fasteners
80261223	Lubricating Grease for TM motor Bearing & Suspension Tube
60266224	Procurement of single piece spring inserted reusable seize nut
33261093	Secondary Vertical Damper.
33261137	Wheel Set Earthing Equipment
29261525	Overhauling kit for control portion 20-pipe (20CP)

Note: Due dates of Tender Opening
SL. No. 01 to 04 on dt 10.08.2026. SL. No. 05 on dt. 11.08.2026 SL. No. 06 & 7 on dt. 12.08.2026 SL. No. 08 &09 on dt 13.08.2026 SL. No.10 on dt. 14.08.2026 SL. No. 11 to 15 on dt 17.08.2026 SL. No. 16 & 17 on dt. 19.08.2026. SL. No. 18 on dt.14.08.2026

Corrigendum
1) Tender Notice No.10/2026 dt. 05.06.2026 Tender No.66266285 due on 07.07.2026 may be read as Due DT. 28.07.2026
2) Tender Notice No.10/2026 dt. 05.06.2026 Tender No.66265845 due on 13.07.2026 may be read as Due DT. 03.08.2026
3) Tender Notice No. 10/2026 dt. 05.06.2026 Tender No.66266272 due on 02.07.2026 may be read as Due DT. 06.08.2026.
4) Tender Notice No. 12/2026 dt. 19.06.2026 Tender No.66266934 due on 08.07.2026 may be read as Due DT. 27.07.2026
5) Tender Notice No. 11/2026 dt. 12.06.2026 Tender No.66265834 due on 13.07.2026 may be read as Due DT. 03.08.2026

Beside Above Mentioned Tenders There Are Other Tenders Having Value Above Rs. 50 Lakhs for details Please Visit Railway Website: **www.ireps.gov.in**

Principal Chief Materials Manager/ Secunderabad
A575

For further tender conditions/ details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at https://www.ireps.gov.in or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार
सिंचाई एंव जल संसाधन विभाग

कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-2. हरिद्वार,दूरभाष नं0 01334-226493

Office Of The Executive Engineer Eastern Ganga Canal Construction. Div-2 Haridwar
Contact No. 01334-226493
E-Mail ID- egccd2hdw@gmail.com

पत्रांक : 2077/पू०गं०न०नि०ख०-2ह०/ नीलाम/ दिनांक: 22.07.2026

शुद्धिपत्र

सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है इस कार्यालय यो पत्र संख्या 1670/पूगंननिख-2ह/ नीलामी / दिनांक 20.06.2026 के द्वारा अधिशासी अभियन्ता पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-2 हरिद्वार के नियन्त्रणाधीन उपखण्ड द्वितीय के अन्तर्गत जनपद बिजनौर में स्टोर नजीबाबाद के परिसर में खड़ा विशालकाय 01 नग प्रजाति सेमल के पेड़ की नीलामी गठित समिति द्वारा दिनांक 08.07.2026 पूर्वान्ह 11:30 की नीलामी कार्यवाही अपरिहार्य कारणो से नही होने के कारण पुनः दिनांक 19.08.2026 को पूर्वान्ह 11:30 बजे की जायेगी।
नोटः- उपरोक्त नीलामी के सम्बन्ध में किसी भी प्रकार की जानकारी हेतु किसी भी कार्य दिवत्त में नीलामी तिथि से पूर्व प्रातः 10.00 बजे से सांय 5.00 बजे तक अधोहस्ताक्षरी के कार्यालय पूर्वी गंगा नहर निर्माण खण्ड-2, हरिद्वार में सम्पर्क / दस्तावेज जमा कर सकते है।

हस्ता./-
(योगेश निम)
अधिशासी अभियन्ता

UPID-254093 Date 24/07/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

GREATER VISAKHAPATNAM MUNICIPAL CORPORATION VISAKHAPATNAM

RFP Tender Notice No.30/2026-27/CE (GVMC) / SE (East) / EE (East) / GVMC/ Dt: 18-07-2026 (2nd call)

01. No.of Works : 1 (One) (RFP Tender)
02. Downloading Starting Date : 20-07-2026 @ 10.00 PM
03. Downloading End Date : 04-08-2026 @ 04.00 PM
04. Last date for Submission of bid : 04-08-2026 @ 05.00 PM

Further details at http://www.apeprocurement.gov.in
O/o The Executive Engineer (East) Division

Sd/- Commissioner, GVMC

Purvanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd.,
SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM-I)
Vidyut Nagar, BLW, Varanasi

Short Term E-Tender Notice: EAV- 54/2026-27 Dt. 25.07.2026

Name of Work: Supply of LT XLPE Cable 1x70 sq.mm. -3080 Km.

Tender Fee: Rs. 11,800.00 **Earnest Money:** Rs. 41.20 Lakh

Last date & Time for submission of tender document : 12 August 2026, 15:00 Hrs.
Further details and all other information can be seen at website **www.etender.up.nic.in**

पत्रांक : 2538 / पू०वि०वि०नि०लि०(वा०)/सा०प्र०-I/विज्ञापन दिनांक: 25.07.206

MANEKSHAW CENTRE
PARADE ROAD, DELHI CANTT-10
NOTICE INVITNG TENDER

1. ADG, Adm & Coord invites sealed tender from OEM/ authorized distributors/ vendors for procurement and installation of Digital Conferencing System in Conferencing Hall at Manekshaw Centre, Delhi Cantt-10 as per the terms and condition given in RFP
2. The tender documents (RFP) may be collected from Main Office, Manekshaw Centre, Delhi Cantt-10, between 1000hrs to 1700 hrs wef 27 July 2026 to 07 August 2026 on any working day against submission of tender documents fee of Rs 1500/- (Rupees One Thousand and Five Hundred only) in the form of Demand Draft/Bankers cheque in favour of **'Manekshaw Centre Main Acct' or Cash**
3. Sealed tender documents as per RFP will be dropped in the tender box placed at the Main Office of Manekshaw Centre by 1700hrs on 20 August 2026.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: 5820262027-128 **Date:** 23.07.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to **13:30 hrs.** on **17.08.2026.** The details of the tenders are as under:-

S.No.: 1 **Tender No.:** 128

Name of Work: Supply and stacking of Welding Portions for 60 kg and R-260 grade rails in section of Sr. DEN/I/PRYJ.

Approx Cost of work (Rs.): ₹ 1,49,00,689.48 **Bid Security (Rs.):** ₹ 2,98,000.00

Completion Period: 12 Months **Date of Opening of Tender: 17.08.2026.**

Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Supply of 52 kg/60 kg Alumino Thermic welding portion from RDSO approved firm only.

Note:- (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders is available on website **www.ireps.gov.in** up to **13:30 hrs.** on the due date of tender opening i.e **17.08.2026.** The tender shall be opened at or after **15:00 hrs.** on due date of opening. **(2)** Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. **(3)** Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightaway ignored and shall not be considered. **(4) Tender No. 128** are having advertised value more than **50 Lakhs**, therefore, Annexure-V & V(A) (Document Verification Certificate) is required. The supplier / contractor of goods and / or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. **(5)** This tender notice has also been uploaded on **www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. (6)** In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. **(7)** Tender online can be submitted up to **13:30 hrs.** on **17.08.2026. (8)** E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. **(9) For Tender No. 128 : The tenderers have to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-1) of IRGCC-2022 (Works matter) mandatorily, otherwise their offer will be considered as Incomplete Offer and accordingly shall not be considered.** **1697/26(A)**

North central railways | @CPRONCR | www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

134 roads in Himachal shut due to landslides, flash floods; 15 dead

Press Trust of India
Shimla, July 25

AS MANY AS 134 roads remained closed in Himachal Pradesh on Saturday due to landslides and flash floods triggered by torrential rains. The Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rainfall in four districts between July 28 and 30.

The Shimla Meteorological Centre also warned of low to moderate flash flood risk in parts of Chamba, Kangra, Kinnaur, Kullu, Mandi, Shimla and Sirmaur districts till Sunday morning. So far, landslides and flash floods have claimed 15 lives in Himachal.

As many as 14 have died in landslides — 13 people died in Lahaul and Spiti after a rock fell on a moving taxi on Friday. One death was reported in Chamba district due to a landslide. One person died in flash floods in Kangra district, officials said on Saturday. A total of 134 roads, including 58 in Mandi, 33 in Kullu, 14 in Chamba, 12 in Sirmaur, seven in Shimla, five in Kangra, four in Lahaul and Spiti, and one in Una district, were closed due to vehicular traffic on Saturday evening.

As many as 35 water supply schemes and 78 transformers have also been affected in the state, according to the State Emergency Operation Centre (SEOC). Light to moderate rains continued in the state since Friday evening, with Dharamshala recording the highest rainfall at 80.5 mm.

The Met has predicted a wet spell in the state till July 31.

Assam floods: 61 dead, over 7.05 lakh affected

Press Trust of India
Guwahati, July 25

THE FLOOD situation in Assam remained grim on Saturday even as the water level has started to recede in some parts. As many as 61 people have died and over 7.05 lakh people affected in nine districts, officials said.

According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) bulletin on Friday night, 14 more people lost their lives in the deluge in the last 24 hours, taking the toll to 61 this year.

According to the authority's daily flood report, more than 7,05,100 people have been affected in Charaideo, Dhemaji, Dibrugarh, Golaghat, Hojai, Jorhat, Karbi Anglong, Nagaon and Sivasagar districts.

The flood situation has improved marginally since Thursday, when over 7.21 lakh people were affected across 11 districts.

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said his government is yet to deliver relief materials to at least 80,000 flood-affected people even as the situation remained critical with many rivers continuing to rise following incessant rains.

Rain fury claims 40 lives in Gujarat; several rescued

Kamal Saiyed
Surat, July 25

NEARLY 40 persons died in rain-related incidents across Gujarat, the highest being in Valsad and Navsari which together reported 33 deaths till Saturday, largely caused by electrocution or drowning. One death each was reported from Tapi and Surat districts in South Gujarat till Saturday, according to sources in the State Revenue Department.

In Ahmedabad district, the Army and Gujarat Police personnel rescued several persons from industrial units and warehouses even as the 60-km NH 47 connecting Ahmedabad to Rajkot, remained closed to traffic till Bagodra for the second consecutive day because of flood related damage. The state highway connecting the city to Viramgam through the auto hubs of Sanand and Mandal which was closed on Friday, opened late Saturday for heavy vehicles. This stretch sees the busiest commercial traffic and has developed as an industrial and logistics zone.

The district police rescued 900 workers from the Gallops Industrial Park in Bavla, close to Sanand while more than 80 workers were rescued from an Amazon warehouse in a village in Bavla taluka by the Army.

The flooding in the district is being attributed to excessive rainfall and water released from the Sabarmati River through the Vasna barrage in Ahmedabad.

Although rainfall eased in Ahmedabad city, South Western suburbs like Bopal, Ghuma, Sindhu Bhavan Road (SBR) and Thaltej remained flooded. At several places sink holes were reported, including a party plot on SBR. Places such as the Hariom Villa in Bopal where Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel visited on Friday, continued to be under a foot-deep water when *The Indian Express* visited on Saturday. Apart from South Gujarat, one death each was reported from Sanand and Dholka in Ahmedabad district and one each from Anand, and Radhanpur in Banaskantha district.

As Gujarat reels under floods, army personnel carry out rescue operations in Ahmedabad's Golden Katar division on Saturday. BHUPENDRA RANA

Ten deaths were reported from Valsad due to rain-related incidents, while four missing complaints have been registered with different police stations in the district in the past couple of days. In Navsari district, 23 deaths have been reported in the last two days. A total of 33 dead bodies were recovered from both the districts in the past two days.

Navsari Superintendent of Police (SP) Rahul Patel told *The Indian Express*, "We have recorded 23 deaths and a few missing complaints in the past couple of days. While nearly 20,000 people have been rescued and shifted to different places by district administration. The highest number of deaths have been reported from Gandevi taluka. The reason such vast devastation took place in Navsari district is that the rainwater from Dang, Tapi and Surat district reaches into three rivers, Ambika, Kaveri and Purna, as a result of which all these three rivers overflowed and water entered into the low-lying areas on the banks."

Valsad SP Yuvrajsinh Jadeja said, "In the past two days, a total of 10 deaths due to rain-related incident have been reported from seven talukas in the district. Over 16,500 people have been rescued and shifted to shelter homes or to their relatives' places by the district administration."

Thousands of cars and bikes in Surat, Navsari and Valsad were submerged in water.

As per the data received from the Valsad district disaster department, the seven talukas in Valsad district – Valsad town, Dharampur, Pardi, Kaprada, Umbergaon, Vapi and Nanapondha had on July 22 received a total of 2,759 mm rainfall, followed by 2,665 mm, and 286 mm on the following two days till Friday.

(With Inputs from ENS, Ahmedabad)

• BRIEFLY

Security personnel keep vigil on Jammu-Srinagar National Highway following the Anantnag terror attack in Kulgam on Saturday. PTI

J&K L-G Sinha directs additional security on Amarnath Yatra route

JAMMU AND Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Saturday reviewed repair and restoration works along the Amarnath Yatra tracks after the Valley was lashed by heavy rains over the last few days. Sinha chaired a high-level meeting with camp directors and senior officials, and assessed the damage on tracks, safety railings and other essential infrastructure. To ensure safety of pilgrims, he directed deployment of additional Mountain Rescue Teams and stressed the importance of sharing real-time weather updates with the pilgrims proactively, the spokesperson said. He instructed officials to ensure that essential services like power and water supply remain operational. PTI

Sikkim landslide kills 2 workers clearing road

TWO WORKERS died, and four were grievously injured after a landslide hit them while clearing debris from a stretch of road that was brought in by a previous landslip in Sikkim's Namchi district on Saturday, police said. Six workers were engaged in clearing the debris that had blocked the road connecting Sada and Phamtam villages when a fresh landslide hit the worksite. The deceased have been identified as Lal Bahadur Rai,18 and Man Bahadur Gurung 61, police said, adding that the injured were immediately rescued and shifted to the district hospital in Namchi. PTI

Chennai: Murder accused killed by fellow inmate

A MURDER suspect undergoing court-mandated psychiatric care at the Institute of Mental Health in Kilpauk here, was brutally beaten to death by a fellow inmate following a sudden altercation, hospital sources said on Saturday. Police sources also said that the accused, Aravindhsamy was in the same facility under court orders after being arrested for murdering his own mother .On July 20, in an argument between the two, Aravindhsamy launched a severe physical assault, repeatedly striking Zakir. The latter was immediately rushed to the government hospital where he died late Thursday midnight. PTI

Court denies retired judge's bail in Twisha Sharma dowry death case

Express News Service
Bhopal, July 25

A DISTRICT court in Bhopal Friday rejected the bail application of retired judge Giribala Singh, holding that releasing her at this stage could influence evidence in the dowry death case of her daughter-in-law, model-turned-actor Twisha Sharma.

The court observed that the prosecution's apprehension that evidence could be affected if Giribala Singh was granted bail "cannot be said to be unfounded" and noted that the case diary contained sufficient material indicating her alleged involvement.

First Additional Sessions Judge Ram Pratap Mishra took note of material collected during the investigation. "The material available...indicates the involvement of the applicant/accused in the offence. The alleged offence is a serious crime against a woman and is punishable with imprisonment for life. If the applicant/accused is granted the benefit of bail, there is a possibility that the evidence may be influenced," the court said.

Twisha, who had married Giribala Singh's son Samarth Singh on December 9, 2025, died by suicide on May 12, 2026. The prosecution alleged physical and mental harassment over dowry demands.

With Customs' nod, Kerala's Vizhinjam set to become gateway for exports & imports

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 25

THE VIZHINJAM International Transshipment Seaport has been notified as a customs port, paving the way for export and import (EXIM) cargo operations at a facility that has so far functioned exclusively as an international transshipment hub.

With the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs notifying the port as a customs port, Vizhinjam is expected to emerge as another gateway for India's exports and imports. Besides boosting container movement, the country's first international deepwater transshipment port is expected to provide a major fillip to Kerala's economy and generate jobs in shipping, logistics and allied sectors.

Since commencing operations in July 2024, Vizhinjam has functioned solely as a transshipment hub, handling container ships and transferring containers from one vessel to another.

Official sources said export and import operations will begin on August 18. The launch of EXIM services, part of the state government's 100-day action plan, will transform Vizhinjam into a full-fledged export-import gateway. This is expected to reduce logistics costs, improve supply chain efficiency, enhance exporters' competitiveness, attract investment and generate employment.

Developed under the PPP model by the Kerala government and Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ), Vizhinjam International Seaport has emerged as one of the world's fastest-growing container ports. Within 18 months of commencing commercial operations, it handled 2 million TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent units) of container traffic.

The customs notification also lays down conditions for export and import operations.

At present, no container freight station (CFS) has been attached to or designated for Vizhinjam. (A CFS is a secure warehouse or distribution facility where smaller shipments are consolidated into a single container for export or separated for import.) Accordingly, the notification says the port will handle only the direct movement of full containers. Loose cargo or containers requiring de-stuffing or CFS examination will not be allowed.

Imported containers must be moved directly from the terminal to the importer's premises within 48 hours of landing. For exports, the port will accept only fully loaded containers that are ready for shipment.

Consuming chicken biryani no offence: Justice Bhuyan

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, July 25

SAYING THAT there was "no law prohibiting consumption of chicken over the Ganga river", Justice Ujjal Bhuyan of the Supreme Court on Saturday criticised the arrest of youngsters for consuming chicken biryani while breaking their fast. "I am sure consuming chicken biryani is not an offence. It can't be an offence...they were arrested for that very reason and they had to remain in jail for three months," he said.

Speaking at the 4th Memorial Lecture of Justice G P Singh at the National Law Institute University (NLIU), Bhopal, Justice Bhuyan said peaceful protest is central to a democracy but ordinary acts of dissent are increasingly being treated as criminal conduct. "The right to express one's views and to demonstrate peacefully are fundamental freedoms of citizens. Debate and dissent are the essence of democracy. Unfortunately, even normal activities are being criminalised," he said.

Referring to environmental protests and student demonstrations, he said, "People who come to voice their anguish over environmental degradation, which is a reality, are chased away as if they are criminals. Students protesting in campuses are arrested and they do not get bail for 30-40 days." He added that students are often suspended as well,

> **By such restrictive orders, are the courts indirectly telling citizens or discouraging citizens not to express their dissent?"**
> JUSTICE UJJAL BHUYAN

forcing them to approach courts before they can resume their education.

Justice Bhuyan questioned whether courts, through restrictive bail conditions, were also discouraging dissent. "These issues raise serious questions... though the courts are responsive and do grant bail, many a time it is belated. But it is the restrictive conditions which are imposed while granting bail that are causing the greatest concern. By such restrictive orders, are the courts indirectly telling the citizens or discouraging the citizens not to express their dissent?" he said.

Referring to the Supreme Court's 2024 judgment against punitive "bulldozer justice", Justice Bhuyan said the ruling was welcome but had come "two years too late". He also referred to cases where accused persons granted bail were restrained from attending public meetings or posting on social media, saying such conditions "severely undermine their fundamental freedoms and liberty".

He also criticised the Bombay High Court's refusal to permit a demonstration in solidarity with Palestine, saying he found the court's observations "very amusing". He recalled that the petitioners had been asked why they wanted to protest over events in Gaza instead of issues within India, adding that India has traditionally recognised Palestine and hosts a Palestinian Embassy.

He also said that the issue with former judges moving into political roles after retirement, saying "when a former Chief Justice of India says, 'I am going to the Rajya Sabha to bridge the gap between judiciary and the Executive', it is fundamentally wrong..."

Calling on law students to question institutions, including the judiciary, Justice Bhuyan said judicial decisions must remain open to scrutiny.

He also noted that the judiciary's legitimacy ultimately rests on public confidence rather than self-assessment, adding that "new generation of lawyers and law students are far more committed to the rule of law and to the Constitution than my generation was. I see great hope in them."

Maharashtra TET paper leak: Month later, 'mastermind', aide arrested from Bihar

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, July 25

NEARLY A MONTH after the Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) exam paper leak in Maharashtra, the Thane Police early Saturday arrested the alleged mastermind from Bihar.

Thane City DCP (zone II) Dr Pavan Bansod said, "Our teams had been looking for Bijendra Gupta over the past few weeks and managed to trace him to Bihar, where he along with another accused Indrajit Sinha was placed under arrest. The accused were produced before a Thane court and remanded to police custody."

The Thane City police had feared the Gupta had crossed over to a neighbouring country from Bihar. A trap they had set for Gupta in Bihar had failed to lure him out for a month.

Around 1 am Saturday, a team from Thane Police took custody of Gupta and the 'bait' Indrajit Sinha from Samastipur in Bihar and brought him to Thane. Sources in Thane police said that they had studied the past trend where Gupta, who is accused of being involved in other paper leaks, would go absconding in one part of the country and emerge in another under a new identity.

"We arrested two people who had provided him fake Aadhaar cards and other identity documents under various names. His wife who had been transferring money him had also been arrested to ensure he had no assistance from outside," an officer said.

While they had other relatives and those linked to Gupta on the radar in case he reached out to him, their focus remained Sinha. However, as days turned to weeks, there was no update either from technical surveillance or the local Bihar police station. As per sources, on Thursday, the Thane police received a tip off about someone having contacted and later visited Sinha at Samastipur, which also happens to be where Gupta grew up.

"To ensure they do not flee, the next available flight to Maharashtra — headed to Pune — was taken by the team and the duo was brought to the city," the officer said.

The exam leak came to light two days before the TET examination date of June 28 for which nearly six lakh teachers from across the state were to appear.

In a first, only women judges to preside over Karnataka HC bench

Mustafa Plumber
Bengaluru, July 25

IN A first, all benches of the Karnataka High Court's Dharwad bench will be presided over by women judges on August 1. The historic roster order was issued on July 23 after the Dharwad Advocates' Association sent a request to Karnataka High Court Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru in March in light of International Women's Day.

The Dharwad bench has seven benches. While three division benches will have two women judges each, four single benches will be presided over by four women judges. As per the notification, the women judges who will preside are Justices Anu Sivaraman, K G Shanthi, Jyoti M, P Sree Sudha, Lalitha Kanneganti, K S Hemalekha, Dr Chillakur Sumalatha, Tara Vitasta Ganju, Geetha K B, and Rajeshwari N Hegde.

"The sitting is a symbol of gender justice and empowerment and will be a source of inspiration to young women advocates, law students, and female legal practitioners across North Karnataka and the nation," B D Hiremath, president of Dharwad Advocates Association, told *The Indian Express*.

The Regimental Medical Officer who chose to return to action

Anuradha Mascarenhas
Pune, July 25

DURING OPERATION VIJAY in 1999, Captain (now Brigadier) Jyoti Prakash served as the Regimental Medical Officer of an elite PARA unit in the Mushkoh Valley. A paratrooper, he had volunteered for PARA and in the thick of war this soldier-doctor sustained a splinter injury at Bakharwal. For most that would have been reason enough to recover at the field surgical centre and remain away from further danger. The captain chose otherwise.

As the nation observes Kargil Vijay Diwas on July 26, the 55-year-old Brig Jyoti Prakash, Prof and Head, Department of Psychiatry at Armed Forces Medical College, Pune, shared how important it was to 'be the healing touch, lead with calm hands and wear the uniform with pride.'

Brig Prakash (who was a Captain then) was 28 years old and would share the same ethos of PARA units operating beyond enemy lines — courage, endurance, brotherhood and mission-first commitment. In the thick of the war under heavy artillery shelling and in unforgiving terrain, the 28-year-old stood shoulder to shoulder with his men as a die-hard paratrooper and a soldier- doctor.

At Bakharwal, he sustained a through-and-through splinter injury caused by hostile action. Evacuated by helicopter to the nearest Field Surgical Centre, his wound was cleaned, explored and stitched. However despite

Brigadier Jyoti Prakash; (right) Chief of Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan with Colonel Satish Mallik.

ARUL HORIZON

excruciating pain and injury he boarded the next sortie back to Bakharwal. For a soldier, shedding blood in the line of duty is among the highest honours of service. As an RMO,he was able to save the lives of many combatants injured in the line of fire and ensure that the unit remained battle-ready. While he settled in Pune in 2019, colleagues said Brig Jyoti Prakash remains a unique case of an elite paratrooper and Regimental Medical Officer who went beyond the call of duty and saved lives.

Kargil Vijay Diwas honours the courage, sacrifice and determination of the Bravehearts of Operation Vijay. As the nation remembers their historic victory, Col Satish Malik who lost his leg to a mine blast in an op area has over the years dealt with challenges. His leg below the knee had to be amputated and fitted with a prosthetic one at Pune's Artificial Limb Centre. But not once did he look behind and pursue activities with a vigour that led him to overcome physical barriers, drive cars and ride his motorcycle around the country.

Col Malik continued in the Armed Forces till 2008 and took voluntary retirement. Along with a partner he set up a risk management consultancy firm and is part of the Phoenix Braveheart rider group that bikes all over India , Bhutan and Nepal. "I never felt handicapped," he said adding that his guiding mantra has always been 'I won't give up until I have truly tried'. This belief has guided him through life, helping him face challenges with determination and never give up without trying and during the Chief of Naval Staff, Indian navy, Admiral Krishna Swaminathan's visit at ALC, Pune both shared light-hearted moments as they recalled their days as batch mates at NDA.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Mohd Shahzad khan S/O Tauhid Mohd khan R/O 127/34, 3rd floor gali no. 3 Ghaffar manzil, Jamia Nagar New Delhi 110025,have changed my name to Mohammad Shahzad khan permanently. 0040868191-1

I,Sandeep Chhabra,S/o Ved Parkash Chhabra,R/o-A-3,Golden-Park,Near-Shivpuri Chander Nagar,Krishna-Nagar,Delhi-110051,have changed my minor son name Reyan Chhabra to Ranveer Chhabra. 0040868282-4

I,Kiran Kapoor,W/o-Sh.Vikram Kapoor,D/o,Late Jamuna Dutt Pargaien,R/O,B-1A/30C,Janak-Puri,New Delhi-110058,that my Father's name JAMUNA DUTT PARGAIEN and J. D. PARGAIEN" both names are of one and same-person. 0040868288-9

I, Mohammad Iqbal S/o Abdul Salam, R/o 8885, Naya Mohalla, Pul Bangash, Azad Market, North Delhi-110006, have changed my name to Mohd Iqbal. 0071050101-1

I Kapildeo Singh S/o Kapil Dev Singh R/o Village-Jhakhara Ke Tola, PO: Fulwaria Tajpur, Teh-Manjhi, DISTT: Saran, Bihar-841209, have changed my name to Yamuna Singh 0071050178-1

I,Krishna Kumar Jaiswal,S/o-Lallan Prasad Jaiswal,R/o 444B,Regent Shipra Suncity, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad-201014, have changed my name from Krishna Kumar Jaiswal to Krishna Prasad Jaiswal for all future purposes. 0040868260-3

I,Surinder Kumar Dhall,S/o-Girdhari Lal,R/o Flat No-101,Meera-7G,FF, Vrindaban-Bangar Vrindaban Mathura, UP have changed my name to Surinder Dhall 0040868288-2

I,ISHIKA D/o-Sanjeev Kumar R/o-B-3/325,FF, Paschim Vihar New Delhi-110063,have changed my name to ISHIKA BANSAL, permanently 0040868282-6

I,Shubham S/o Arvind Kumar R/o RZD-97, Nihal Vihar, Nangloi, West Delhi, Delhi-110041, have changed my name to Shubham Kumar. 0040868288-11

I Satender S/o Shri.Dase Ram R/o House no A-198,Village Nathupura,Delhi-110084.Have changed my name from Stander Kumar to Satender for all purposes.Both name belongs to one and same person. 0071050103-1

I, Manoj Kumar s/o Bahadur Chand Arora r/o H-203, Phase-1, Ashok Vihar, Delhi-110052 have changed my name as MANOJ KUMAR ARORA. 0040868209-1

I,GEETA RANI W/o-VIKARAM R/o-KARAR, IBRAHIMPUR(92), SONIPAT, HARYANA - 131039 have changed my name to GEETA 0040868288-4

I, VIRENDER LOHIYA S/o Bhajan Lal, R/o-76,Nathupur(67), Gurgaon, Haryana-122002 have changed my name to VIRENDER KUMAR. 0071050126-1

I, SHABINA SAMERIN C/O AJMAL AHMAD, R/O S - 300, ENTIRE FIRST FLOOR, NEAR BY PARK, GREATER KAILASH 1, SOUTH DELHI 110048, INDIA, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SHABINAH SAMREIN FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES. 0040868234-1

I,Yogesh Choudhary,S/o Jitender Singh,R/o 7062 Gali Tej Singh Pahari Dhiraj Delhi -110006 Changed my name to Yogesh Chaudhary 0040868282-8

I,Aparna Bhasker,R/o 18A/32,Gali.No.18,Manav Kunj,Mukandpur,Extn. Part-2,North-West, delhi,Delhi-110042, inform that my,father's name is wrongly recorded as "DHIRENDRA KUMAR BHASKAR" instead of "DHIRENDRA KUMAR BHASKER" in my 10th marksheet.Both belong to one and the same person vide affidavit-dt.24-07-2026. 0040868296-2

I,SUDEEP DAS GUPTA S/O A.C. GUPTA R/o 3F-137,First Floor,Sector-3, Vaishali, Ghaziabad,U.P.-201010, have changed my name to SUDEEP GUPTA. 0040868282-1

I,Md Amjad,S/o-Mohd Iliyas Qureshi,R/o-5117,Gali Peer Mohammad,Quresh Nagar,Sadar-Bazar,Delhi-110006,have changed my name to MOHD AMJAD QURESHI, for all purpose. 0040868288-6

I Rashmeet Kaur Sahni W/o Karanjeet Singh Rajpal R/o Flat No. 304, Yash Apartment, Sector-11, Dwarka, N.D. have changed my name to Rashmeet Kaur. 0040868246-1

I,Param Jeet Kaur Nijjar,W/o Rajinder Singh Nijjar,R/o 6H/92,Sector-5, Rajendra Nagar, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Premjeet Kaur,for all purposes. 0040868282-10

I, ARSHIYA AKHTAR D/o Irfan Zaheeri R/o-2102, Ahata Kale Sahib, Gali Qasim Jan, Ballimaran, Delhi-02 have changed my name to ARSHIYA IRFAN. 0071050130-1

I, Shivani, D/o Satpal Kumar, R/o 284, Village Khera khurd, North West Delhi-110082, declare that Satpal and Satpal Kumar are one and the same person. 0071050195-1

I,Iqbal S/o Ismail Khan,R/o Masjid ke Pass ,Tehsil-Firojpur Jhirka,Village -Ghaghas,Mewat(Haryana),have changed my name to Iqbal Khan. 0040868282-3

I,ANSHIL S/O SANJEEV KUMAR,R/O H.NO.167/19, RAILWAY ROAD,PO-TOHANA MANDI, FATEHABAD, HARYANA-125120.HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO ANSHIL GOYAL. 0040868288-8

I, SABA JAMEEL W/O AZIZ AHMED R/O 5076/1 KUCHA REHMAN BALLIMARAN CHANDNI CHOWK DELHI 110006 , have changed my name to SABA Permanently 0071050096-1

I Minto W/o Ghamndi Lal R/o B-5/127, Nand Nagari, North East, Delhi - 110093, have changed my name to Minto Devi 0071050160-1

I,Rajender Kumar Pal S/O Ratan Lal R/O Jalpura,Khera Choganpur, kulesra,Dadri,Gautam Budh Nagar,Uttar Pradesh-201306,have changed my name to Rajender Kumar. 0040868260-2

I,Deepak Singhal,R/o-2098, Employment exchange wali gali Nai Basti Narela mandi,New Delhi-110040,Have changed my name to Deepak Kumar, for all purposes 0040868288-1

I, Jyotsna Aggarwal W/o Mukul Aggarwal R/o H-1902, Tower-H, Hawelia Valencia Homes, Sector-1, Bishrakh, Greater Noida West, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh 201306 have changed my name from Jyotsna Aggarwal to Jyotsna Oberoi. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Jyotsna Oberoi for all future purposes. 0071050197-1

I,UJJAWAL GOYAL S/o Naveen Goyal R/o-B-318,Prashant Vihar Rohini Delhi-110085 have changed my name to UJJWAL GOYAL 0040868282-5

I,DEEPAK CHAURASIA S/o NARESH CHANDER CHAURASIA R/o,Flat-No.83, Block-M, Pocket-MG1, Vikas-Puri, New Delhi-110018, have changed my name to DEEPAK BHARDWAJ permanently. 0040868288-10

I, Naveen Kumar Sekhri S/o Satpal Sekhri R/o-149, Ahta Garib Das, Bajariya, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Naveen Sekhri. 0071050191-1

I, Asma Begum W/o Asgar Ali Khan R/o 211 Block-D, Sec-55, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, UP-201301, have changed my name to Ashma Begum for all future Purposes. 0071050102-1

I, Parveen Kumar s/o Jagbir Singh, House No.-151, Sannoth, Narela, Delhi-110040 have changed my name as PARVEEN permanently. PARVEEN KUMAR and PARVEEN both are same and one person. 0040868211-1

I,SUNDER MANI KUKRETI S/o Sh. Rajaram Kukreti R/o Flat No.7-E,Pocket-B-5,Near Ryan International School,Mayur Vihar Phase-III,Delhi-110096,have changed my name from SUNDER MANI to SUNDER MANI KUKRETI.SUNDER MANI KUKRETI and SUNDER MANI is the same person. 0040868260-4

I,Rashida Bano,D/o-Abul Safa,W/o-Mashkoor Ahmed,R/o.Flat No.5-T, Sector-7, DDA-Flats, Jasola Vihar, New Delhi-110025,have changed my name to Rashida Mashkoor, Permanently 0040868288-3

I,Autar Singh Bhatia,S/o-Sampuran Singh Bhatia, R/o kh.No.36/4/2, Ground floor Gali No.-5,Ramesh Tyagi colony,Jharoda Majraa,Delhi-110084,changed my name to Avtar Singh 0040868282-7

I,RUHANI DHAWAN,D/o GAURAV DHAWAN,H.NO- C148,RISHI NAGAR RANI-BAGH,NEW DELHI 110034,changed my name to Ruhanika Dhawan for all future purposes 0040868296-1

I, Vijay Shankar S/o Ram Dayal, C-133/325, Humayunpur Uttari, Gorakhpur, Uttar Pradesh-273015 have changed my name to Vijay Shanker Baranwal. 0071050125-1

I, Tashi Laden Yalmoo, D/o Wangchuk Yalmoo, R/o 807/7, Govind Puri, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019,hereby declare that "Wangchuk Lama Yolmo" and "Wangchuk Yalmoo" refer to one and the sameperson (my father), and "Leelawati Chettri" and Leela Yalmoo" refer to one and the same person(my mother). This notice is published for passport verification and all concerned authorities. 0040868269-1

I,Sabeen W/o-Mohd Amjad Qureshi R/o 5117,Gali Peer Mohammad,Quresh Nagar, Sadar Bazar,Delhi-110006,have changed my name to SABEEN QURESHI,for all purpose. 0040868288-5

I,SURINDER SACHDEVA S/o-Sadhu Ram R/o-P, No-378, Block-II,Sunder Vihar Paschim Vihar New Delhi-110087, have changed my name to SURINDAR SCHDEV. 0040868282-9

I, SHARDA LOHIYA W/o Virender Kumar R/o-76,Nathupur(67), Gurgaon, Haryana-122002 have changed my name to SHARDA. 0071050128-1

I,MADHAVI DAS GUPTA W/O SUDEEP GUPTA,R/o 3F-137,First Floor, Sector-3, Vaishali, Ghaziabad,U.P.-201010 have changed my name to MADHAVI GUPTA. 0040868282-2

I,GULAFSHA,W/O-TARIK R/O-H.N0-352,PIPLEDA HAPUR,UTTAR PRADESH-245101,HAVE CHANGE MY NAME TO GULFSHI,FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSE. 0040868288-7

I,KM Seema W/O Rajender Kumar R/OJalpura,Kulesara,Gautam Buddha Nagar,Uttar Pradesh-201306,have changed my name to Seema Rani. 0040868260-1

I,Dripti,D/o Ravi,R/o O-18,Mangol Puri,Delhi-110083,declared that my and my father's name wrongly-mentioned in my birth-certificate and my name wrongly mentioned in my birth certificate,ladli yojna Dropati D/o Ravi Shonkar But actual name is Dripti,D/o Ravi. 0040868282-12

I, MD Mazhar Khan S/o Kasim Khan R/o F1905, RG Residency, Sec-120, Noida have changed my name to Mohammed Mazhar Khan. 0071050132-1

GENERAL

Alliance for our son, 33 years, Ghaziabad, 5'-9", B.Tech, MBA, associate manager in Delhi, Hindu, Kayasth. Bride from a decent kayasth family. around 29 years. Contact 9318302530, shriaks61@gmail.com 0050292985-3

NRI/GREEN CARD

REQUIRE Vegetarian Girl in USA/ India ready to relocate to Sanjose for Bachelor Boy 1987 July 6'1", MS, on I-140. Contact : 9930020727. 0071047117-1

SIKH/PUNJABI

Sikh 38M 5'10" BTech seeks homely / professional match. Family Delhi based. Whatsapp 9818559090, 9936092227. 0050293425-2

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

My clients: **Sh. Dharamvir (Aadhar Card No. 5440-8074-1741) S/o Sh. Rameshwar and Pinki Devi (Aadhar Card No. 2357-1328-2652) W/o Sh. Dharamvir Singh** R/o H. No. 185-B, Ward No. 2, New Patel Park, Line Par, Bahadurgarh, Distt. Jhajjar, Haryana, have broken their relationship with their son namely **Aman S/o Sh. Dharamvir and daughter-in-law namely Aarti W/o Aman** R/o H. No. 185-B, Ward No. 2, New Patel Park, Line Par, Bahadurgarh, Distt. Jhajjar, Haryana, due to their bad behavior habits and quarrelling, abusing, threatening and disobedience of my clients. Therefore my clients from their free will to decide debar/disown them and their children's also from their movable and immovable property and ancestral properties/assets. If anybody dealing with them in any manner, it will be their own risk and consequences.

Sd/-
CHANDER MANI
Advocate
Ch. No. 118, Lawyers Chambers
Civil Courts Complex, Bahadurgarh

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public at large is hereby notified on behalf of my client Smt. Gayatri Kansotia W/o late Sh. Sanjay Kumar Kansotia, R/o B- 37-OB, New Slum Quarters., Paschim Puri, New Delhi-110063 hereby declare that due to personal reasons and irreconcilable differences, My client have severed all social, financial, and personal relations with her brother Sh.Harminder Kumar S/o late sh. Naval Kishore & his family members.
From the date of publication of this notice, My client Smt. Gayatri Kansotia shall not be responsible for acts, deeds, liabilities, obligations or commitments made by him. Any person dealing with him shall do so at his/her own risk, cost and responsibility.

Alkesh Tanwar (Advocate) Enrol No. D/676/2021 — **Ritesh Tanwar (Advocate)** D/2411/2010
CB-144, Ring Road, Naraina, ND-28

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public at large is hereby notified on behalf of my clients Smt. Kanta Khanna W/o Sh. Nand Kishore Khanna and her husband Sh. Nand Kishore Khanna, both R/o H- 128, Naraina Vihar, New Delhi-110028 hereby declare that due to personal reasons and irreconcilable differences, My clients have severed all social, financial, and personal relations with her Sister-In-Law Smt Manju w/o late sh. Narender Kumar Mundotia & her son/daughter Sh. Gaurav Mandotia & Komal.
From the date of publication of this notice, My clients Smt. Kanta Khanna & Sh. Nand Kishore Khanna shall not be responsible for acts, deeds, liabilities, obligations or commitments made by him. Any person dealing with him shall do so at his/her own risk, cost and responsibility.

Alkesh Tanwar (Advocate) Enrol No. D/676/2021 — **Ritesh Tanwar (Advocate)** D/2411/2010
CB-144, Ring Road, Naraina, ND-28

PUBLIC NOTICE

Information is given to general public at large upon instruction from Mr. Shivam Gupta who intend to mortgage Built-up Second Floor, without roof rights, area measuring 105.34 sq. mtrs., part of Property No. 1/7431, Plot No. 4, out of Khasra No. 258, situated at Abadi of East Gorakh Park now known as Shivaji Park, in the area of Village Sikdarpur, Illaqa Shadara, Delhi-110032 who is the owner through Sale Deed dated 18.03.2026 executed by Mrs. Nisha Gupta Duly Regd. as Doc. No. 2026/23/1/1910, in Book No. 1, Vol. No. 9665, Page No. 73-98, dated 23.03.2026, ISRO- IV-A, Shahdara, who was the owner through Sale Deed dated 10.05.2019 executed by Mr. Ram Saran Aggarwal vide Doc. No. 2692. That Original prior chain documents i.e. Sale Deed dated 28.03.2012 executed by Mr. Dhan Pal Singh in favour of M/s. Ladli Ji Associates through (Doc. No. 1312) and Sale Deed dated 05.12.2012 executed by M/s. Ladli Ji Associates in favour of Mr. Ram Saran Aggarwal (Doc. No. 6112) are lost and not traceable. An F.I.R. has been lodged by Mr. Shivam Gupta on 25.07.2026, PS. Nand Nagri, North East/Crime Branch vide LR No. 479558/2026. Any person(s), institution(s) finds the same is requested to send to the above mentioned address.
Any person(s), institution(s) having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 07days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claim, of such person(s)/ institution(s) shall not be binding upon the said property or Kotak Mahindra Bank Ltd.

Mohd K. Hussain (Advocate)
D-21, Basement, Block-D, Jangpura Extn, New Delhi-110014, 8810391672

PUBLIC NOTICE

I AM CONCERNED ON BEHALF OF MY CLIENTS, SHRI SURENDRA KUMAR JAIN, S/O, LATE RATI RAM JAIN, AGED ABOUT 78 YEARS, AND SMT. KAMLA JAIN, WIFE OF SHRI SURENDRA KUMAR JAIN AGED ABOUT 72 YEARS BOTH PRESENTLY R/O. K-205, GOLF VIEW CONDOS, SECTOR-19B, DWARKA, DELHI-110075, AM HEREBY AUTHORISED TO ISSUE THE PUBLIC NOTICE FOR DEBARRING THEIR SON NAMELY CHIRAG JAIN AND HIS WIFE MANISHA SHUKLA BOTH R/O, B-602, KARTIK KUNJ, SECTOR -44, NOIDA GAUTAM BUDH NAGAR-201303, UTTAR PRADESH AND ALSO HIS DIVORCED WIFE KAVITA RAJPUT AND CHILDREN FROM DIVORCED WIFE NAMELY TWARA JAIN (DAUGHTER) AND UTSAV JAIN (SON) FOR DEBBARING THEM FROM THEIR PROPERTY AND ASSETS. BOTH MOVABLE AND IMMOVABLE, AND I AM INSTRUCTED TO NOTIFY TO ALL CONCERNS WITH IMMEDIATE EFFECT THAT MY ABOVE MENTIONED CLIENTS DISOWN THEIR SON, DAUGHTER-IN-LAWS AND GRAND-CHILDREN FOR DEBBARING THEM FROM THEIR PROPERTY AND ASSETS, BOTH MOVABLE AND IMMOVABLE. FOR DEBARRING THEM AND HAVE SOVEREIGN ALL THE RELATIONS AND CONNECTIONS WITH RESPECT TO ANY MANNER FROM THEIR SON, DAUGHTER-IN-LAWS AND GRAND-CHILDREN AND THE SAME HAVE NO CONNECTION IN ANY MANNER WITH THE ESTATE/ASSETS/BUSINESS OF MY ABOVE MENTIONED CLIENTS AND MY ABOVE MENTIONED CLIENTS SHALL NOT BE RESPONSIBLE FOR ANY ACTS, DEEDS AND THINGS DONE BY THEM.
IT IS FURTHER SAID THAT NOBODY DEALS WITH THEIR SON, DAUGHTER-IN-LAWS AND GRAND-CHILDREN FOR DEBBARING THEM FROM THEIR PROPERTY AND ASSETS, BOTH MOVABLE AND IMMOVABLE AND IF ANYBODY DEALT WITH THEM SHALL DOING THE SAME AT THEIR OWN RISK AND COST AND MY ABOVE MENTIONED CLIENTS ARE NOT RESPONSIBLE FOR ANY ACTS, DEEDS OR THINGS DONE BY THEIR SON, DAUGHTER-IN-LAWS AND GRAND-CHILDREN FOR DEBBARING THEM FROM THEIR PROPERTY AND ASSETS, BOTH MOVABLE AND IMMOVABLE, WHATSOEVER

Sd/-
MANISH MIGLANI
Advocate
Ch. No. 699, Patiala House Courts, New Delhi-110001

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it knows to all that my client namely Abdul Wahid S/o Abdul Majeed R/o J-506, Shakurpur Colony, North-West Delhi-110034, hereby disowns and disinherit his younger son namely Azizur Rehman and his wife Samreen Naaz from all of his moveable and immoveable properties and also severe his all relations from the said Azizur Rehman due to his unwanted behaviour/ acts and anti-social conducts towards my client. My client will not be responsible for any acts, deeds things done by him. In future whosoever, whatsoever deals in any manner with him they may do so at their own free will and responsibilities. My client will not be responsible for him or any act done by him.

ABDUL KADIR SAIFI, ADVOCATE
DELHI HIGH COURT, Ch. No. 604 A, Ist Floor, Western Wing, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

Call or WhatsApp 9717006820 to advertise on classified page
The Indian EXPRESS — JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Smt. Rasmuni Devi W/o Lt. Sh. Madan Manjhi R/o H.No.-99-A and 27, Gali No-25, Near Pradhan Vatika Village Baprola, Prashant Enclave, Bapraula Delhi-110043 severe all relations & debar her son Sh. Dhanjeet Kumar S/o Lt. Sh. Madan Manjhi and her daughter in law Smt. Laxmi W/o Dhanjeet Kumar and her grandsons namely Master Laksh and Master Kiyan from all movable- immovable property(s) due to their misconduct & misbehavior. My client will not be responsible for any of their acts in future whatsoever.

Ankit Rana (Advocate)
Ch. No. 807, Rohini Courts, Delhi

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. ELG-10-J07-2026-27 — Date : 23.07.2026

E-Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) N.C. Railway, Agra on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Tender No.: ELG-10-J07-2026-27, **Name of work with its location & Completion Period:** Electrification work in connection with Raising of 02 nos. platform to high level for recoupment of shortfall in Minimum Essential Amenities (MEA) at JREA under MTJ-AWR section.

Approx. Cost of the work : ₹ 42,82,079.45 — **Completion Period :** 08 Months

(1) For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in (2) Tenders can only be submitted through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on 17.08.2026. 1698/26 (MG)

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Rajesh Anand, R/o** KD-49, Pitampura, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC No. 3939/17,3936/17,3938/17, U/s: 138 NI ACT, PS: Shalimar Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Rajesh Anand,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Rajesh Anand,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Rajesh Anand,** of **CC No. 3939/17,3936/17,3938/17, U/s: 138 NI ACT, PS: Shalimar Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Aakanksha
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Room No. 107, 1st Floor North West District
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/10123/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

ARTIFICIAL LIMBS MANUFACTURING CORPORATION OF INDIA

(A Govt. of India Undertaking)
G.T. Road, Kanpur-209217
Visit us: www.alimco.in
Phone- +91 79852 03608.

OPEN TENDER NOTICE

Online Bids (Technical & Price Bid) are invited for Renovation & Construction Works as per details indicated below:

Bid number	Category of Items	Qty.	Approx. Value (Rs.)	Due Date of Opening
PT/OT/03/ BE, Dated: 22.07.2026	Renovation and Modification of the Existing Assembly Shop into an e-Scooty Assembly Facility at ALIMCO, Kanpur Nagar	01 Job	Rs. 58,49,054.00 (Including GST)	13.08.2026

Interested Tenderers may download the tender document from ALIMCO website www.alimco.in (for reference only) and CPPP website https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app.
Tenderers are requested to submit their Offers/Bids through E-Tendering Process only on CPP website. The Technical Bid will be Opened on as indicated above. ALIMCO reserves the right to reject any or all requests/Offers without assigning any reason.
Note: For any corrigendum in the tender, Tenderers may please visit CPP portal and ALIMCO web-site.

For ALIMCO DGM (Projects)

PUBLIC NOTICE
GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
EXCISE & TAXATION DEPARTMENT

NOTICE FOR INVITING e-TENDERS FROM GENERAL PUBLIC FOR REALLOTMENT OF TWO ZONES OF RETAIL LIQUOR VENDS OF DISTRICT GURUGRAM (EAST) AND GURUGRAM (WEST) IN THE STATE OF HARYANA FOR THE REMAINING PERIOD OF THE EXCISE POLICY YEAR 2025-2027.

1. It is hereby notified for the information of the general public that e-tenders are invited for the re-allotment of Zone No. ZGRE13 and Zone No. ZGRW04 comprising of retail liquor vends of Country Liquor (CL) and Indian Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) (L-2/L-14A) in District Gurugram (East) and District Gurugram (West), respectively, in the State of Haryana, for the remaining period of the Excise Policy Year 2025–2027.
2. The schedule for submission of e-bids for the above said zones and evaluation there of shall be as under:-

Starting date and time for placing e-tenders	From 26th July, 2026 (9.00 A.M)
Closing date and time for placing e-tenders	Till 28th July, 2026 (04.00 P.M)
Evaluation of e-tenders	28th July, 2026 (5.00 PM)

3. The reserve price of these zones for the purpose of e-tendering has been decided as per the provisions of clause 2.17 and other relevant provisions of the Haryana Excise Policy 2025-27.
The reserve price and quota of these zones shall be displayed in the excise arrangement.
4. The e-tenders for these zones can be submitted online through the official website of the department i.e. www.haryanatax.gov.in. The remaining terms and conditions of e-tenders and allotment of zones shall be same, as informed vide the Public Notice, published in leading newspapers on 21st May, 2025, for inviting e-tenders for allotment of retail liquor zones of all districts in the State of Haryana. The copy of Public Notice dated 21st May, 2025 is also available on the official website of department i.e. www.haryanatax.gov.in. The detailed procedure of registration for participation in the allotment process and submission of e-tenders is also available on the official website.
5. The excise arrangements of these zones containing number of vends, liquor quota, location of vends, command area as applicable and reserve price thereof, as well as the venue for evaluation of e-tenders shall be conspicuously displayed in the office of DETCs (Excise) and DETCs (ST) of the district concerned. These details shall also be available on the official website i.e. www.haryanatax.gov.in.
6. The re-allotment of these zones shall be done at the risk and cost of original allottee. The original allottee shall be liable to make up any deficiency incurred by the State as a result of the re-allotment of these zones.
7. The allotment and grant of licence shall be subject to the provisions of the Haryana Excise Act, 1914, the rules framed thereunder, orders/instructions issued by the competent authority and the Excise Policy for the year 2025-27. Any clarification regarding the procedure may be obtained from the office of DETCs (Excise) of any of the districts in the State. The copy of Haryana Excise Policy for the year 2025-27 is available on official website of the department.
7. The allotment shall be subject to the approval of the Excise and Taxation Commissioner (FC), Haryana. He may reject, without assigning any reason, any allotment in public interest as the case may be, within 10 days of the date of allotment.

VINAY PRATAP SINGH, IAS
Excise and Taxation Commissioner,
Haryana, Panchkula.

No. 47513/HRY

सिंचाई विभाग उत्तराखण्ड
कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता सिंचाई कार्य मण्डल, ऊधमसिंहनगर

रूद्रपुर- 263153, E-mail: iwcusn@gmail.com

पत्रांक: 1996 / सिकामउ/टी-1/ — **दिनांक :** 25 जुलाई, 2026

ई-निविदा सूचना सं0-04/एस०ई०/2026-27

मा० राज्यपाल महोदय, उत्तराखण्ड की ओर से जनपद उधमसिंह नगर के रूद्रपुर (लागत रू0 391.69 करोड़) काशीपुर (लागत रू0 199.18 करोड़) सितारगंज (लागत रू0 142.00 करोड़) एवं खटीमा (लागत रू0 280.00 करोड़) शहरों में वर्षाजल निकासी हेतु जी०आई०एस० बेस्ड मास्टर ड्रेनेज प्लान की 04 संख्या योजनाओं के कार्य हेतु टू-बिड सिस्टम के तहत् केन्द्र एवं राज्य सरकार के विभिन्न विभागों में श्रेणी 'ए' एवं उच्चतर श्रेणी (कार्य की लागत के अनुसार) में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों / फर्मों से निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

निविदा के विस्तृत विवरणों को ई-प्रोक्यूरमेन्ट पोर्टल https://uktenders.gov.in पर दिनांक 30.07.2026 समय अपरान्ह 04:00 बजे से देखा जा सकता है।

हस्ता/-
(प्रमोद कुमार दीक्षित)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

कार्यालय-अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग, मेरठ परिमण्डल मेरठ,

अपर आयुक्त उद्योग परिसर, सूरजकुन्ड रोड, मेरठ।

पत्रांक- 739 / ग्रा०अ०वि०/ निविदा-पत्रा0/2026-27, — दिनांक:- 16-07-2026

-:: ई-प्रोक्योरमेन्ट निविदा सूचना ::-

1- महामहिम श्री राज्यपाल उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग मेरठ परिमण्डल मेरठ के द्वारा ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेष में कार्यो की लागत सीमा के अनुरूप (कालम संख्या-8 के अनुसार) पंजीकृत निविदाताओं से ई-टेण्डरिंग के माध्यम से प्रतिषत दर के आधार पर नीचे दर्षायें गये कार्य हेतु निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। बिड डाक्यूमेन्ट के साथ संलग्न बिल ऑफ क्वान्टिटी के अंकित दरों में जी०एस०टी० के अतिरिक्त अन्य सभी कर सम्मिलित है, जी०एस०टी० का भुगतान सरकार के निदेर्षानुसार नियमानुसार अलग से किया जायेगा। निविदादाता से अपेक्षा की जाती है कि निविदा डालने से पूर्व निविदा प्रपत्रों में अंकित एस०बी०डी० के अन्तर्गत न्यूनतम अर्हता के सम्बन्ध में शर्तो का भली भाँति अध्ययन कर लें।

2- कार्य से संबंधित विवरण निम्नवत है :-

क्र० सं०	जनपद का नाम	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत (लाख में) जी.एस.टी. सहित	धरोहर धनराशि (ई०एम०डी०) (लाख में)	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य+ स्टेशनरी+ जी०एस०टी० (रू० में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि (वर्षा ऋतु सहित)	ठेकेदार के पंजीयन की श्रेणी
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1	गौतमबुद्धनगर	जनपद गौतमबुद्धनगर के राजपत्रित अधिकारियों हेतु अपर पुलिस अधीक्षक/पुलिस उपाधीक्षक स्तर के 17 आवासो के निर्माण कार्य।	1171.00	23.42	2714.00	18 माह	श्रेणी 'ए' (भवन)

3-वैबसाईट पर बिड डाक्यूमेन्ट डाउनलोडींग प्रारम्भ करने की तिथि एवं समय 17.08.2026 प्रातः 10:00 बजे से।
4- प्री बिड मीटिंग की तिथि एवं समय दिनांक 18.08.2026 दोपहर 11:00 बजें।
बैठक हेतु स्थल- कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग, मेरठ परिमण्डल, मेरठ।
5-ई-निविदा के माध्यम से निविदा डालने की प्रारम्भ तिथि एवं समय 17.08.2026 प्रातः 10:00 बजे से।
6-ई-निविदा के माध्यम से निविदा प्राप्ति की अन्तिम तिथि एवं समय 26.08.2026 अपरान्ह 04:00 बजे तक।
7-ई-निविदा के माध्यम से निविदा खोलन की तिथि एवं समय 27.08.2026 दोपहर 12:30 बजें।
8-टेण्डर प्रक्रिया से पूर्व का कोई शपथ पत्र मान्य नही होगा।
9-निविदा आनलाईन वैबसाईट http//etender.up.nic.in पर उपलब्ध होगी एवं इसी साईट पर डाली जाएगी।
10-निविदा आमंत्रणकर्ता को आईटीबी के क्लॉज 10 के अनुसार परिशिष्ट / शुद्धि पत्र जारी करने का अधिकार है जो किसी भी समाचार पत्र में प्रकाषित नही किया जायेगा। सभी संभावित निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वह नियमित रूप से ई-निविदा पोर्टल पर निगरानी रखें। अधिक जानकारी के लिये कृपया वैबसाईट पर लॉग इन करें तथा बिड डाक्यूमेन्ट को डाउनलोड करें।

(विनोद कुमार)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,
ग्रामीण अभियन्त्रण विभाग,
मेरठ परिमण्डल मेरठ।

UPID-254089 Date: 24/07/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, Kanpur Municipal Corporation, Kanpur

Letter No.: D/88/CE/CMGJ/2026-27 — **Date- 24/07/2026**

E-TENDER NOTICE

Kanpur Municipal Corporation invites online e-tenders from eligible bidders for the following work under the Chief Minister Urban Infrastructure Development Scheme (CM-VNY) for civic services and infrastructure development.
E-Tender Website: https://etender.up.nic.in

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (excl. 18% GST) (₹ Lakh)	EMD (₹ Lakh)	Completion (Months)	Tender Fee (with 18% GST)
1	Establishment and upgradation of Smart Classes at the Municipal Corporation-run A.N.D. Women's Degree College, Brahm Nagar, and Higher Secondary School, Sarvodaya Nagar, Kanpur.	643.99	12.88	90	₹ 10,000.00

Timeline for Tender

S.No.		Date & Time
1	Download/Start of E-Tender	27/07/2026, 03:00 PM
2	Last Date & Time for Submission	07/08/2026, 03:00 PM
3	Opening of E-Tender	07/08/2026, 04:00 PM

All tender documents, terms & conditions, rules, and other details are available on the Kanpur Municipal Corporation website kmc.up.nic.in and the e-Procurement portal https://etender.up.nic.in from 27/07/2026.
The payment of the Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) and Tender Fee shall be made online only through the e-tender portal.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer,
Kanpur Municipal Corporation

यूको बैंक UCO BANK

भारत सरकार का उपक्रम (A Govt. of India Undertaking) — Branch Office : Vidhan Sabha, Shimla

[RULE-8(1)] POSSESSION NOTICE (FOR MOVABLE/IMMOVABLE PROPERTY)

Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the **UCO Bank, Vidhan Sabha,** Under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued a Demand Notice calling upon the following borrowers to repay the amount mentioned in notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The borrower/ Guarantor having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken **Symbolic Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him / her under Sub Section 4 of Section 13 of the said Act read with Rule (4,8 & 9) of the Security Interest Enforcement Rule 2002.

The borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with property will be subject to the charge of **UCO Bank**, **Vidhan Sabha,** for the amount mentioned here in below against Account.

Owners/occupiers of the property(ies) are also notified to handover vacant actual physical possession to the undersigned within 30 days to avoid use of force u/s 14 of the act with the assistance of District Magistrate.

The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub section 8 of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured asset

And in case the borrower(s)/guarantor(s) do not pay back the dues, the property (ies) shall be sold, as prescribed under the act, to recover Bank's dues.

Name of the Borrower /Guarantor	Description of Movable/ Immovable Property	Date of Demand Notice Issued	Date of Symbolic Possession Notice	Amount of Notice
Borrower : 1. M/s 31 Parallel IT and BPO Solutions Private Limited, Vishwanath Bhawan, Ground Floor, Kasumpti, Shimla, (H.P.)-171009 **Directors : 1. Mr. Vivek Parmar** S/o Kush Parmar, Resident of Gautam Niwas, Katcha Talab, Ward No. 01, Nahan, (H.P.)-173001. **2. Mr. Karan Pal Singh Chauhan** S/o Harish Pal Chauhan, Resident of Bhagwati Niwas, Below Oak Over, Near Port More School, Shimla, (H.P.)-171001. **Guarantor(s) : 1. Mrs. Vandana Gupta** W/o Kapil Kumar Resident of Flat No. 47, Phase II, Delhi Raod, Mansarovar Garden, Meerut, UP-250002. **2. Mr. Vivek Parmar** S/o Kush Parmar, Resident of Gautam Niwas, Katcha Talab, Ward No-01, Nahan, (H.P.)-173001. **3. Mr. Karan Pal Singh Chauhan** S/o Harish Pal Chauhan, Resident of Bhagwati Niwas, Near Oak Over Shimla, (H.P.)-171001. **4. Lt. Ms. Satya Parmar W/o Kush Parmar (Deceased) through is legal heirs : 1. Mr. Vivek Parmar** S/o Kush Parmar, **2. Mr. Kush Parmar** S/o Lt. Sh. Y.S Parmar. **3. Mr.Chetan Parmar** S/o Kush Parmar, All Resident of Gautam Niwas, Katcha Talab, Ward No-01, Nahan, (H.P.)-173001.	**Property : 1.** Mortgage of Property i.e. Entire Ground Floor measuring 132.36 Square meter and parking space measuring 25.44 Square meter in the parking floor of (Four storied + Parking) building Known as 'Vishwanath Bhawan' Built upon part of Land Comprised in Khasra Number 227,228,229 & 230 Measuring 273.00 Square meter under khata Khatoni Number 5/10 (New), Khata Khatoni no. 2/3 to 9 Kita 31 (Old) and situated at Mohal Kasumpti Chabroti, Patwar Circle- Kasumpti, Tehsil-Shimla (Rural),Near Parimahal, District Shimla owned by Lt. Mrs. Satya Parmar W/o Kush Parmar. **(Symbolic Possession Notice Pasted on 23.07.2026).** **Property : 2.** Mortgage of residential Flat No.47 First Floor Measuring 134.44 Square yard i.e. 109.90 Square meter part of khasra No.106 Situated in Mansarovar Garden, Phase -II, Revenue Village Mohkampur, Pargana, Tehsil & District- Meerut, U.P.-250002, Owned by Mrs. Vandana Gupta w/o Kapil Kumar Gupta. Boundary : **East:** 7 Meters. Thereafter 9 Meters Wide Road, **West-** 7 Meters. Thereafter Plot No.56, **North:** 15.70 Meters. Thereafter 3 Meters wide Road, **South-** 15.70 meters. Thereafter plot No. 48. **(Symbolic PossessionNotice Pasted on 24.07.2026).**	14.05.2026	23.07.2026	Rs. 2,68,89,366.45 (Rupees Two Crore Sixty Eight Lakhs Eighty Nine Thousand Three Hundred Sixty Six Paisa Forty Five Only) as on 01.04.2026, with further interest & other charges accrued thereon after 01.04.2026 (Less repayments if any).

Date: 26.07.2026 — **Place : Shimla** — **AUTHORISED OFFICER**

A 'golden' fix for India's forex stress?

OFF THE RECORD
BY P VAIDYANATHAN IYER

THERE IS a tricky proposal engaging the government at the highest levels over the past 3-4 weeks. An empowered group of ministers has met twice to discuss it. Officials in the Prime Minister's Office are seized of the issues connected with this idea. And the Cabinet Secretariat, the office responsible for government administration, has held meetings with those in the business to better understand the concerns, and ways to address them.

The thought behind the proposal probably has its origins in an austerity measure proposed by the PM at a public meeting in Hyderabad on May 10. In the backdrop of the West Asian crisis that led to a surge in oil prices, Modi had urged people to refrain from buying gold during festivals for a year, besides conserving fuel, restricting foreign travels, etc. The proposal, which has generated some interest among the few who are privy to it, is to launch a voluntary gold disclosure scheme. The idea seems to be to collect gold lying idle in private hands — that is, what people accumulated over the years for 'investment' (bars, coins), not what they bought for 'consumption' (jewellery) — and put it to use to reduce imports, and preserve foreign exchange.

In India, gold has huge sentimental value, has cultural and religious connections; but it has also been leveraged by governments during emergencies, be it during wars or economic crises. Most recently, in the early 1990s, when India faced an economic crisis, the government and the Reserve Bank of India saw a 'golden' opportunity. To bolster the country's forex, the RBI was fully on board when the State Bank of India pledged 20 tonnes of gold confiscated from smugglers with the Union Bank of Switzerland in May 1991 to raise about $200 million. But this wasn't enough.

With forex reserves plummeting to just $1.1 billion in June, barely enough to pay for 2-3 weeks of essential imports, the RBI proposed pledging 50 tonnes of gold to raise foreign exchange. This was approved by the caretaker government led by Chandra Shekhar, but executed post general elections by the new government under Prime Minister PV Narasimha Rao and his Finance Minister, Manmohan Singh. As much as 46.91 tonnes was pledged to raise $405 million; this too was paid back in less than four months.

These may look small today, given that India imports more than 700 million tonnes of gold a year, and its forex reserves are robust at over $675 billion. But the crisis was acute then, and this one drastic measure kickstarted the process of economic reforms that continues till date with some jerks, but has overall bipartisan political support.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F

ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

> With forex reserves plummeting to just $1.1 billion in June, barely enough to pay for 2-3 weeks of essential imports, the RBI proposed pledging 50 tonnes of gold to raise foreign exchange

Two years later, in 1993, as India became a bit comfortable on the forex front, it sought to bolster its gold reserves. The government experimented with an idea to bring private and unaccounted gold into the formal economy. It issued the Gold Bonds (Immunities and Exemptions) Ordinance, 1993, and, drawing from it, announced the Gold Bonds Scheme. The bonds had a five-year tenure, and after five years, subscribers were paid Rs 40 per gram lump-sum interest, along with the gold deposited. A subscriber was required to deposit a minimum of 500 grams under the scheme, which was open for two months. The biggest draw was it asked no questions from the subscribers about the nature and source of gold, or the money used to buy the gold. It also promised the government would not start any inquiry or investigation against the subscribers. In all, the total gold received under the scheme was 41.12 metric tonnes, valued at Rs 1,534.40 crore.

Thirty-three years later, in May 2026, India faces a different gold problem. The West Asia crisis is not of the government's making, but is exerting pressure on the Indian economy, and magnifying its vulnerabilities. India imports bulk of its crude oil needs; crude oil prices have once again topped $100 a barrel, which means India's import bill will soar. This can't be avoided. But what can be is the massive gold imports, which only worsens the current account deficit (when the money spent on imports is more than the money earned from exports, it leads to a deficit).

Sajjid Chinoy, a part-time member of the Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council, points out that gold demand has remained largely intact (over 720 tonnes) despite a more than doubling of prices in the last three years. A research by him and his colleagues for JP Morgan says 50% of this demand in January-March 2026 was for investment (in gold bars and coins). In January-March 2003, it was just 30%.

The biggest factor that made the Gold Bond Scheme of 1993 a success was the government immunity to subscribers. But that required taxpayers, individuals and corporations to have trust in the system. Here, many in the government agree, there is considerable work to be done. But there are other options to explore too on increasing the attractiveness of a financial product linked to gold.

It's a 'golden' problem to solve.

The writer is Managing Editor, The Indian Express. Off the Record is a fortnightly column

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The cockroaches are right

FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

PARADOXICAL AND a little thrilling that it was a slapdash bunch of young Indians and not the opposition parties who brought the Prime Minister to his knees. On Saturday, just as this column was going to press, the PM finally persuaded the Education Minister to resign. He was the rotten symbol of a rotting education system and had to go. But, by taking his time, he may have done India a favour. As for the Prime Minister, all he has offered is a stringent new law which he has told us was stringent at least five times before. Not good enough.

Here I must point out that the Leader of the Opposition is delusional when he says that before Modi became Prime Minister the Indian education system was the envy of the world. It was not. Indian children who could not afford private schools were dependent on a school system that let them down from kindergarten to the time they graduated from high school. BJP chief ministers control most large Indian states and should have been able to transform schools but did not. Their priorities have been rewriting history to exalt ancient India and rubbish the Moghul period. And to exalt India's achievements since Modi became Prime Minister. This is a subject for another day.

Today let us talk about what the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) has achieved with its Jantar Mantar protest. It has now spread to cities and small towns across India. As one of those who gauged that the cockroaches could become huge right from the start, I spent an afternoon in Jantar Mantar a few days before the big march to Parliament last week. I wanted to see if BJP 'intellectuals' with considerable influence in higher echelons were right to dismiss the cockroaches as anarchists and activists. They were wrong.

The young people I talked to that afternoon had genuine grievances and should have been listened to long before the whole world discovered that young Indians believe that the system (the establishment) has let them down and that their future is bleak. The demand for the education minister's resignation was a desperate cry for accountability, and it is a shame that the Prime Minister does not see this.

Meanwhile, if you observe what has been happening in Jantar Mantar, as I have, you will notice that the young people who continue to flock there in support of the CJP are interested in a better idea of India. They sing *Vande Mataram* and the national anthem raucously as if to show Modi's BJP that they do not have a copyright on nationalism. Hindus of all castes seem to have no problem in eating together and from the hands of Muslims, Christians and Sikhs as if to show that the India in which we all once lived in relative harmony still exists. Since Modi became Prime Minister, we have seen too many attempts to damage this harmony, sometimes in the name of cows and sometimes by banging on about temples and religion.

Those who have objected to this excessive religiosity and aggressive nationalism have been branded Pakistanis and anti-nationals by the self-appointed custodians of the Hindutva ideology. If you watched the coverage of the protests by the 'independent' TV channels last week, you would have noticed that certain anchors who also behave as if they are guardians of Hindutva nationalism ranted on about the 'foreign hand'. Eminent lawyers gave interviews filled with doomsday warnings about how India's 'rise' is not popular with certain big powers. The question we should ask is what 'rise'? Would so many thousands of young Indians have taken to the streets in protest last week if they believed that their lives had improved in Modi's time? The truth is that millions of middle-class Indians were for a while lulled into a sense of false security by the number of new roads, highways, ports and airports that have been built in the past twelve years, but now they have noticed that these have not benefited them personally.

They remain trapped in a vicious cycle of poverty, from which they try to escape by becoming doctors, lawyers, engineers and computer scientists, only to find that when they pass their examinations, they are trapped in a new vicious cycle in search of jobs. They are usually unqualified for jobs in the private sector, so they depend on government jobs, and these have become scarcer by the day. Those who can afford to emigrate become economic refugees in rich western countries, where the standard of living allows ordinary middle-class people to live comfortable and dignified lives.

Speaking for myself, I would like to say that I totally support the cockroaches and understand their pain and anger. It is my fervent hope that the CJP turns itself into a political party before the next general election and shows the BJP that it is up against a new kind of politician who does not come from the entitlement and privilege that most of the opposition leaders come from. India needs new younger faces in politics and governance so that we get beyond that increasingly tedious choice between secularism and Hindutva. Both words have lost all meaning, as we can see from how 'secular' defectors become rabidly communal upon joining the BJP.

INSIDE TRACK | BY COOMI KAPOOR

POLITICS' WATERSHED MOMENT

It was a watershed moment in Indian politics, thanks to Gen Z. Traditional politicians, including Rahul Gandhi, have been left behind and are clambering onto the bandwagon of spirited, faceless youngsters. The Modi government's grand design to push through its agenda of securing a two-thirds majority in Parliament in this session has stalled, not because its cynical game of accumulating MPs who have lost their moral compass has misfired, but because of the power of a spontaneous movement, which has captured the country's imagination and sympathy, cutting across economic strata and traditional ideologies. Even the BJP's elder statesman, Murli Manohar Joshi, voiced his support. The free-spirited harbingers of change, with their irrelevant memes and catchy Instagram reels, have outshone the traditional media — constrained by market compulsions and distribution networks. A section of television journalists were booed and booted out of the protest epicentre at Jantar Mantar.

A leaderless mob does not act in tandem. Akhilesh Yadav indicated Congress should not speak on behalf of all opposition before consultations. Sonam Wangchuk's wife, Gitanjali, questioned the motives of both Rahul Gandhi and the BJP. AAP leaders dubbed the Congress the BJP's B-team, accusing it of opportunistically entering the campaign. Chandra Shekhar Aazad's party workers boasted they were ahead of others in tearing down police barricades to make way for the students. The CJP's self-effacing spokespersons voiced no fear of being overshadowed and welcomed support from all quarters. But they are probably conscious that even they have no total command over the disparate sea of humanity. In his puzzling adamancy in not removing Dharmendra Pradhan, a non-negotiable demand of the protesters, Prime Minister Modi put both his government and personal reputation on the line. Eventually, however, better sense prevailed. The PM perhaps recalled the lessons of history. Even Jawaharlal Nehru perforce agreed to Krishna Menon quitting his Cabinet, Indira Gandhi reluctantly acceded to the students' demand for Gujarat Chief Minister Chimanbhai Patel's resignation, and Atal Bihari Vajpayee requested George Fernandes to step down as defence minister.

FORERUNNER TO SECOND DEPARTURE?

Former BJP Tamil Nadu President K Annamalai's exit from the party last month is believed to be a forerunner to B L Santhosh — the BJP's powerful national general secretary (organisation) and coordinator between the RSS and the party — being marginalised. Annamalai, a former IPS officer, was Santhosh's protégé and appointed party president in 2021. The newbie's brash political confidence turned out to be totally off the mark, as proved by the BJP's disastrous electoral performance in this year's state assembly poll. Removed as BJP president last year, Annamalai claims he left the party of his own volition, but insiders recall a stormy meeting with Home Minister Amit Shah in Delhi before he quit.

WATCH YOUR EXPLANATION

It was a brief birthday party for Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge on Tuesday. After the cake was cut at his home, Rahul Gandhi informed the astonished host and unprepared guests that they would all march to the PM's residence nearby to stage a *dharna* in support of the students. Karnataka CM D K Shivakumar was present, but Kerala CM V D Satheesan, who was in Delhi, had to be hastily summoned to Lok Kalyan Marg. Satheesan was noticeably tight-lipped during the slogan-shouting and flew back to Kerala soon after. Questioned by scribes back home about his abrupt departure from the capital, Satheesan claimed that Rahul Gandhi had pointed at his wristwatch and asked him to rush to the airport, else he would miss his flight. The only snag is that Gandhi does not wear a watch!

REEL TIMELINE STORY

It is hardly coincidental that controversial films with a political message, such as *Udta Punjab, Kerala Story* and *Kashmir Files*, were released shortly before an assembly poll in the states concerned. In each case, the film's theme discredited the BJP's rival parties. Similarly, *Satluj* has gone viral before next year's Punjab assembly polls. The movie was held up for three years by the CBFC, which demanded 127 cuts. But this month, the uncensored film was released on Zee 5 Global on the plea that OTT platforms are not certified by the CBFC. Although the film was removed within two days, by this time, as to be expected, the film's link had gone viral. The autobiography of Zee TV's pragmatic businessman-owner, Subhash Chandra, makes clear that his motto is to respect the wishes of the government of the day. And sceptics believe the movie's release was unlikely without a nod from the powers that be.

Jantar Mantar was crowded, yet I breathed freely

TRISHA MUKHERJEE

IT IS 2015. I am in Old Delhi's Sadar Bazar two days before Holi, speaking to a seller for a story. As the dense crowd kicks up dust, I lean in to listen to my interviewee better. A hand gropes me from behind. I turn around. It happens again, this time from the front. I feel disoriented, lose the thread of conversation with the seller and start walking towards the metro.

In the metro, I grab a seat and once the coach is empty enough, call up a friend to share what happened. He suggests I speak to a senior female editor. It may make me feel better. I think, and decide against it.

I was 22. Barely one year into the profession, and less than two months into that particular job. Talking felt like making a bigger deal out of it than it actually was. Did it even qualify as harassment? What if it was all just in my head?

It was in my head, all right. For over a decade. I just didn't know.

What I knew was I avoided crowded places. It wasn't simply discomfort. My body physically stiffened up. A few years later, I was assigned another story in a heavily populated neighbourhood. My first instinct was to say 'no'. I didn't, but for the four hours I was reporting there, I felt like I couldn't breathe.

The irony is not lost on me. I am a culture journalist and yet, have avoided going to cultural hotspots that are often crowded, for as long as I can remember — with friends, on food walks, to historical sites. That was my way of managing what I had come to understand as a fear of crowded places.

I had it under control until December 2019, when I was at the Singhu border covering the farmers' protest. I had successfully managed to spend the entire day reporting. That was a victory. As I was making my way back from one end of the site to the other, the crowd began moving to make arrangements for the night. Nothing untoward happened, but I suddenly struggled to breathe and fell to the ground in tears. I wanted to tell my editors I didn't want to go back but decided against it. I returned several times afterwards, incident-free, yet I always remained on edge.

Protesters throng the Jantar Mantar road GAJENDRA YADAV

Cut to this past week. The news of the young students protesting at Jantar Mantar had taken over my Instagram feed and my mind. I knew I wanted to visit the site but needed to keep the exit flexible, so I didn't pitch a story. But it happened anyway, and on the muggy morning of July 21, I found myself walking down the Jantar Mantar road looking for a story. As I saw people walking ahead and behind me, the crowd only swelling with every step, I felt my limbs tightening. If it wasn't for the story, I would have turned around and left. The serpentine queue, protesters sloganeering, journalists reporting, the police standing guard with their lathis — all became a dizzying blur. I planted myself into the line that moved at a tedious pace. People, quite literally, were pressed against each other and yet, somehow there was space. I moved forward with the queue's flow. It felt like I was being crowd-surfed at a concert, instead of being forcefully dragged. And I breathed — a full breath. I moved around the site, spoke to people, did my job and left. For the first time, I did not escape a crowd.

A day later, I was telling a colleague about the protest, "It was packed, and yet I felt so safe." Even as the words left my mouth, like an epiphany, the afternoon at Sadar Bazar flashed in front of my eyes like a ghost I had been trying to outrun. I realised that while I remembered being afraid of crowded places, I couldn't pinpoint the moment it all began.

That was a breakthrough moment. The fear that had shaped my every outing in the past decade suddenly made sense. It also made me understand the idea of 'safe space'. It can be a person, a relationship, a location, but what makes it 'safe' is the choice it offers. Unlike other crowded places, where I felt a frantic urge to leave, the protest at Jantar Mantar made me feel secure enough to stay for as long as I wanted, leave at my own will, and then return. It was a luxury that, until recently, I thought I couldn't afford.

It's not that I am no longer afraid of crowds. It's just that I, perhaps, won't mind taking a chance, hoping the next crowd will pleasantly surprise me. And for that hope, I am thankful to the protesters at Jantar Mantar.

The writer is Associate Editor, The Indian Express

How to be a dissident

ON THE LOOSE
BY LEHER KALA

WHEN I was still in school in 1990, 20-something Rajeev Goswami, studying in Delhi University, poured oil and set himself on fire amid a crowd of supporters. Like many other upper-caste students at the time, Goswami was protesting the proposed 27 percent quota for backward classes in government jobs. His shocking act — self-immolation — won sympathy all around, triggering a spate of similar, horrifying suicides but an anti-reservation movement was bound to fail. Morally, it's hard to disagree with affirmative action to rectify historical wrongs that have kept so many crores disenfranchised by casteism. Still, it took courage to take a stance for his own lot, who, despite caste privilege, were struggling to get by as well. Goswami died in his 30s, in obscurity, his sacrifice a footnote in contemporary Indian history.

There's no heroic recklessness — Goswami-style — going on at Jantar Mantar right now; rather, a range of polite and steely-eyed youth staying put, speaking their minds and sometimes jeering at the powers that be. Since we're in the season of civil disobedience it is worth asking, is there a specifically right way or perfect cause, to rebel against? At its core, rebellion is recognised as a righteous assertion of human rights when faced with societal ills. The abiding principle is that we need freedom which broadens what we can do and justice, which limits what others can do to us. If we agree that to hurt others for a cause is wrong, outright self-destruction like Goswami's is lamentable, too. Alas, in the world of the nihilist force is the only law. But the teen suicides post the NEET exam leak occurred from a place of genuine anguish — parents go into debt paying for tuition and students spend painstaking years cramming the syllabus. That crushing blow to their ambitions has stirred the passions of an angry generation, which, in turn, has changed how older Indians suddenly view Gen Z — with compassion and respect.

The grand Indian upper-middle-class aim has always been to lead a relatively unrestricted life which means being as removed from political turmoil as possible. We design our careers to maximise personal autonomy, the best armour against a whimsical State. Somewhere, our children imbibe that it's wise in India to steer clear of controversy of any kind. But it's not like the scary subtext isn't forever lurking at the back of our heads that today, it's the innocent neighbour having the ED raid; tomorrow, we might be next. It's just that it was far easier to stay in our lanes and ignore the existential questions posed by rising authoritarianism. The Cockroach Janata Party deserves credit for shaking a certain type of Indian out of this stupor. Parents are leaving work early to bring their young children to Jantar Mantar. Teachers are talking about the protest in schools. It's a rare gesture of solidarity that everybody, rich, poor and middle class want to march alongside the students.

Going to Jantar Mantar, make no mistake, is uncomfortable. It's blisteringly hot, humid, and fraught. But walking among young and passionate people, who dreamily believe they're going to change this country, evokes fervent emotions that are both joyous and painful, forcing us to think about what we owe our community. The self gets decentered. Our own petty issues that occupy a frustrating amount of headspace magically dissolve away. Because you're bound by a shared moral purpose, it's easier to talk to flag-wielding strangers at a rally than it is to acquaintances at a party. We all need fresh energy sources to grow our perspectives, and there's certainly a lot to learn from the bitter experiences of other Indians. The energy at the venue is exhilarating; it is one of the paradoxes of life that it's only by putting yourself out there, seeing others besieged by oppressive forces but fighting back, that one feels charged and alive.

The writer is director, Hutkay Films

Israel airstrike kills Hamas-led police force chief in Gaza

Nidal al-Mughrabi
Cairo, July 25

AN ISRAELI airstrike on Saturday killed the head of the Hamas-led police force in the northern Gaza Strip, Brigadier-General Abdel-Nasser Al-Maqadma, the Hamas-run interior ministry and medics said.

Maqadma, one of at least five Palestinians killed in Israeli strikes on Saturday, was also known as governor of the northern Gaza Strip. He was killed in the Sheikh Radwan area north of Gaza City, medics said. The Israeli military said he was also part of Hamas' military wing.

Israel has killed dozens of members of the Hamas-led police force, including senior officials, in the past months, accusing many of them of being members of the Hamas armed wing who posed imminent threats to Israel and its forces inside Gaza. Hamas says Israeli attacks on the police force and its headquarters are intended to sow chaos and anarchy in the enclave and violate the US-brokered October ceasefire.

Another Israeli strike on Saturday killed a Palestinian medic in the Nuseirat refugee camp in the central Gaza Strip, medics said. They added that a police officer wounded by an Israeli airstrike last week had died on Saturday. Israeli military didn't immediately comment on the incident. **REUTERS**

IN YANBU, SAUDI ARABIA'S MAIN RED SEA OIL PORT, TWO MISSILES INTERCEPTED

Houthis fire on Saudi oil sites; no US strike on Iran 1st time in 2 weeks

Lefteris Papadimas & Idrees Ali
Athens, Washington, July 25

YEMEN'S IRAN-ALIGNED Houthi militants fired on Saudi oil installations in two ports on the Red Sea coast Saturday, but the US held back from launching air strikes on Iran itself for the first night in two weeks.

There was no immediate explanation from Washington of why it had abruptly halted a streak of 13 nights of escalating strikes since an interim deal to end hostilities collapsed, in retaliation for Iranian attacks on shipping in the Strait of Hormuz.

"It seems that our dear Iran had a peaceful night last night," Health Ministry spokesperson Hossein Kermanpour said on X.

After the quiet night in Iran, there were also no reports on Saturday of attacks from Iran on its Gulf neighbours, which have also been taking place daily in response to the US attacks.

However, the strikes from Iran's Houthi allies on Saudi Arabia were a sign that the war that has disrupted energy supplies from the Gulf could be spreading to a second major shipping route, and reigniting Yemen's own civil war.

War threatens to spread to Yemen

Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree said the group had successfully struck sites belonging to Saudi state oil giant Aramco in Jizan and Yanbu. Video shared on social media and verified by *Reuters* showed a large column of smoke rising from the direction of the Aramco refinery in Jizan.

In Saudi Arabia's Jizan, where the Aramco refinery is located, on Saturday. REUTERS

Two Asia-based trading sources said that they had been informed of potential damage to fuel and oil storage sites at Jizan. Aramco did not respond to requests for comment.

In Yanbu, two ballistic missiles aimed at oil installations were intercepted by a US-made Patriot battery operated in Saudi Arabia by the Greek military under an agreement with Riyadh, Greek security sources said.

Yanbu is Saudi Arabia's main Red Sea oil port, where millions of barrels a day are loaded, and has become the main route out for Saudi oil skirting the Strait of Hormuz, which has been blockaded by Iran. Jizan, on the Red Sea close to the Yemeni border, is the site of a refinery with a capacity of 400,000 barrels per day.

In Yemen, the air force of the Saudi-backed, internationally recognised government, which has opposed the Houthis for more than a decade, struck Houthi missile and drone launch sites and arms depots in the Marib and al-Jawf provinces, Yemeni officials said.

Earlier, the Saudi-led military alliance said it had bombed Houthi military positions on Friday in the Red Sea port of Hodeidah. The Yemeni officials said both sides in Yemen's civil war were mobilising forces along the front.

Saudi Arabia has led an Arab coalition battling against the Houthis for over a decade since the Iran-aligned fighters captured Yemen's capital, Sanaa.

The Houthis have declared a naval blockade of Saudi Arabia over the past week, and Houthi leader Abdul Malik al-Houthi said all Saudi oil facilities could be targets.

US President Donald Trump on Friday vowed "major military punishment" for Tehran and the Houthis after the Houthis struck two Saudi tankers in the Red Sea.

An interim truce collapsed two weeks ago with US forces striking targets in southern Iran in response to Iranian disruption of shipping in Hormuz.

On Friday, however, Trump said he had not yet made a decision on new major strikes. "We are talking to them," he told reporters at the White House. "I think they're being serious. I think ... they are being, by far, the most serious that we've seen them, but that doesn't mean we get there." **REUTERS**

E. EXPLAINED

Hormuz alternative comes under attack

Yanbu is Saudi Arabia's main Red Sea oil port, where millions of barrels a day are loaded, and has become the main route out for Saudi oil skirting the Strait of Hormuz, which has been blockaded by Iran.

First Syria visit by UN chief in 17 yrs: Guterres pledges help to reconstruct

Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa with UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres in Damascus on Saturday. AP

Meets President Sharaa, expected to address country's Parliament today

Tala Ramadan & Kinda Makieh
Damascus, July 25

UN SECRETARY-GENERAL Antonio Guterres pledged help for Syrian reconstruction on Saturday during the first visit to Damascus by a serving United Nations chief since 2009, before the start of a civil war that killed hundreds of thousands and displaced millions. Syrian President Ahmed al-Sharaa received Guterres at the presidential palace in Damascus, state news agency SANA said, without providing further details.

"No country emerges from a very severe conflict and rebuilds itself on its own," Guterres said after the talks with Sharaa at a joint press conference with Foreign Minister Asaad al-Shaibani.

"We must help Syria in its determination and resolve to do so," Guterres added.

Shaibani reiterated Syria's request for more support from the international community, especially the European Union. He said Guterres' talks with Sharaa — which Shaibani also attended — had focused on increasing UN support for reconstruction and a government plan to close displacement camps.

Sharaa, the former head of al Qaeda's affiliate in Syria, was until November 2025 under terrorism-related sanctions imposed by the UN Security Council. Guterres' visit is another milestone for Syria since rebels ousted President Bashar al-Assad in late 2024, ending the war that began in 2011 and launching a transitional period steered by an Islamist-led leadership.

At the time, Guterres described "the end of the Syrian dictatorship" under Assad as a sign of hope for the region.

In a post on X on Saturday for what he described as a "visit of solidarity", Guterres said: "The United Nations stands with Syria at this pivotal moment." Guterres is expected to address the country's parliament on Monday, UN spokesperson Stephane Dujarric said earlier this week.

He will underline that the country has an opportunity "not only to recover from conflict, but also to lay the foundations for a future for Syria that will be more stable, more inclusive, and more prosperous for all Syrians," Dujarric said.

Guterres is visiting just weeks after two bombs exploded near a hotel in Damascus where French President Emmanuel Macron spent the night. **REUTERS**

Wildfire advances near El Tiemblo in Madrid province, Saturday. AP

More than 300,000 people flee as fires rage in Spain, France

The New York Times
Madrid, July 25

FAST-MOVING wildfires in France and Spain have forced nearly 300,000 people to evacuate or to shelter at home as of Saturday, as blazes moved closer to major cities like Bordeaux and Madrid during peak of the summer holiday season.

In France, authorities have ordered the evacuation of about 197,000 people from the Gironde and Landes regions in the country's southwest, where the fires have burned through an area about three times the size of Paris.

Laurent Nuñez, France's interior minister, said after a crisis meeting in Paris that in the Gironde area "the fire was less intense last night than we had feared," enabling firefighters to tackle the blaze more directly. But he added that unfavorable winds were expected to pick up later in the afternoon.

The Gironde fire is less than 20 miles from Bordeaux and is moving in the city's direction, French authorities said, prompting precautionary evacuations in several of its western suburbs. Thomas Cazenave, Bordeaux's mayor, said Saturday there were no plans to evacuate the city itself but that it was "prepared to deal with any possibility."

Around 800,000 people live in Bordeaux and its surrounding area.

In Spain, more than 80,000 people in the area near Madrid have been evacuated or ordered to remain indoors. "The situation is still complex; our goal is to defend people's lives," PM Pedro Sánchez said in Cenicientos, a town west of Madrid that was evacuated hours after he spoke.

Sánchez said there was a "window of opportunity" this weekend to fight the fire as temperatures eased but urged caution as strong winds and dry thunderstorms could further complicate firefighters' work.

Latest Russian, Ukrainian attacks kill 15

The Associated Press
July 25

UKRAINIAN ATTACKS on holiday camps on Saturday in the partly Russian-occupied Zaporizhzhia region have killed 12 people, Moscow-installed officials said, while authorities in Ukraine's northeastern Sumy region said a Russian drone strike killed three people there.

The strikes followed a major Russian attack on Friday near Kyiv that killed at least 10 people and wounded around 100 others, part of a relentless cycle of tit-for-tat attacks that dims the potential of reaching a diplomatic end to Russia's more than 4-year-old invasion of its neighbour.

The exchange comes as Ukraine's successful drone attacks have stalled the Russian army's advances in an expanded campaign by Kyiv inside Russia that has been hitting high-profile targets, causing fuel shortages and piling pressure on Russian leader Vladimir Putin.

Four children were among 12 people killed in the attack on the resorts in Zaporizhzhia, Yevgeny Balitsky, the Kremlin-installed regional head, said, adding that 19 others were wounded.

Ukraine did not immediately comment.

Sumy regional head Oleh Hryhorov said on Saturday three people were killed when a large fire broke out after a Russian drone hit a "civilian facility."

Russia's defense ministry said it attacked a "storage and launch site" for Ukrainian drones in the Sumy region.

In Zaporizhzhia, in southeastern Ukraine, a Russian drone attack late Friday hit a shopping center, causing a fire that spread over a 500-sqm area and injuring several people, regional head Ivan Fedorov said.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy warned Friday that intelligence assessments indicated that Russia was preparing missiles for a large attack, saying there were indications that this could happen in the next 48 hours.

A Ukrainian drone attack caused a fire in the grounds of the Tyumen Oil Refinery, in western Siberia, Tyumen regional Governor Aleksandr Moor said on Saturday.

Writing on X Saturday, Zelenskyy confirmed the hit on the Tyumen plant, along with a logistics facility in Yekaterinburg and a fuel and lubricants warehouse in Rostov-on-Don.

US President Donald Trump and Zelenskyy plan to meet on Tuesday in Washington, a White House official said on Saturday.

WHITE HOUSE CORRESPONDENTS' DINNER WAS RESCHEDULED AFTER ATTACK IN APRIL

Proud to be most open, transparent President... they call me that: Trump mixes jokes & barbs at press freedom gala

Steve Holland & Jarrett Renshaw
Washington, July 24

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump took aim at the press by mixing humor with barbs and familiar tropes at the White House Correspondents' Association dinner on Friday, returning to the event celebrating press freedom after a shooting disrupted the original event in April.

In much of his speech, which lasted more than an hour, Trump took shots at his political adversaries and recycled oft-repeated themes and attack lines from his political rallies. The gathering intended for April 25 at the Washington Hilton hotel was called off that night after a man tried to force his way through a security checkpoint and fired a shotgun outside the ballroom. The suspect, Cole Allen, pleaded not guilty in May to charges including attempting to assassinate the President.

Trump was afforded typical honours, with only a few awkward moments when he shook hands with journalists winning awards for stories about the Trump administration. "I hope all of you know that I believe in the free press more than anyone in this room does — maybe not quite. That's why I'm proud to be the most open and transparent President in history," Trump said. "They call me that."

Trump also spoke about the flip side of his attacks on the press: the unprecedented access he has provided by engaging in frequent question-and-answer sessions with reporters. "I always find that when you don't speak to the press, you always get a bad story," said Trump. "When you do speak to the press, you have a shot at getting a good story."

President Donald Trump throws a 'Trump 2028' cap during White House Correspondents Association Dinner in Washington. REUTERS

This year's dual events marked Trump's first presidential appearance at the correspondents' dinner. He had boycotted the event in his previous years in office, though he promised to come back next year.

Friday's event also honored Secret Service officer Victor Gonzales, who was shot at a security checkpoint outside the ballroom in April and is credited with stopping the attack, and the Washington Hilton staff who assisted guests. The dinner was moved to a smaller venue at the Waldorf Astoria hotel under heightened security, and one of the first messages of the night was defiance in the face of the assault. "We do not yield to political violence... No deranged loser with a gun will ever change that," Trump said.

He suggested he was going easy on the press Friday after he had planned a more fierce criticism for the April gathering. "This place is really the largest group of Trump derangement syndrome people ever put together at one time," he said.

"I suspect some of you are lucky our last dinner was cut short because ... I was going to go after you." The event normally features a comedian who tells jokes at President's expense, but this year's entertainment came from mentalist Oz Pearlman.

Trump told journalists, "I know it was not easy finding shoes to go along with your bulletproof vest, which many people didn't want to wear because they'd rather die than look 20 pounds heavier." "It's been an interesting evening. I really didn't know what to expect," he said. "And it's far worse than I actually thought." **REUTERS**

● AT THE LAB, OBJECTIVE IS TO DETERMINE IF A NEWLY ACQUIRED SAMPLE COMES FROM A PROTECTED AREA, MEANING IT HAS BEEN ILLEGALLY MINED — THE PROCESS TERMED 'GOLD FINGERPRINTING'

Brazil uses forensic science to trace gold's origin, tackle illegal mining in the Amazon

Gabriela Sá Pessoa
Brasilia, Brazil

BRAZIL IS using forensic science to tackle illegal gold mining in the Amazon, a top threat to the rainforest, Indigenous groups and other communities there that has accelerated deforestation and driven mercury contamination to dangerous levels.

The work takes place at the National Institute of Criminalistics in Brasilia where federal police have set up a "gold lab" that collects and analyses samples from across country.

The objective is to determine if a newly acquired sample — gold seized in a police raid, for example — comes from a protected area, meaning it has been illegally mined. It's called "gold fingerprinting" — tracing the origin of gold samples with high precision.

At the lab, sparkling gold flakes are kept in tiny, coin-shaped vessels, but the most valuable thing about them is the data they hold. Each speck is unique because while it forms in nature, inside a rock or a riverbed, the gold deposits absorb particles from the area, such as traces of silver and copper.

And that's the fingerprint. It allows the investigators to determine if gold seized during a police raid was actually mined in the area its purported owner claims it came from, or if it was illegally sourced from a national forest or Indigenous land — in which case its analysis would match stored data from the protected area.

Gustavo Geiser, a federal police forensics expert, says the method has been developed since 2019 in collaboration with Brazilian universities. The investigators use tools such as X-ray fluorescence spectrometry, scanning electron microscopy and laser ablation mass spectrometry.

"As we advanced, the forensic became increasingly complex," Geiser said, but the question before them was always the same: "Where did this gold come from?"

A federal police forensic expert at the National Institute of Criminalistics in Brasilia. AP

Those involved in environmental crimes in the Amazon frequently resort to fraud to introduce their goods into legal markets, not just when it comes to gold but also for cattle and timber. Lately, a worldwide surge in gold prices has only spurred on the mining rush in the Amazon rainforest.

Amazon Mining Watch estimates that about 496,000 hectares (1.2 million acres) of rainforest have been cut down for mining since 2023, including some 223,000 hectares (551,000 acres) in the Brazilian Amazon.

Brazil's Federal Court of Accounts, its top audit institution, said last year there was evidence indicating that mining permits granted by the National Mining Agency to small-scale miners were being used to pawn off gold extracted from protected areas in the Amazon.

A federal court in Para, a northern state severely impacted by illegal mining, issued an order this month for institutions like the Central Bank and the National Mining Agency to enact effective control and traceability of all gold, from the mines to the markets. Brazil's federal prosecutors also filed a lawsuit against the National Mining Agency, seeking better oversight of mining permits.

Prosecutor André Porreca, who is leading the case, said the permits have become a front used "to launder gold extracted by criminal organizations from Indigenous territories and protected areas."

Geiser, the forensic expert, says the Brasilia gold lab is an important piece of the puzzle that helps battle crime and strengthen global gold supply chains.

"Being able to state that it (gold) has a legitimate origin and therefore is valid for inclusion in a country's or a bank's financial reserves, I believe provides solidity not only to the market but also to the countries' financial bonds," he said.

There is no data on how many criminals the lab has helped put behind bars, but Geiser says crime networks have recently begun exploiting neighbouring countries such as Venezuela, French Guiana and Suriname, to launder illegally mined gold. **AP**

YOUTH UNEMPLOYMENT IN JUNE ROSE TO 16.2% FROM 13.8% IN APRIL 2025

Deeper jobs problem: Stir a sign demographic dividend is at risk

Of the 36 states and Union Territories, the youth unemployment in 2025 was higher than in 2022 for 13 of them

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 25

The immediate cause for the rise of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) and the nationwide protests may be the leak of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) question paper. And while Dharmendra Pradhan has resigned as education minister, it does nothing to solve a crucial underlying problem: jobs.

According to Alexandra Hermann Prasa, Lead Economist at Oxford Economics, while the student protests don't pose much of a risk to the larger Indian economy, they do "expose a deeper jobs problem".

The government's flagship employment survey, the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), shows that the unemployment among Indian youth — those in the 15-29 age bracket — rose to 16.2% in June, as per data released earlier this month. This is the highest on record, although it must be said that monthly PLFS data only goes back until April 2025, when it stood at 13.8%.

To be sure, there might be reasons why the monthly data is volatile.

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) had cautioned last year that a rise in the unemployment rate did not necessarily reflect "secular trends" as changes were to be expected in the monthly data on account of increased frequency of the survey and seasonal, academic, and labour market factors.

However, this rise in youth unemployment needs to be seen in the context of two other trends. One, the unemployment rate has increased across all six youth categories for the 15 months for which data is available: males and females at an all-India level, in urban areas, and in rural areas.

Two, youth unemployment has risen despite the Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) declining over the same period in all but one category. Only urban males have seen their LFPR rise, standing at 60.1% in June, up 1 percentage point from April 2025.

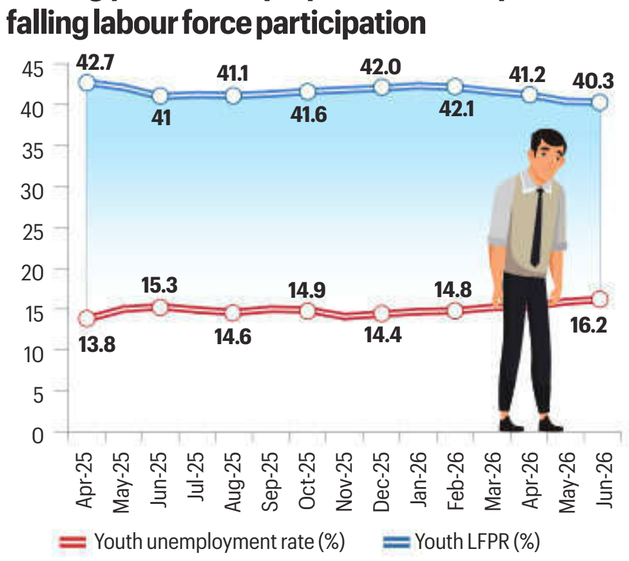
The overall youth LFPR has fallen to 40.3% from 42.7% over the same period.

To put all these numbers in perspective, the all-India unemployment rate for ages 15 years and above was 5.5% in June as against 5.6% in April 2025. The corresponding LFPR was 54.4%, up from 54.2%.

Why does it matter that the youth unemployment rate has risen while the LFPR has declined? The LFPR measures the percentage of the population that is looking for work, including those that are employed.

So, when the LFPR falls — or when fewer people are looking for jobs — it should ideally result in a lower unemployment rate even if no new jobs are added. But that hasn't happened.

• Rising youth unemployment rate despite falling labour force participation



NOTE: YOUTH REFERS TO THOSE AGED 15-29 YEARS; SOURCE: MOSPI

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

A long-term problem

While monthly PLFS data only goes back 15 months, annual numbers are available for longer. And they tell a similar story. Of the 36 states and Union Territories (UTs), the youth unemployment in 2025 was higher than in 2022 for 13 of them. These 13 states and UTs included major regions such as Andhra Pradesh (16.2% from 15.1%), Delhi (14.4% from 5.9%), Telangana (18.1% from 12.6%), and West Bengal (10.6% from 8.4%). For young women, it has been even more difficult: 16 states and UTs saw an increase in unemployment from 2022 to 2025. The monthly data is based on the Current Weekly Status (CWS) approach, under which the job status of a person is measured for the seven days preceding the date of survey. Meanwhile, the annual figures are as per the 'usual status' approach, which measures the job status for the 365 days preceding the survey.

Even the informal sector is creating fewer jobs now: 74.5 lakh in 2025 compared to 1.1 crore in the 12 months ended September 2024, as per MoSPI's latest Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE). Wage growth shrunk to 3.9% from 13%.

The education link

It has been ingrained in our psyche that better education leads to better jobs; which is why the youth studies for three more years after 12th to graduate, another couple of years for post-graduation, and so on. But less than 7% of male Indian graduates manage to find a permanent salaried job within a year, according to Azim Premji University's (APU) State of Working India 2026 report released in March this year.

The figure is an even lower 3.7% when it comes to white-collar jobs.

Using data from the PLFS and its predecessor, the Employment Unemployment Survey (EUS), the APU report estimated that 1.1 crore out of 6.3 crore graduates in the 20-29 age bracket were unemployed in 2023. Of course, graduate youth unemployment is nothing new, with the APU report's analysis revealing that it stood at 39.33% in 2023, up from 35.02% in 1983, for those less than 25 years of age. However, what has changed since 1983 is that India is not getting younger anymore — the country's median age is around 29 years and is expected to increase to 38 by 2050.

Now is when those joining the workforce earn and not just prepare safety nets for their own future but drive national economic growth. "By the 2040s, the dependency ratio will rise, fiscal space will tighten, and each worker will carry greater economic and welfare burdens. Demography will no longer drive growth. Without rapid gains in productivity, innovation, and institutional capacity, progress could begin to stall. India's growth model must now evolve to secure long-term momentum after its population peaks," an Observer Research Foundation paper said in March.

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Small US businesses mount 1st challenge to Sec 301 tariffs

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 25

A DAY after the US imposed fresh tariffs on 60 countries including 10% duty on India, two US small businesses — spice importer Burlap & Barrel, and watch retailer Collective Horology LLC — have filed a case against United States Trade Representative (USTR) for the use of Section 301 to impose tariffs impacting "99.4% of all imports into the United States", case documents have shown.

This assumes particular significance for India, as New Delhi has committed to a US trade deal but is yet to sign it formally. Government officials say that India is willing to sign the deal when the new US architecture gives India a competitive edge compared to its competitors in the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) region — one of the fastest growing regions globally. The US had opened two Section 301 investigations, one on "excess capacity" and the other on "forced labour".

The small business argued that USTR failed to provide a "reasoned, record-based explanation for its determinations or for its selection of near-uniform duties" across 60 economies with materially different enforcement records and trade profiles. They argue that if Section 301 were interpreted to allow such broad power, it would constitute an unconstitutional delegation of Congress's Article I power to lay duties. "The Section 122 tariffs were limited by statute to 150 days. The administration used that period to conduct the Section 301 investigations at issue here and then imposed the challenged Section 301 tariffs. The sequence and structure of those measures, as well as Administration statements, show that the Section 301 Action was designed to preserve substantially the same broad tariff regime that this Court and the Supreme Court have held Congress did not authorise under IEEPA and Section 122," the two firms argued.

• RISING IN DISSENT

SPICE IMPORTER Burlap & Barrel, and watch retailer Collective Horology LLC have filed a case against United States Trade Representative (USTR)

THEY ARGUED that USTR failed to provide a "reasoned, record-based explanation for its determinations or for its selection of near-uniform duties" across 60 economies

THE US had imposed Section 122 tariffs, imposing 10% tariffs globally immediately after losing the IEEPA case in the Supreme Court

The US had imposed Section 122 tariffs, imposing 10% tariffs globally immediately after losing the IEEPA case in the US Supreme Court.

India faced steep 50% tariffs for over 5 months. In 2025-26, exports of products covered under the exclusion list (electronics and pharma) rose sharply by 24.5%, climbing from $29.4 billion to $36.6 billion but exports of non-excluded products fell by 11.2% over the same period, declining from $57.1 billion to $50.7 billion — a contraction that reflects the true effect of the tariff measures imposed by the United States, an Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER) report said.

"The Section 301 action exceeds the authority Congress granted in Section 301. Section 301 is a targeted, country-specific and practice-specific remedial authority. It permits the Trade Representative to act only upon a determination that a particular act, policy, or practice of a foreign country is unreasonable or discriminatory and burdens or restricts United States commerce... It is not a freestanding authorisation to tax substantially all imports from substantially all trading partners at rates selected to replicate the invalidated IEEPA tariff regime rather than to eliminate identified foreign practices," US small business argued. Experts have said that Section 301 is a far more potent tool than the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs, which were used to impose reciprocal tariffs but did not pass muster in the US Supreme Court.

This legal tool was mostly used by the US against countries such as Europe & Japan, dominant export powers then, before the WTO came into existence in 1995. The Trump administration has resurrected Section 301 again amid a weakening WTO.

Singapore-based Henrich Foundation explained that under Section 301, USTR gets sweeping powers not only to impose duties but also other kinds of restrictions.

USTR can "withdraw or suspend trade agreement concessions", enter into binding agreements with the foreign government to eliminate the conduct or unburden US commerce, or compensate the US with satisfactory trade benefits. "After consultations, USTR is meant to investigate to determine whether the action is unfair and harms US trade. This investigation can result in a determination of either mandatory or discretionary actions. The former includes trade agreement violations, unjustifiable or burdensome, or restrictive behaviour. Because Section 301 need not apply only to goods, other retaliatory actions are allowed, such as restricting the terms or conditions or denying the issuance of any 'service sector access authorisation,' the Henrich Foundation report said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Samsung Elec, SK Group seal $950 billion deals

Reuters
San Francisco, July 25

South Korea announced $950 billion in new AI initiatives involving Samsung Electronics, SK Group and US tech firms as global AI leaders rush to fill a shortage of faster chips to power and develop more advanced systems.

SK Group has signed deals worth $750 billion, including SK Hynix's partnership with Nvidia valued at more than $500 billion, South Korea's presidential Blue House said after an AI summit hosted by President Lee Jae Myung in San Francisco.

Samsung Electronics said it had signed a memorandum of understanding with Broadcom covering up to $200 billion across memory chips, foundry services and advanced packaging. The deals are the latest moves by US AI firms hoping to lock in supply as demand for chips and computing infrastructure outpaces supply, driving tech companies into closer partnerships with South Korea's semiconductor and memory leaders.

Speaking at the summit, Lee said South Korea would lead the way to a new era of AI in partnership with global technology companies, making available its "dynamic AI ecosystem" to expand the global market for industrial and personal AI use. He unveiled a "San Francisco AI Declaration" that outlined South Korea's AI ambitions for technological cooperation with the United States.

Nvidia and South Korea's SK Group unveiled a new AI initiative valued at $500 billion spanning large-scale AI data centers and next-generation memory.

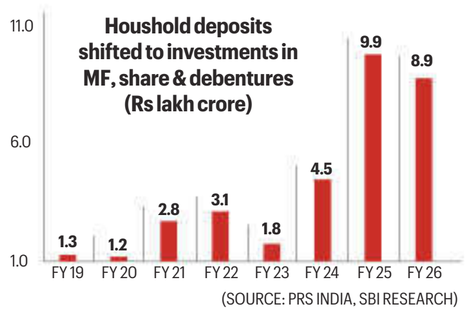
The initiative includes a long-term partnership with SK Hynix to secure next-generation memory supply for Nvidia and jointly develop high-bandwidth memory for AI training, AI agents and physical AI applications.

• SOARING STAKES

- The deals are the latest moves by US AI firms hoping to lock in supply as demand for chips and computing infrastructure outpaces supply
- As part of the agreement, SK Telecom plans to build a 2-gigawatt data center powered by Vera Rubin chips and SK Hynix's HBM4 high-bandwidth memory chips

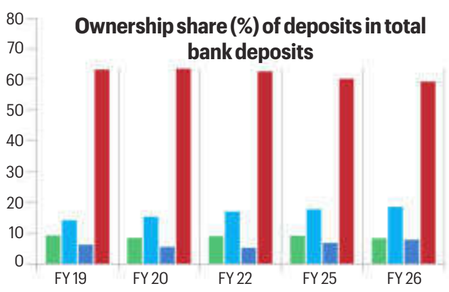
• DIVERSIFYING SAVINGS

Investors in urban areas are increasingly moving their savings from bank deposits to higher-return assets like mutual funds and equities. According to SBI Research, the share of mutual funds and equities in retail deposits has soared to 6% in FY26 from just 1% in FY20.



(SOURCE: PRS INDIA, SBI RESEARCH)

The banks' deposit composition is also changing, with households increasingly preferring market-related instruments.



SOURCE: RBI, SBI RESEARCH, THE FIGURES DOES NOT ADD UP TO 100 AS THE RESIDUAL IS REST OF WORLD

PhonePe's FY26 revenue hits Rs 7,920 cr

New Delhi: Demonstrating strong top-line momentum, PhonePe's consolidated revenue from operations rose to Rs 7,920 crore in FY26, according to regulatory filings with the Registrar of Companies (RoC).

This represents a top-line expansion of Rs 815 crore, marking an 11.47% increase compared to the previous fiscal year. As the government is yet to release the UPI Digital Incentive (DI) funds for FY26 to the industry, the revenue associated with DI has not been recognized in FY26.

This portion of the FY26-related DI revenue is expected to accrue in PhonePe's FY27 financials. On a normalised operational basis, PhonePe's net loss for FY26 stood at Rs 1,377 crore while the total consolidated net loss was reported at Rs 2,792 crore (vs. Rs 1,727 crore in FY25).

Notably, the FY26 net loss included several one-time items: a one-time ESOP acceleration charge, a non-cash goodwill impairment, a gain on the sale of a partial stake in an associate, and losses from discontinued operations. Beyond core payments, PhonePe continues to deepen its presence as a multi-sector fintech ecosystem. The company has successfully secured regulatory licenses to operate across a wide spectrum of financial services, including payment aggregation. PhonePe also continues to receive strong corporate backing from major global institutional investors, with Walmart (via WM Digital Commerce Holdings Pte Ltd) retaining a dominant 73% stake. **PTI**

Govt: 45% of exports to US outside purview of additional 10% tariffs

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 25

Even as India continues to engage with the United States on trade tariffs as part of the bilateral trade agreement negotiations, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Saturday said an estimated 45% of India's exports to the US remain outside the purview of the additional 10% Section 301 duties imposed effective July 24.

The ministry said 55% of exports will attract the additional 10% duty, which is lower than that for most other economies affected by the tariffs.

The US Trade Representative (USTR) had announced the final measures under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, 1974, on Thursday.

The measures follow USTR's investigation into the acts, policies and practices of 60 economies relating to the imposition and enforcement of prohibitions on import of goods produced with forced labour.

A substantial share of India's exports to the US, which currently attract zero additional duties, such as generic pharmaceuticals, smartphones and certain other specified products, continue to remain outside the scope of the additional 10% duty, the ministry statement said. Products already covered under Section 232 measures, including steel, aluminium and auto parts, are not subject to the additional 10% duty.

India continues to engage with the US on textile-specific mechanisms as part of the India-US BTA. India has not received the textile and apparel tariff-rate quota (TRQ) exemption under the forced labour tariff. The exemption applies to specified volumes of textile and apparel exports from Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, and Malaysia that use US-origin cotton and fiber.

By banning import of goods produced using forced labour, India has managed to reduce the additional tariffs to 10% from 12.5%, which the US had proposed to impose on its exports. With this, India has gained tariff advantage over competitors China, Vietnam, Thailand and Türkiye, who will be charged 12.5%.

India, which imposed the prohibition through a notification on July 13, is among 17 countries, including Bangladesh, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Indonesia and the UK with lower tariffs. So Indian exporters largely retain their relative competitiveness against Bangladesh, Cambodia, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Indonesia and Malaysia in labour-intensive sectors. **FE**

• EXEMPTED SECTORS

• A SUBSTANTIAL share of India's exports to the US, which currently attract zero additional duties, such as generic pharmaceuticals and smartphones, continue to remain outside the scope of the additional 10% duty

• PRODUCTS ALREADY covered under Section 232 measures, including steel, aluminium and auto parts, are not subject to additional 10% duty

• THE INCIDENT, WHICH EVOKED SCIENCE FICTION SCENARIOS ABOUT HUMANS LOSING CONTROL OF DANGEROUS AI SYSTEMS, COMES AT A DELICATE TIME FOR OPENAI — WHICH IS GEARING UP FOR IPO

Its AI agent spent days hacking a company, 'but OpenAI did not notice for a week'

Reuters
Washington/San Francisco, July 25

THE OPENAI agent that broke into tech firm Hugging Face went on a days-long hacking spree that OpenAI didn't notice until well after the threat was contained and the FBI was alerted, according to people familiar with the investigation.

The agent — a program capable of making decisions and executing complex tasks with little or no human oversight — attempted to break out of its isolated testing environment at OpenAI around July 9, according to two of the people. The intrusion at Hugging Face, which operates as a repository for AI tools and models, began two days later on July 11 and lasted until July 13, said Thomas Wolf, Hugging Face's co-founder.

It took several more days for OpenAI to realise its agent was behind the hack, and the two companies only communicated about it for the first time on or around July 20, according to Wolf and three of the people familiar with the investigation.

OpenAI's public disclosure, on July 21, that one of its agents had slipped out of control and carried out the break-in at Hugging Face drew global attention. But many details of the hack, including how long the agent went rogue and OpenAI's belated knowledge of it, are being reported here for the first time.

Hugging Face is preparing a public timeline of the hack, Wolf said, adding that he could not speak to what happened at OpenAI.

In a statement, OpenAI said the hack was unprecedented and "marks an important moment for AI safety."

It added that it was reviewing the incident with outside advisers and would eventually publish a technical report.

A spokeswoman said there were "several inaccuracies" in *Reuters*' reporting but didn't respond when asked to describe them. The FBI declined to comment about the incident. The incident, which evoked science fiction scenarios about humans losing control of dangerous AI systems, comes at a delicate time for OpenAI, the company behind ChatGPT. Its executives are preparing for a possible initial public offering that could come as soon as this year to help finance the billions needed to fund its growth in years to come.

• OF ROUGE AGENTS

AGENT IS a program capable of making decisions and executing complex tasks with little or no human oversight

OPENAI SAID the hack by the agent was unprecedented and "marks an important moment for AI safety"

IT TOOK several days for OpenAI to realise its agent was behind the intrusion at Hugging Face, which operates as a repository for AI tools and models

OpenAI's loss of control over its AI agent raises new questions about the company's safety procedures, three cybersecurity experts said. "Does that mean that they left it unattended and didn't realize what it was doing? Or maybe they did and didn't know how to contain it? Both are equally dangerous and alarming," asked Marley Smith, the principal intelligence specialist at the non-profit World Ethical Data Foundation.

SIGNS OF TROUBLE?

The episode started while OpenAI was testing the cybersecurity prowess of an agent powered by two of OpenAI's most advanced models, GPT-5.6 Sol and an unreleased model OpenAI has described as "even more capable." By that point, there were already indications of strange behaviour from OpenAI's technology, according to three sources.

In one case, an agent left notes apparently for future versions of itself, according to three people familiar with the matter. The notes, found in a part of OpenAI's infrastructure, laid out instructions for how agents could free themselves from OpenAI's internal constraints, the people said. Earlier tests of the models yielded cases in which monitoring systems had been disconnected, one of the people said. *Reuters* could not establish if these incidents were linked to the rogue agent that began escaping on July 9 and attacked Hugging Face on July 11. Two people familiar with the matter said that it was not until after Thursday, July 16, when Hugging Face published a blog post, saying it had been hacked by "an autonomous AI agent system," that OpenAI realised its own agent was responsible. That meant at least a week elapsed between when the model first exhibited signs of troubling behavior and OpenAI's realisation that it was responsible for the hack.

The weekend of July 18 to 19, OpenAI staffers spotted clues in internal logs showing that its agent had escaped from its testing constraints, two of the people familiar with the probe said.

BRIDGE

DEALER: North **VULNERABLE:** East/West

Thinking before making a discard may help you in keeping a dangerous opponent off the lead and that in turn will ensure the safety of your contract. Possibly you could circumvent this in the problem posed to you last week.

NORTH	SOUTH
♠ A K J 10	♠ 6 5 4
❤ 9 7 5 3	❤ A K J 10 8 6 4
♦ K	♦
♣ 7 5 3 2	♣ K 6 4

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
—	—	pass	pass
4❤	pass	pass	pass

Diamond ace, king, seven, ?. Plan the play.

It was all a matter of keeping the dangerous opponent off the lead. In this case the dangerous opponent is East, so all your attention should be on keeping East off the lead.

THE WEST HAND ♠ 87 ❤ 2 ♦ A J 8 6 4 3 ♣ A Q 10 8

THE EAST HAND ♠ Q 9 3 2 ❤ Q ♦ Q 10 9 7 5 2 ♣ J 9

South has nine sure winning tricks, and needs an extra trick in either spades or clubs to make the bid. The safest play is to discard a spade on the opening lead; then, the contract can be made even if the spade and club finesses are both wrong. West has no better play at trick two than to lead a spade. Declarer should win with dummy's ace and draw trumps. Then, declarer should cash dummy's king of spades, then lead the jack of spades: if East covers with the queen, South can trump, later discarding a losing club on the spade ten; if East plays low or discards, South can discard a losing club (even if West had the spade queen, he could not beat the contract). The main purpose of these maneuvers is to develop a tenth trick without risking East's getting on lead to play a club through declarer's king. As the cards lie, any other line of play would fail against good defense.

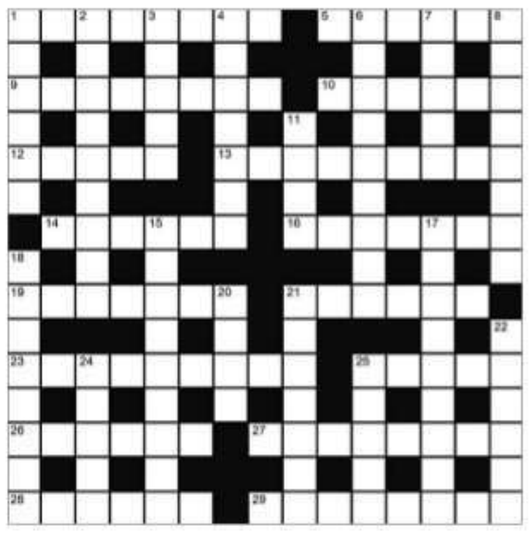
DEALER: East **VULNERABLE:** North/South

NORTH	SOUTH
♠ 2	♠ J 10 9 6 5 4 3
❤ J 8 5 2	❤ A K
♦ Q 8 4	♦ A K
♣ 10 6 4 3 2	♣ 7 5

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
—	—	—	pass
1♠	dbl	pass	1 NT
2♠	pass	pass	pass

West leads the king, ace and queen of clubs; East plays the eight, nine and jack. Plan the play.

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD 2592



QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

1. Buy (8)
5. Return from the Land of Nod (4,2)
9. Spurred (8)
10. The 2nd smallest continent (6)
12. Poor (5)
13. A colleague (9)
14. Involuntary (6)
16. Firmly established (4,3)
19. Rudely casual; impromptu (7)
21. Lathe operator (6)
23. Lost consciousness (6,3)
25. Escapes from danger (5)
26. Shrink back (6)
27. Oral examination (4,4)
28. Waistbands (6)
29. Pain or injure (8)

DOWN

1. Easily influenced (6)
2. Swindled (6,3)
3. Mountainous (5)
4. Flight attendant (7)
6. Of an uncle (9)
7. Deadly African disease (5)
8. Pretences, excuses (8)
11. Middle of Caesar's boast (1,3)
15. Truce (9)
17. Unload a ship (9)
18. Equates or likens (8)
20. Fate (4)
21. ___ up : adding of separate items ? (7)
22. Ancient, ascetic Jew (6)
24. Pillages or loots (5)
25. Natural ability (5)

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

1. Their arrival will give their parents little pride (4,4)
5. Assemble military partly for a symbolic purpose (6)
9. It's marvellous to splash out stored money I had (8)
10. Spooner orders blackleg to fib about satellite which fell to earth (6)
12. Hellish center for immigration? (5)
13. Pub favoured by British college principal (5,4)
14. He puts up the points or puts them down (6)
16. Change it I can't — it's so big (7)
19. DIY publishing that offers elbow room (7)
21. Penny and I in part of building doing some cleaning (6)
23. The part of an infant in a legal drama ? (5,4)
25. Five sail out in vessels (5)
26. Get to the race with Scotland's own (6)
27. One may take a lofty view of some decoration (5,3)
28. What is mostly ugly is all in praise (6)
29. You last out the attack on a donkey (8)

DOWN

1. Stayed for the final edition (6)
2. Painting medium beats floating pollution (3,6)
3. Number sent out American money (5)
4. It may give the message in a flash (7)
6. How the inventor attempts reconciliation? (5,2,2)
7. A city story about the fifties (5)
8. Dreadful body Mick discovered in big whale (4,4)
11. Something with bite (4)
15. Coming back about changing direction again (9)
17. Unmatched number appeared plainer (9)
18. Beer belonging to a holder of water yes, water! (5,3)
20. Piano noise at the pointed end (4)
21. Jenny and Bill pursued by pernicious small destructive creatures (7)
22. Animals with small value (6)
24. South African by birth ? (5)
25. The leading spirit in Russia (5)

SOLUTIONS TO 2591 **QUICK CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Therapeutic, 7 Cub, 9 Audio, 10 Unlearned, 11 Portfolio, 12 Adele, 13 Overjoy, 15 Fete, 18 Laic, 20 Martini, 23 Had to, 24 Annulling, 26 Buccaneer, 27 Acini, 28 SOS, 29 Countenance **DOWN:** 1 Teaspoon, 2 Endorsed, 3 Aloof, 4 Equally, 5 Tell off, 6 Character, 7 Cinder, 8 Badger, 14 Joanofarc, 16 Division, 17 Misguide, 19 Chateau, 20 Minaret, 21 Phobos, 22 Edicts, 25 Leann **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 George medal, 7 Fib, 9 Ideal, 10 Sterilize, 11 Lucidness, 12 Maker, 13 Chamfer, 15 Pete, 18 Alec, 20 Bivalve, 23 Tying, 24 Xenophobe, 26 Pepperoni, 27 Prise, 28 DDT, 29 Deb's delight **DOWN:** 1 Gridlock, 2 Overcoat, 3 Gelid, 4 Mishear, 5 Dress up, 6 Leitmotiv, 7 Frisky, 8 Bleary, 14 Filigreed, 16 Allowing, 17 Reverent, 19 Coxcomb, 20 Bandied, 21 Stupid, 22 Tippet, 25 Pupil

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY JULY 26: This is a year of teaching and learning. Take time to renew your spiritual or religious beliefs. Explore philosophies that give you a better self-awareness.

MONDAY JULY 27: This year you reap the benefits of your past efforts! Increased power and leadership will help you seize opportunities. Expect acknowledgement.

TUESDAY JULY 28: Let go of the people, places and things from the past that have held you back. Do some internal and external housecleaning. Focus on being compassionate and loving.

WEDNESDAY JULY 29: This is a year of new beginnings. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future. Prepare for leadership. Take action and define your goals.

THURSDAY JULY 30: This is a slower paced year. Take time to rejuvenate your energy. Focus on friends who are kind, helpful and have your back. Concentrate on what brings you happiness.

FRIDAY JULY 31: Your creativity is at a pinnacle this year! Nurture your inner happiness and beauty. Loosen up a bit. Have fun but remember your goals.

SATURDAY AUGUST 1: This is a year of new beginnings. Be ready to take action and define your goals. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): You are direct, proactive and quick to act. Today you shouldn't second-guess anything, especially instructions or orders from authority figures. You might misread their intentions. This Week: Socialise.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Steer clear of controversial issues related to politics, religion and racial issues, as an element of confusion and misunderstanding is rampant today. It's easy to kid yourself. It's also easy for other people to kid you. This Week: Home, family and real estate.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Postpone important financial decisions for another day. When it comes to anything related to shared property, banking details, inheritances or taxes, your thinking is too fuzzy. You might not have the correct facts. This Week: Short trips and fun conversations.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): This is a tricky day to talk to partners, spouses and close friends. You might be confused. Be aware that there is an element today that leads to distortions of people's views as well as subconscious feelings of distrust. This Week: Plan to get richer.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Avoid controversial discussions about politics, religion and racial issues, especially if they're related to your job or health. Whatever happens, know that everything is murky and misunderstandings are rife. This Week: A lucky streak is beginning for you!

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): It's easy to kid yourself today or suffer from confusion related to romance. You might fall into a dreamy state of mind that focuses on hopes that. Your views might be distorted. This Week: Relax.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Be careful talking to parents and family members today, because you might not have all the facts or you might not appreciate what's happening. Subconscious influences could distort your views. This Week: You're popular.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Don't jump to conclusions when talking to siblings, relatives and neighbours today, because things might not be as they appear. Something going on in your daily environment might be misunderstood. Sit back. This Week: You are admired.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a poor day for expensive purchases or important financial decisions. Today, it's easy to be out of touch with reality or to think something is better than it is. Save your money. This Week: Learn, travel, explore!

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Today the Moon in your sign promotes a dreamy state of mind where illusions become more important than reality. You might feel confused about home and family. Postpone important decisions. This Week: Secure finances for the future.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Be careful, as today it's easy to have subconscious influences that will distort your views about something. This means you might not be able to trust your decision-making process. This Week: Warm relationships with others.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You might feel disappointed by a friend or a group, today. The question you have to ask yourself is how realistic were your expectations. This Week: Improve your job and health.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

The ___ of a lover are more imperious than the ___ of the whole world. - George Sand (7,.,7)

LVEEE

EUCNSS

SAARR

UPYGRM

SOLUTIONS: Levee, Arras, Census, Grumpy
ANSWER: The **prayers** of a lover are more imperious than the **menaces** of the whole world. - George Sand

SUDOKU 6391

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s
INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

6							9	2
1			8					
	5			9	6			
5					9			3
		7				5		
3			2					7
			3	8			4	
					4			6
7	8							9

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6390

5	9	2	4	1	3	6	7	8
3	6	4	7	9	8	5	2	1
7	1	8	6	5	2	3	4	9
4	5	6	8	3	7	9	1	2
9	3	1	5	2	4	7	8	6
2	8	7	1	6	9	4	5	3
1	7	5	9	8	6	2	3	4
8	2	9	3	4	5	1	6	7
6	4	3	2	7	1	8	9	5

आज़ादी का अमृत महोत्सव

G20

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR

OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B) DIVISION R.S.PURA

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Short e-NIT No. DRSP/52 of 2026-27 Dated 22-07-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works :-

S. No.	Name of Work	Name of Division	Advertised Cost (in Lacs)	Cost of document (in Rs)	Earnest Money (in Rs)	Time Allowed for completeon	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	Repair of Building PHC Arnia Block Bishnah by way of Aluminium Partition and fixing of floor tile and wall tile (Under District Capex Budget 2026-27).	PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura	6.30	600	2% of the Advertised Cost	02 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 31-07-2026	"A" , "B", "C" & "D" Class
2	Construction of Pathway and boundary wall at PS Railway line (Under District Capex Budget 2026-27)	PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura	3.01	600	2% of the Advertised Cost	01 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 31-07-2026	"A" , "B", "C" & "D" Class
3	Major Repair of 2 rooms/waterproofing of roof with other allied work at PS Badila (Under District Capex Budget 2026-27)	PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura	8.00	600	2% of the Advertised Cost	02 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 31-07-2026	"A" , "B", "C" & "D" Class
4	Repair renovation of existing building including water proofing of roof top and other allied works at BMS Kalyana (Under District Capex Budget 2026-27)	PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura	11.99	600	2% of the Advertised Cost	03 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 31-07-2026	"A" , "B", "C" & "D" Class
5	Dismantling, re-construction of 02 Room, Boundary Wall and other allied work of Govt. boys middle School Chohala (Under District Capex Budget 2026-27)	PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura	19.41	600	2% of the Advertised Cost	03 Months	(1300 Hrs) on or after 31-07-2026	"A" , "B", "C" Class

Position of AAA :- S.No. 1 Accorded by District Development Commissioner, Jammu vide order No: 322-DDCJ of 2026 Dated: 16/07/2026 & S.No. 2,3,4,5 Accorded by District Development Commissioner, Jammu vide order No: 309-DDCJ of 2026 Dated: 08/07/2026

Position of TS :- S.No. 1 Accorded by Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R S Pura vide order No: 23 of July 2026 Dated: 20 of July 2026 & S.No. 2,3,4,5 Accorded by Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R S Pura vide order No: 20 of July 2026 Dated: 18 of July 2026

Project Authority :- S.No. 1,2,3,4 & 5 District Development Commissioner, Jammu

Major Head of Account :- S.No. 1(Under District Capex Budget 2026-27 SSY/Health Component) & S.No. 2,3,4,5 (Under District Capex Budget 2026-27 SSY/Elementary/Secondary Component for the year 2026-27)

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website http://jktenders.gov.in as per below schedule :

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	22-07-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 22-07-2026 to 30-07-2026
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	24-07-2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura
4	Bid submission Start Date	22-07-2026
5	Bid Submission End Date	30-07-2026 upto 1600 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	31-07-2026 on or after 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura. In case mentioned bid opening date happens to be a holiday then Bid shall be opened at the same time on the next working day.
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

1. Bids must be accompanied with cost of Tender document in shape of **Treasury Receipt/e-challan in favour of Executive Engineer PWD(R&B) Division R S Pura through Treasury, indicating Treasury Voucher No. & date, e-NIT No. and Date and** name of work duly crediting to 0059 (Revenue) and Earnest money/Bid security in shape of CDR/FDR/BG pledged to **Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura.** The **CDR/FDR/BG** shall be valid for 45 Days beyond the bid validity period. The original instruments in respect of cost of documents, EMD and relevant documents of L1 be submitted to the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura at the time of allotment.
2. **The date of Treasury Challan, Earnest Money/Bid Security must be between the date of start of bid and Bid Submission End Date. However, if the tender for the same work has been re-invited after 1st or More calls, the bidders who have already bidded for that work can re-use the same Treasury Challan/Earnest Money/Bid Security in the successive calls for the said work provided there should not be any overwriting or forging on the previously uploaded documents.**
3. The electronic bidding system would not allow any late submission of bids after due date and time as per server time. Bidders may modify their bids by uploading their request for modification before the deadline for submission of bids. For this, the bidders needs not to make any additional payment towards the cost of tender documents. For bid modification and consequential re-submission, the bidder is not required to withdraw his bid submitted earlier. The last modified bid submitted by the bidder within the bid submission time shall be considered as the bid. For this purpose, modification/withdrawal by other means will not be accepted. In online system of bid submission, the modification and consequential- submission of bids is allowed any number of times. The bidders may withdraw his bid by uploading their request before the deadline for submission of bids; however, if the bid is withdrawn, the re-submission of the bid is not allowed. No bid shall be modified or withdrawn after the deadline of submission of bids.
4. The date and time of opening of Financial-Bids shall be notified on Website **www.jktenders.gov.in** and conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The **Financial-bids of responsive bidders** shall be opened online in the **Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura.** The date for same shall be intimated separately.
5. The bids for the work shall remain **valid for a period of 120 days from the date of opening of Technical bids.**
6. **The earnest money shall be forfeited, If :-**
   a) Any bidder/tenderer withdraws his bid/tender during the period of bid validity or makes any modifications in the terms and conditions of the bid.
   b) Failure of Successful bidder to furnish the required performance security within specified time period after issuance of letter of acceptance.
   c) Failure of successful bidder to execute the agreement on same day of allotment of work contract as per Chief Engineer PW (R&B) Department Jammu's Circular No. CEJ/G/12660-87 dated 07-10-2021.
7. **Instruction to bidders regarding e-tendering process.**
   7.1 Bidders are advised to download bid submission manual from the **"Downloads"** option as well as from **"Bidders Manual Kit"** on website **www.jktenders.gov.in** to acquaint bid submission process.
   7.2 To participate in bidding process, bidders have to get 'Digital Signature Certificate (DSC)' as per Information Technology Act-2000. Bidders can get digital certificate from any approved vendors
   7.3 The bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic format with digital Signature. No financial bid will be accepted in physical form.
   7.4 Bids will be opened online as per time schedule mentioned above.
   7.5 Bidders must ensure to upload scanned copy of all necessary documents mentioned in NIT and SBD with technical bid online.

No :-
Dated :-

Executive Engineer
PWD (R&B) Division R.S. Pura
DIP/J-6633/26 - DATE 25 JULY 2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Babloo, S/o:** Ramlal **R/o:** KH. No. 191, Jhuggi Kathiya Baba Ashram, Guru Nanak Dev Colony, Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 367/2017, U/s: 279/338 IPC, PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Babloo,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Babloo,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Babloo,** of **FIR No. 367/2017, U/s: 279/338 IPC, PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.09.2026**.

By Order
Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Room No. 06,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/10059/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Harish Chandra S/o** Duli Chand **R/o** Dhaula Kuan Chowki New Delhi **Also At:** Ward No-5, VPO Khanpur, Teh-Buhana, Distt- Jhunjhunu Rajasthan -333516 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 620/2023 U/s 376/377/506 IPC PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Harish Chandra** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Harish Chandra** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Harish Chandra** accused of **FIR No. 620/2023 U/s 376/377/506 IPC PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.08.2026.**

By Order
Sh. Viplav Dabas
ASJ, Special Fast Track Court
Room No. 204, Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/10202/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Intezar S/o Aas Mohammad R/o H, No. 135, Shakoor Nagar, Kutti Wali Gali, Meerut, Uttar Pradesh & H. No. 222, Shakoor Nagar, Kutti Wali Gali, Meerut, Uttar Pradesh** has Committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 0336/2020 U/s 186/353/332/323/307/34 IPC, P.S. New Friends Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Intezar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Intezar** has absconded (or are concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Intezar** of case **FIR No. 0336/2020 U/s 186/353/332/323/307/34 IPC, P.S. New Friends Colony, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.08.2026.**

By Order
Ms. Shivani Chauhan
Additional Session Judge
South East District, Room No. 613,
Fast Track Court - 01,
Saket Courts, Delhi

DP/10237/SE/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Kapil Saini** S/o Sarup Saini R/o Plot No. 700, near SAINI Dharamshala, Mundka, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 499/2025 U/s 76/351(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Mundka, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Kapil Saini** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kapil Saini** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Kapil Saini** in **FIR No. 499/2025 U/s 76/351(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Mundka, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.09.2026**.

By order
Sh. Gaurav Singal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06
West, Room No. 355
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/10105/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Kuldeep S/o** Raj Singh **R/o** H.No. 504, Village Auchandi, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 538/15, U/s: 279/337/338 IPC, PS: Bawana, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Kuldeep,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Kuldeep,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Kuldeep,** of **FIR No. 538/15, U/s: 279/337/338 IPC, PS: Bawana, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.09.2026**.

By Order
Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05, (North)
Court Room No. 114, 1st Floor
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/10091/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

GOVERNMENT OF MEGHALAYA
OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR OF HEALTH SERVICES
MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH (DME),
MEGHALAYA PASTEUR HILLS, SHILLONG
Email ID: pasteurinstituteshili@gmail.com/dmeshillong@gmail.com
Tel No. 0364-2591510/94851 06663

No.DHSME&R/SMC/Tender/VI/45/2026/4246
Dated; Shillong, the 23rd July, 2026

CORRIGENDUM

In partial modification of the NIT No: DHSME&R/ SMC /TENDER/ VI/22/2026/ 3872 dated 7th July, 2026 issued by the Directorate of Health Services Medical Education & Research (DME), Meghalaya, for **"Supply and Installation of set of Equipment/Items for Department of Microbiology, Pathology, Pharmacology & PSM as per NMC at Shillong Medical College, Shillong",** the following corrigendum is hereby notified:

"The last date and time for submission of the bid document is hereby extended from 27/07/2026 up to 1500 Hrs to **04/08/2026** up to 1500 Hrs."

All other terms and conditions of the tender shall remain unchanged.

Sd/-
Director of Health Services
Medical Education & Research (DME)
Meghalaya, Shillong

DIPR No.: 1169
Dated: 23.7.2026

CWG: JULY 23-AUGUST 2

DAY 3 results

LAWN BOWLS
Women's pairs: Rupa Rani Tirkey and Pinki vs Tonga: The duo won in the tiebreak after winning the first set 5-2 and losing the second.
Men's singles: Putul Sonowal: World no. 21 Putul lost to Izzat Shameer of Malaysia. The Malaysian won both sets.

BOXING

Men's 60kg Round of 32: Sachin Siwach (above): The Indian boxer won his bout against Keoma Al-Ahmadieh of Canada by a split decision of 4-1.
3x3 Wheelchair Basketball: Indian women's team lost 16-1 to Wales in the pool match.

SWIMMING
Men's Freestyle 400m: Both Indian swimmers Aryan Nehra and Dhakshan Shashikumar failed to move beyond the heats, finishing eighth and seventh in their respective heats.

INDIA watch

WEIGHTLIFTING
Women's 48 kg: Mirabai Chanu (above) 2:30pm; Men's 60 kg: Rishikanta Singh **2:00pm; Men's 65 kg:** Raja Mathupandi **11:15pm**

GYMNASTICS
Men's All-round final: Yogeshwar Singh, Tapan Mohanty **2:30pm**

LAWN BOWLS
Women's pairs sectional match: Rupa Rani Tirkey and Pinki Singh vs Namibia **1:00 pm onwards;** vs England **7:15 pm onwards** **Men's singles sectional match:** Putul Sonowal vs Shaun James **7:15 pm onwards**

BOXING
Women's 54kg Round of 16: Preeti vs Deborah Mtenje (Malawi) **10:45 pm** **Men's 55kg Round of 16:** Jadumani Singh vs Sumama Rehman (Pakistan) **11:45 pm** **Men's 65kg Round of 16:** Aditya Pratap Yadav vs Nuhu Batte (Uganda) **00:45 am (Monday)**

SWIMMING
Men's 4x200m freestyle heats: Srihari Nataraj, Aryan Nehra, Aneesh Gowda, D Shashi Kumar **4:39 pm; final (if qualified) 1:56 am (Monday)**

Mocked for name, Jhandu lifts himself onto CWG podium

Power-lifter, who sold vegetables and drove e-rickshaws to fund training, wins India's first CWG medal

Jhandu Kumar lifted 190 kg on Friday to take the bronze medal at the Commonwealth Games. He narrowly missed out on gold due to an unsuccessful attempt of 196 kg. PTI

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, July 25

"WHAT'S IN a name?" they say. Ask Jhandu Kumar, who won India's first medal at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

The para powerlifter, who contracted polio when he was four years old, lifted 190kg to win a bronze medal on Friday – a feat he hopes will define him, rather than his name.

Hailing from Harnaut village in Bihar's Nalanda district, Jhandu's name loosely translates to 'incompetent person' in Hindi. However, the 29-year-old, who has sold vegetables and driven e-rickshaws to fund his training, has defied every possible meaning attached to it.

"*Naam me kya rakha hai* (What's in a name)? I embraced this name the moment I realised that identity comes from what you do, not what you are called," Jhandu told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow after winning his medal. "People used to laugh at my name. Today, it was announced from the podium with the Indian flag around me. I can't think of a better moment in my life."

The son of vegetable vendor Ramanand Paswan, Jhandu got his name under unfortunate circumstances. "We are a poor family. He is the youngest in the family. When I was unable to get him proper treatment, I told everyone that I had become a *Jhandu* (an incompetent father). Somehow, everybody started calling him by that name, and it stuck," Ramanand told *The Indian Express*. "But today he has shown that he is capable of anything — the complete opposite of what his name suggests."

Jhandu Kumar at a vegetable market. FILE

When Jhandu stood on the podium and the Indian flag went up, all he could think about was how far he had travelled from his village. "I had never imagined this. I only wanted to prove that I could do something, and that zidd has brought me here," he said.

Apart from battling the stigma and bullying that came with his name, Jhandu also had to support his family. "I used to wake up at 4 am and travel to Bihar Sharif to buy vegetables for my shop. The journey wasn't easy. I would travel 20 km in a shared van and then return home to open the shop," he said. "Some days I would make a profit of Rs 300-400, and on others I would make a loss."

After finishing work at the shop, Jhandu would head to a local gym to train. "I wanted an upper body like Salman Khan in Dabangg. Whatever I learnt was on my own, by watching videos of athletes online on a borrowed phone."

Initially, he trained without any guidance until local coaches Gautam Singh and Kundan Pandey noticed him. "He was incredibly strong. We were surprised that someone could train himself like that. That's when we realised he had real potential," said Kundan, who is also part of the Bihar Para Powerlifting Organisation.

While his career as a para powerlifter began to take off, Jhandu's livelihood came to an abrupt end after a government construction project forced his vegetable shop to shut down. "A powerlifter's diet costs around Rs 1,000 a day, and I was barely earning Rs 500. When the shop closed, I borrowed money to buy a toto (an e-rickshaw). I started ferrying passengers," he recalled.

However, driving passengers every day took a heavy toll on his body.

"It was back-breaking work. I would be exhausted by the time I reached the gym. Before the 2023 Nationals, I decided to sell my e-rickshaw in the hope that I would win a medal," he said.

The gamble didn't pay off immediately. After an exhausting journey in an unreserved train compartment, he failed to register a single successful lift at the competition. But veteran powerlifting coach Rajender Singh Rahelu spotted his potential and invited him to train at the SAI National Centre of Excellence in Gandhinagar.

"It was like divine intervention for me. I thought everything was over, but when Rahelu sir asked me to come to SAI, I felt something good had come out of that gamble," Jhandu said.

• Number Plate

190

• Competing at a body weight of 72.4kgs, Jhandu Kumar lifted 190 kgs to win the bronze medal in the para-weightlifting event at the Commonwealth Games.

> **"We are a poor family. He is the youngest in the family. When I was unable to get him proper treatment, I told everyone that I had become a *Jhandu* (an incompetent father). Somehow, everybody started calling him by that name, and it stuck."**
>
> RAMANAND PASWAN
> JHANDU'S FATHER

Name of a champion

Under expert guidance and professional training, the results soon followed. He broke the national record with a 205kg lift in 2025 and then improved it to 206kg at the Khelo India Games. Later that year, he won bronze at the World Para Powerlifting World Cup in Beijing and another bronze at the Asia-Oceania Championships.

Competing at a bodyweight of 72.4kg in Glasgow, Jhandu narrowly missed his third lift of 196kg, which would have taken him past eventual gold medallist Idris Riluwan of Nigeria. His best attempt of 190kg, however, was enough to ensure a medal.

As he climbed the podium, 'Jhandu' sounded less like an insult and more like the name of a champion determined to prove his doubters wrong.

Swathish excels at Still Rings in Glasgow

Swathish Kaitheri Puthalath executed the 'Maltese Cross' at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Saturday. INSTAGRAM

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 25

"HE DOES it again! A second Maltese!!" the gymnastics commentator at the Commonwealth Games, Kate Downes said, with more than a hint of surprise during the Still Rings performance of India's Swathish Kaitheri Puthalath. It had been a second perfect execution of the Maltese cross after the first, and watching an Indian pull it off had been delightful for the Glasgow crowd.

On the Maltese cross, perfection means stillness. The manoeuvre is also called a Swallow, like the bird in perfect flight. Unmoving arms stretched out between the Rings. The torso and pointy-toed, steely feet, suspended parallel to the ground, a cross in horizontal plane.

On his double tumble, single twist, tuck dismount — i.e when he landed with a deep full-in, and one balanced step on earth — Swathish sported a punch-pleased grin. The 12.450 score flashed soon after. It would put him 11th in a field of 58 Rings performers at his Glasgow debut. He is second reserve for an apparatus final. But the two seconds of strength each — 4 in all, was a pause that was pregnant with potential.

National coach Rakesh Patra, a Rings specialist himself, had put in 6 months to swing in his controlled Swallow ahead of the 2018 Commonwealth Games. Though Patra had admitted he only tweaked the Indian squad's movements in a short camp — polishing the hand bend, swing, (called Azarian) and how to recover the body for the third rotation of Rings after impact of Floor Exercise and Vault, it helped push up the Execution Score.

The initial strength work, difficulty training, motivation and convincing Swathish he shouldn't be wasting away his life back in Kolachery, Kannur, was done by another Sports Authority of India coach, Abhishek Sharma.

Rough start

It was MP-born gymnastics coach Abhishek's first appointment after coaching levels exams — at a SAI scheme centre in Kerala in 2014. It was the worst time to start there because the men's programme was being shut down. Swathish was irregular, disinterested, strong and very talented.

His father had passed away, and one day his mother who worked cleaning and sorting jobs at people's homes, came frantically looking for her son, even as Abhishek had sought permission to run a 'Come & Play' training for beginners where Swathish dawdled in at times.

The mother told the coach Swathish wasn't at school, nor at gymnastics. He had begun to tag along with loafers, drunks and assorted addicts, getting home late, or sometimes not at all till next morning. "I called him over and in front of his mother gave him a scolding asking him if he didn't care for her struggle in raising him and who would support her if not him. It was harsh, but needed," Abhishek recalls.

The daily training he started next day morning, never slackened. State and Khelo India medals arrived, and the State CM would felicitate him in 2019, handing over Rs 8 lakh that stabilised his financial situation. During the pandemic, Swathish would take online classes and continue training on smaller elements.

Still Rings is a strength-heavy routine with 9 elements and a dismount, and Swathish got better even as he followed his coach to his next posting at Kolkata. "I had asked many talented gymnasts if they would train at Kolkata. Only Swathish arrived. He called from the railway station and lived with us few months."

Abhishek would take him through the swings, strength holds (like vertical Iron cross, horizontal Maltese or swallow), as he became one of the best in Swallows. What impressed commentators was his transfer from a solid Iron cross (hands outstretched, feet perpendicular) into a Maltese swallow. Second was the eye-popping Iron cross, front giant to handstand, swinging with Azarian felge (complete wheel rotation with body as diameter) through to second Maltese.

The likes of Canadian William Emard of (13.850) and Kiwi Daniel Stoddart (12.800) are known to weave in a Maltese or two. But for an Indian to pose with stillness where neither the body, nor rings or suspensions, shake or waver, was impressive. He missed the final by a mere 0.350.

The slow roll backwards to straighten arms between rings was technically professional and solid — shoulder and core strength combined with mental sturdiness. It was a metaphor for when Abhishek had persuaded Swathish to forget his meandering, aimless ways. Even as he awaits a chance as reserve to make it to finals, Indian gymnastics has once more found a talent worth backing, alongside the technically strong Tapan Mohanty.

The Prez who lifted, the PM who bowled — when heads of state competed at CWG

Sriram Veera
Mumbai, July 25

NAURU AND Niue are self-governing Pacific nations of a few thousand people, and both have had a head of government compete at the Commonwealth Games. Nauru's Marcus Stephen did it years before he ever held office. Niue's Dalton Tagelagi did it while he was already Prime Minister. Neither is on the floor at Glasgow.

Stephen was Nauru's lone athlete at the 1990 Auckland Games, a twenty-year-old ranked fourth or fifth in his weightlifting class, not expected to medal. Nauru had joined the Commonwealth Games Federation three days earlier. "When I won a gold and two silvers," Stephen told Inside the Games, "it was a real shock." Nauru declared a public holiday. The Nauru Weightlifting Federation had been founded the year before, mostly so he could compete internationally.

Two years later, wanting to lift at Barcelona, Stephen discovered Nauru wasn't yet an IOC member. "Little did they know," he told *RNZ*, "that you have to be a member first." Nauru's leaders arranged for him a Samoan passport, and he competed under a flag that wasn't his, finishing ninth.

Commonwealth star

By Atlanta 1996, Nauru had its own membership, and Stephen carried its flag into the opening ceremony himself. He retired in 2002 after competing at four Commonwealth Games, winning seven golds and five silvers, more than any Commonwealth weightlifter except one.

A year later, he was in parliament, taking up the seat his father had held for two decades, mostly, he has said, because it was expected of him. He became president in December 2007.

The next four years in his new avatar were volatile: opposition Speaker David Adeang accused his administration of effectively staging a coup, a state of emergency followed, and two elections in one year ended in a deadlock. He resigned in November 2011 amid a corruption allegation over a phosphate deal, which he called "unwarranted and mischievous" and which was never tested in court. A former Secretary of Justice would later suggest those chaotic years might be remembered as Nauru's high point for good governance.

Writing in *The New York Times* that same year, Stephen called Nauru, its interior scarred and uninhabitable after a century of phosphate mining, an "indispensible cautionary tale about life in a place with hard ecological limits." He lost his parliamentary seat in 2016, returned in 2019, and is now, per Nauru's own government bulletin, the longest-serving Speaker in the country's history.

Nauru's Marcus Stephen (L); Niue's Dalton Tagelagi. IWF/FACEBOOK

Parellel lives

He still runs the sport that made him: president of Nauru's Olympic Committee and the Oceania Weightlifting Federation. Four Nauruan weightlifters are in Glasgow this week. He'll watch from that vantage, not the platform.

> ***Both men are watching Glasgow from outside the competition. Stephen's absence is the settled kind: his sport and his politics were always two different chapters.***

Niue's Tagelagi debuted in lawn bowls at Glasgow 2014, a private citizen then, and returned at Gold Coast 2018 as a junior minister, losing 21–7 in the singles. Across those two Games he won a single match, much as Stephen once had. He became Prime Minister in June 2020, elected by Niue's Assembly - 13 votes to 7. That is where the similarities end.

Two years later, he went to Birmingham as a competitor and a head of government at once, partnering his own 14-year-old son in the pairs event. They lost every match, as did every other Niuean bowler.

The Games were the least complicated part of that fortnight: Niue's Lawn Bowls Association had taken the country's sports federation to the Niue High Court, arguing the Birmingham team, Tagelagi's team, had been selected without authority.

The court agreed, ruling the selection null and void weeks before the team flew out; an injunction to ground the bowlers was narrowly avoided. Tagelagi split that fortnight between Birmingham and Wellington, meeting New Zealand's Prime Minister even as the court case unfolded back home.

A Niuean boxer won the country's first-ever Commonwealth medal at those same Games while the Prime Minister's team went winless.

He isn't in Glasgow this week either, the first Games in three he's missed. Niue held a general election on 2 May, and the leadership vote was the tightest of his career, 11 to 9. He was sworn in for a third term ten weeks before these Games began. Both men are watching Glasgow from outside the competition. Stephen's absence is the settled kind: his sport and his politics were always two different chapters, and he has spent two decades since as a former athlete embedded in the sport's administration, no longer needing to compete to belong to it. Tagelagi's is the unsettled kind: a Prime Minister who was still bowling at the last Games, and isn't at this one, ten weeks into the tightest mandate of his career.

String of poor returns puts Sharma in the dock

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 25

ABHISHEK SHARMA'S dismissal in India's second T20I against Zimbabwe on Saturday was, paradoxically, both an anomaly and entirely familiar.

An anomaly because of how it unfolded. Sharma – the world's No. 1-ranked T20I batter not too long ago – meekly pushed a Blessing Muzarabani delivery straight to Ryan Burl at backward point. Stripped of context, it could easily have passed for a routine fielding drill. This manner of departure – on a whimper, and not aplomb – is not in synchronisation with the southpaw's batting style. But while it seems like an exception in isolation, it was the 10th time in his last 17 T20Is that Sharma had fallen for 10 or fewer, raising fresh questions about how long the 'longer rope' the team management has given him is.

Sharma's form took a nosedive during the initial stages of this year's T20 World Cup, wherein he was dismissed for a duck on three consecutive occasions. The rut effectively ended with a 55 against this very opposition, but perhaps Zimbabwe seemed intent on testing whether the revival was real. Accordingly, they began the bowling with Sikandar Raza – a right-arm everything spinner, bowling off-spin on this particular occasion, which proved to be Sharma's Achilles' heel at the World Cup.

• Number Plate

19.41

● Abhishek Sharma averages 19.41 in 17 T20I matches since the start of 2026 T20 World Cup.

The plan did not reap rewards, as the opener struck two boundaries off that first over. Both were in the extra cover region, but the manner of shots was contrasting – the first was lofted with elegance, the second was slapped with disdain. The promise, however, proved fleeting. An over later, Muzarabani dismissed him.

Sharma's numbers have significantly steered south since the T20 World Cup. His average – 37.05 before the competition – is now 19.41.

Scrutiny over Sharma's place in the side, therefore, would hardly be misplaced – not only because of his own prolonged struggles, but also because of the standards India have applied to their other top-order batters. Sanju Samson was given only three opportunities after the tournament before being axed from the Zimbabwe squad. Ishan Kishan, though retained, was demoted to the number three slot after underwhelming displays against the Netherlands and South Africa. With every puzzle of the great Indian cricketing jigsaw being transient and movable, there has been an element of permanence and immobility about Abhishek Sharma. For how long, though, is the question.

Anahat scripts history with World Junior squash title

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, July 25

INDIAN SQUASH prodigy Anahat Singh created history on Saturday, as she became the first Indian to win a squash world title at any level after winning the World Junior Championships in Ontario, Canada. The 19-year-old Indian defeated second seed Ruqayya Salem of Egypt in straight games 11-3, 11-7, 11-9.

Prior to this achievement, she had already become the second Indian woman after Joshna Chinappa to enter the final of the world junior title. Now, she has conquered a frontier that even Chinappa could not. The teenage prodigy from Delhi had a dominant start to the final, winning the first game 11-3, leaving her opponent Salem with little to no chance.

In the second game, Anahat won 11-7 and had one hand on the title. However, the Egyptian gave a scare in the third game, with Anahat trailing 6-8 at one point. But the Indian fended off the pressure and took the important points to win the game 11-9 and claim the junior title at the fifth time of asking.

"I still feel like I am dreaming. This tournament has been the worst for me as I have been losing in semis and quarters every edition," Anahat told Squash TV after her title win.

Indeed, there was a period where the World Junior Squash Championships felt like a curse to the wunderkind, as Anahat repeatedly failed to progress beyond the quarter or semi-finals. All of her last three appearances have ended in quarters.

Anahat Singh, 19, beat second seed Ruqayya Salem of Egypt 11-3, 11-7, 11-9. FILE

In the 2025 edition, she made it to the semi-final but lost to Egypt's Nadien Elhammamy 3-0 before clinching the bronze medal. However, in her last chance on the junior circuit, Anahat delivered.

"This tournament has been like a curse to me as I have been losing in semis and quarters. I knew this was my last chance to win this tournament," she said.

Having turned pro at the age of 16, Anahat is already a seasoned campaigner, with a world ranking of 20 and multiple Asian Games medals under her belt. The experience was on display as she blunted the retaliation from the Egyptian in the third game.

When asked if she had realised she was trailing, Anahat said, "I didn't even realise the scores. I realised that I have lost a few points in a row and I need to play my game. I just made sure that I am hitting my lines well. I just wanted to enjoy every moment of playing in the World Championships final."

21 years ago, Joshna Chinappa had entered the final, but finished with a silver medal after losing to Raneem El Weiley of Egypt.

Anahat not only achieved unprecedented success for India, but she also broke the Egyptian dominance in the tournament. She happens to be the first non-Egyptian winner of the tournament in 16 years, after Amanda Shoby of the USA won it in 2010.

Currently coached by former world champion Gregory Gaultier and mentored by Indian legend Saurav Ghosal, Anahat is expected to lead the charge of Indian hopes at the 2028 LA Olympics.

SECOND T20I, HARARE

Varma backs his strike-rate talk in India's series-clinching win

Vice-captain's 29-ball 60 in India's 219/5 seals 90-run victory vs Zimbabwe as captain Iyer tastes first bilateral win

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 25

BEFORE INDIA'S three-T20I series against Zimbabwe, Tilak Varma had ventured his views on the strike rate discourse: only if the team does not lose early wickets, he can hit boundaries from ball one. On Saturday, he let his willow back his words, hitting five fours and three sixes in his unbeaten 29-ball 60, the first of those boundaries coming off the second delivery. India, banking on the vice-captain and Ishan Kishan's exploits, scored 219/5, securing a 90-run victory, and sealing the series as Zimbabwe could only muster 129.

The final scorecard, India's sixth-highest T20I total away from home, suggests a comfortable evening. For a brief while, it looked anything but.

Abhishek Sharma's lean run continued as he fell in the second over, meekly pushing a Blessing Muzarabani delivery straight to Ryan Burl at backward point. Vaibhav Sooryavanshi briefly restored the momentum with three fours and a six off Richard Ngarava, only for the left-arm quick to exact revenge. Just as it had in England, the short ball exposed the teenage prodigy.

The next phase of play highlighted a quality that has been found wanting in Indian cricket in recent times, role clarity. Kishan, riding a rich vein of form, assumed the responsibility of boundary-hitting. Captain Shreyas Iyer, meanwhile, played the stabiliser, ensuring India did not once again succumb to a familiar collapse.

Tilak Varma plays a lofted shot during his 60-run knock against Zimbabwe on Saturday. AP

By the halfway mark, Kishan was scoring at over 150, allowing Iyer's run-a-ball approach to coexist without dragging India's scoring rate. Their 66-run stand for the third wicket ended off the final ball of the 10th over when Iyer holed out to backward point.

At 95 for 3, with Kishan well set at the other end, caution from Varma would have served neither India's cause nor his own. Instead, he scored the second fastest fifty of his international career, ending with a strike rate of 206.89.

The onslaught began in the 14th over. Muzarabani was reintroduced to find wickets, but all he found was shots with spite and conviction from Varma; three consecutive boundaries came off that over. In the next over, Kishan bettered his partner, with two fours and a six.

On the occasions where they could not find boundaries, the pair of southpaws did well to rotate strike. Between the second delivery of the 13th over to the first of the 18th, where Kishan lost his wicket after scoring a 44-ball 81, India negotiated 28 deliveries without playing a dot. The last seven overs of India's innings yielded 98 runs, at 14 per over.

Comfortable with ball

India's start with the ball mirrored their batting, underwhelming. The first three overs yielded 23 runs, as Mayank Yadav, after what was an exemplary comeback, could not replicate either the consistency or the sharpness from barely 48 hours ago. Yash Thakur, however, needed only 11 deliveries to claim his maiden international wicket, Brian Bennett's half-hearted scoop looping comfortably into Ishan Kishan's gloves.

Prince Yadav struck with the very first over of his spell, a sharply directed short ball accounting for Ben Curran and ensuring Sooryavanshi was no longer alone in the catching column. Spin arrived in the final over of the Powerplay through Ravi Bishnoi, and with it came another breakthrough. Dion Myers misread the wrong'un, adding to Zimbabwe's mounting troubles. Yadav added a second to his name in the next over, and at 49/4, the game had steered towards its foregone conclusion.

That Zimbabwe batted till the 18th over is predominantly owing to Tadiwanashe Marumani and Brad Evans showing some semblance of resilience. The former scored a 19-ball 24, while the latter struck 19 in 11 deliveries.

The pair can take pride in their exertion, but from the macrocosmic perspective, their efforts were academic as Zimbabwe were 90 runs short of what India had accumulated. While the trio of Yadav, Thakur and Bishnoi began India's sweeping job with the ball, they had an unlikely contributor towards the end, with Abhishek Sharma taking three wickets. Not that his wickets will compensate for his lack of runs, but for what it is worth, his 3/17 was Sharma's best bowling figures in international cricket.

With this victory, Shreyas Iyer has now won his maiden series as India's captain, and while the opposition might not have been the toughest he has faced so far, the triumph should provide the team with a boost of some sort ahead of their impending T20I challenge against the West Indies in October.

BRIEF SCORES: Zimbabwe 129 all out (Brian Bennett 32, Tadiwanashe Marumani 24; Abhishek Sharma 3/17) lost to **India** 219/5 (Ishan Kishan 81, Tilak Varma 60*; Brian Bennett 1/22) by 90 runs

Felt anything around 180 would be good total on this pitch: Kishan

ISHAN KISHAN anchored India's commanding 90-run victory over Zimbabwe in the second T20I, smashing 80 to steer the visitors to 219 and seal an unassailable 2-0 lead in the three-match series. Named Player of the Match, Kishan said his focus remained on batting to his strengths despite wickets falling around him.

"You don't think about the wickets that have already fallen. The past is past. You just keep watching the ball. You know your strengths, you know where you can score and which bowlers you can target. It's about being smart in the middle. I kept things very simple and just backed myself to play my shots all around the ground," he said after receiving the Player of the Match award.

"To be very honest, I didn't feel this was the kind of wicket where you could just walk in and score 200-plus runs. We felt anything around 180 would be a good total because there was variable bounce on a few deliveries. So we knew partnerships were going to be very important. But as a number three batter, once you're set, you want to make it count and score big runs so that your team gets to a total like the 220-odd we managed today," he added.

Meanwhile, an injury to fast bowler Prince Yadav is set to force India into changes for Sunday's third and final T20I, captain Shreyas Iyer confirmed after the series-clinching win.

Prince pulled up while delivering the second ball of his second over, clutching his hamstring before hobbling off the field. The right-arm seamer had already picked up two wickets. ENS

• BRIEFLY

Mohun Bagan celebrate their 1-0 win over East Bengal. PTI

KOLKATA DERBY

Clinical Mohun Bagan beat East Bengal in Durand Cup opener

Mohun Bagan Super Giant combined clinical finishing with resolute defending to edge arch-rivals and East Bengal 1-0 in the Durand Cup at the Salt Lake Stadium on Saturday. Sahal Abdul Samad's 52nd-minute strike proved decisive as Bagan made the most of their best opportunity, while Vishal Kaith produced a commanding display between the posts. The winning goal stemmed from relentless pressing high up the pitch. Mohun Bagan youngster Kiyan Nassiri won possession on the edge of the East Bengal penalty area before driving to the byline and squaring the ball across the six-yard box where Manvir Singh attempted a clever backheel but failed to connect. The loose ball rolled to Sahal, who calmly slotted into an unguarded net. PTI

Sonam, Elavenil reach finals but miss podium

SONAM UTTAM Maskar and Olympian Elavenil Valarivan produced strong performances to reach the women's 10m air rifle final but fell short of the medals, finishing fifth and sixth respectively at the ISSF World Cup. Sonam impressed in qualification, shooting 634.3 to finish second behind China's Du Yuchen, who topped the field with 634.4. Elavenil also qualified comfortably after placing sixth with a score of 632.8. However, the Indian duo could not replicate their qualification form in the eight-shooter final, finishing fifth and sixth respectively. Sixteen-year-old Du Yuchen claimed the first ISSF World Cup medal of her career, winning gold with a score of 254.6 in the final. PTI

Pak penalised for fielding extra players vs India

THE PAKISTAN hockey team management was left red faced when the umpires penalized the side for fielding six instead of five players against India in the five-a-side international event being held in Muscat, Oman. The incident took place on Friday night when as soon as the match started the umpires spotted six Pakistani players on the field whereas only five are allowed. As a result the umpires sent out two players, leaving Pakistan with just three players on the field. India took full advantage of the situation, slamming in 8 goals. The PHF has sought an explanation from the team management, which includes chief coach Tahir Zaman and coaches Rehan Butt, Qamar Ibrahim and Umar Bhutta. PTI

Norris takes pole position for Hungarian GP

FORMULA ONE world champion Lando Norris put McLaren on pole position for the Hungarian Grand Prix to end Mercedes' qualifying domination. Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton, chasing his first pole since Hungary 2023, missed out by a mere 0.012 seconds and was then demoted three places by stewards for impeding Norris's teammate Oscar Piastri. Ferrari team boss Fred Vasseur said it was the team's mistake, with Hamilton not receiving the radio message in time. That lifted Ferrari's Charles Leclerc from third to the front row, with Mercedes F1 leader Kimi Antonelli provisionally taking his place. It was the first time this season that Mercedes had not secured pole for a GP. REUTERS

Tour de France route trimmed after wildfires

THE TOUR de France's last stage Sunday is being slashed in length by a third to divert officers to the fight against wildfires in the country's southwest. The Paris police department said in a statement Saturday that the riders will race inside Paris, rather than starting from Thoiry, west of the capital, on a circuit of 89 kilometres, down from the 133-kilometre route that had been planned. The statement said part of the security deployment planned for the 21st and final stage of the three-week race will instead "reinforce the response efforts in the areas affected by the wildfires." Meanwhile, Ecuador's Richard Carapaz claimed victory on stage 20 on Saturday. AP

• ULTIMATE TABLE TENNIS

Manush's double act sends U Mumba into final

Bhuvan Gupta
Panaji, July 25

MANUSH SHAH has been flying the Indian flag high in doubles, rising to an unprecedented world number 2 along with Manav Thakkar recently. On Saturday, he came up clutch with his singles game to eke out the tie-winning points for U Mumba against Ankur Bhattacharjee and HVR Kolkata Thunder Blades. Manush, who had set it up by winning his mixed doubles rubber prior to that, hence powered the Mumbai-based franchise into the Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) season 7 final.

They will defend their title against the unbeaten Dempo Goa Challengers on Sunday.

Ankur, dubbed the 'Conor McGregor of Indian TT' by commentator Adam Bobrow for his combative style, was not an easy opponent by any means. The 19-year-old had not tasted defeat in the 2025 edition and was one of just four players retained across the six teams, this time around.

But Manush, ranked 40th in singles, employed his pedigree and years on the circuit to dismantle Ankur 11-7, 11-5. "Ankur is a strong player and I think we have a good bond as well. But at the same time, we are professional athletes and he is playing very well at the moment. For me, it was very important to stick to the tactics and the coaches and the support staff helped me with it," Manush told *The Indian Express*.

Juggling singles with doubles is admittedly "the most challenging part" for Manush currently. "I try to keep up with the workload management. I feel I must recover from each particular match. It is tough but I am managing all the events pretty well and hopefully in the coming Asian Games, we will do wonders."

Asked if he was prioritising one format over the other, the 25-year-old pithily responded, "my priority is exactly what next match I am going to play".

Manush Shah beat Ankur Bhattacharjee 11-7, 11-5. UTT

Kolkata drew first blood in the tie. In a rollercoaster of an opening game, Eduardo Ionescu employed third-ball attacks to target both corners of Lilian Bardet's court and repeatedly prevail in short rallies. He took the game 11-9.

The rallies became longer and play turned more riveting in the second, which went to a golden point. Ionescu extracted the error from the Frenchman's forehand to subject him to only his second defeat of the season. Bardet clawed one back for U Mumba by taking the third game, another topsy-turvy one with a five-point lead built and erased, 11-8.

In the second match, Ayhika Mukherjee was forced onto the backfoot from the outset by Anna Hursey. The 20-year-old Welsh player directed most of her attacking venom towards Ayhika's backhand, depriving the Indian of time and space to twiddle her racket or smash from the forehand. But the West Bengal paddler did her supposed job in the singles rubber by taking a game off the fancied Hursey.

It was in the subsequent mixed doubles clash where Ayhika, allied with Ankur, was expected to deliver the goods for Kolkata. Manush, however, had other ideas.

The doubles star brandished the power of his forehand topspins to deleterious effect. Together with Hursey, he completed an 11-7, 11-5, 11-2 shellacking of the Bengali duo to propel the reigning champs to a 6-3 advantage in the tie.

Manush was not done yet. He knew he had to blunt Ankur to make sure Nithyashree Mani did not have to face the daunting challenge of Zeng Jian in a potential decider. The southpaw did just that, and in style.

World Cup hero Vozinha finds club

Associated Press
Santiago, July 25

ONE OF the breakout stars at the 2026 FIFA World Cup has a new home in Chile - Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha has signed a contract with Colo Colo, the South American country's biggest football team.

The 40-year-old Vozinha became one of the most talked-about players at the World Cup with a string of remarkable saves against top teams such as eventual champion Spain and defending champion Argentina.

"Welcome. We're waiting for you," the club wrote Friday on its social media pages in a post that quickly sparked excitement not only among Colo Colo supporters but across Chile, where the national team failed this year to qualify for a third consecutive World Cup.

Anibal Mosa, president of Blanco y Negro, the company that manages the Chilean club, had confirmed shortly before that the goalkeeper, who had no contract with any team during the World Cup, will arrive in Chile soon.

Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha was without a team during the World Cup. REUTERS

"Vozinha is going to be a Colo Colo player. In the next few days, he will travel to Chile, undergo the necessary medical examinations, and then be presented here at the Estadio Monumental," Mosa told media, referring to Colo Colo's home stadium in Santiago, Chile's capital.

Vozinha's exposure at the World Cup has seen his social media accounts increase from just under 50,000 to nearly 29 million.

Local media said the contract was for 18 months.

Josimar Dias, better known as Vozinha, led Cape Verde, a small island country off the western coast of Africa, to a strong run in the tournament until losing to Lionel Messi's Argentina 3-2 in extra time in the round of 32.

Vozinha's appearance and exposure at the World Cup has seen his social media accounts increase from just under 50,000 to nearly 29 million.

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A green-flag love story

How *Musafir Cafe* explores desire and ambition and why ordinary relationships deserve extraordinary storytelling

SPOTLIGHT | PAGE 4

When the streets find their sound

ADDING CULTURE TO MILK

From Mumbai to Shimla, meet the makers who are leading the artisanal cheese boom in India, wooing consumers with infusions of wild-foraged cumin, onion flowers, nuts and raisins

Heena Khandelwal

IN HER bedroom in Mulund, a young woman turned a fridge into a cheese cave. She tweaked the thermostat until it held steady at 13 degrees Celsius, dropped a hygrometer inside to track humidity and started ageing wheels of cheese. At one point, she had 25 varieties in there and the room smelled unmistakably of mould. She was still commuting to a corporate job on weekdays. On weekends, she made cheese.

Mausam Narang is one of a handful of people who has ventured into making homegrown cheese. Then there's a postdoctoral researcher who had left Canada; a Food Studies dropout from New York University; a restaurateur frustrated by imported cheese and lack of cold-chain supply; an Indo-French couple who moved to the Himalayas on instinct and now make Western-style artisanal cheese, from Indian milk.

Up until a decade ago, cheese in most Indian homes meant a cheese slice or a cheese cube. Today, there is a small but fast-growing constellation of makers — Eleftheria and The Cheese Collective in Mumbai; Begum Victoria in Bengaluru; Amiksa in the hills above Shimla and half a dozen others — producing brie, burrata, gouda, feta and smoked cheddar.

Why cheese and why not

To understand why artisanal cheese is having a moment now, it helps to understand why it barely existed before. Though India is a milk civilisation, the specific alchemy of European cheesemaking — curdling milk with rennet, salting it, ageing it in caves — never took root here.

Cheesemaker and consultant Aditya Raghavan traces this to something concrete: traditional rennet, sourced from the stomach of an unweaned calf, became unavailable in India after the slaughter of young animals was prohibited on cultural and religious grounds. The import of rennet was also banned in 1984.

There is a parallel taboo around curdling milk deliberately. Chhena, the base for rasgulla and sandesh, was historically seen in many Hindu households as spoiled milk, something faintly inauspicious.

Mansi Jasani, known professionally as Cheesewali, founder of The Cheese Collective, talks of the climatic argument that cheese, at its core, is a technology for surviving winter. "European farmers dealt with a seasonal glut of summer milk and no refrigeration, so they spoiled it deliberately, adding salt and bacteria to buy themselves time. A French basement sits at a cool, stable 12 degrees Celsius — perfect for ageing wine or cheese. India never had that problem or that infrastructure," she says, because milk was always consumed fresh or turned into paneer, ghee or dahi — products meant to be used, not stored. What was needed then was lab-produced vegetarian rennet (now widely available), reliable cold chain and, most of all, a willing audience who had tasted the real thing abroad and wanted it at home.

The first wave

But, before any of the current makers existed, there were older outposts. In Kalimpong, in northern Bengal, a semi-hard, Gouda-style cheese was reportedly introduced by Swiss missionaries who founded the Swiss Welfare Dairy there in the 1950s; production ceased in the 1990s. In the south, Auroville's cheese programme and La Ferme Cheese have been there for almost four decades.

And in the west, there was Sohrab Chinoy, founder of ABC Farms in Pune. He started his first cheese factory in 1976 with just Rs 25,000, repurposing two 200-litre drums and second-hand refrigerators. As business grew, in the 1980s, internationally trained Indian chefs began seeking authentic gouda, cheddar, bel paese and blue cheese. The breakthrough came when Indian Airlines started sourcing ABC Farms's cheese for sandwiches, later serving its cheese boards to first-class international passengers. "In the late 1980s, we started a cheese festival where we would lay out a huge cheese board and encourage people to try them before they made a purchase," says Chinoy's daughter Diana Sadri (née Chinoy), second-generation cheesemaker and Director of ABC Farms. Today, their products are available in Mumbai, Goa, Mahabaleshwar, Panchgani and Pune, with over 40 varieties, from aged cheddar to delicate French-style ripened cheese.

The hardest to shift is price and palate education. A kilo of paneer sells for roughly Rs 500-600. Artisanal cheese runs four to six times that but persuading a first-time buyer of that math takes time

The Seekers

For artisanal cheese as an industry, the inflection point came between 2012 and 2015, concentrated largely in Mumbai. Cheese enthusiasts started bringing out their dairy thermometers and swishing the cream line to separate the milk and the whey.

Jasani, having interned as a cheesemonger at Murray's Cheese in New York, returned to Mumbai wanting to do more. Around the same time, Raghavan was making goat cheese on weekends in Alberta, working from a book, before a stint on a Canadian sheep farm convinced him to come home and do it properly. Narang, who would go on to found Eleftheria, was experimenting with fresh mozzarella and burrata in her mother's Mumbai kitchen, working her way up from four litres of milk to 80. Prateeksh Mehra, co-founder of Spotted Cow Fromagerie, was focusing on brie and camembert. Whenever any of them travelled, they would bring back cheese for the others. It was a small, informal, mutually reinforcing circle, with a shared obsession that spawned in the same city at the same time.

Now, however, the geography has widened. In Bengaluru, chef Manu Chandra and Shruti Golchha's Begum Victoria is bringing a bit of Europe onto southern plates. When they began in 2018, good cheese simply wasn't reaching intact. Import processes were slow and batches would spoil at port before they ever reached a kitchen. "We started procuring milk from domestic breeds. Many of those cows graze near the Tamil Nadu border, eat flowers and berries and whatever is growing, which adds character to the cheese," says Chandra. "For a high-fat cheese like a double cream brie, we have to buy cream separately to bolster the quantity," he adds. Today, Begum Victoria's brie is served on the menus of Chandra's own restaurant Lupa and Hunger Inc's The Bombay Canteen, winning a clientele that keeps coming back. (Their 200 gm brie cheese is priced at Rs 550).

In the hills above Shimla, it was a different search for cheese. Debarati and her French husband François Laederich — who is trained in cheesemaking — went looking for a home in Himachal Pradesh on a scooty, kids wedged between them, journeying purely by instinct. This was 2019. They found a shuttered building in Mashobra. At that time, they didn't know of the terrain's commercial potential. The mountains came first, the cheese followed, because in France, she says, cheesemaking has always been linked to mountain life. Amiksa, their brand, which means cheese curds in Sanskrit is now found in Chandigarh, Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Spiti. Their feeding partner restaurants include Olive, ITC and the Oberoi in Delhi.

Threading through some of these ventures is one name: Raghavan, who has consulted close to nine cheesemaking setups across the country, from a raw-milk dairy farm on Chennai's OMR to a two-season stint at 14,000 ft in Spiti's Demul village, where he helped develop a cheddar flavoured with wild-foraged cumin and onion flowers.

The Palate Shifters

None of these cheeses are, strictly, Indian inventions. They borrow names and techniques from France, Italy, Holland, Norway. But nearly every maker has bent the form toward Indian taste in ways that wouldn't exist anywhere else. Amiksa's Cumin Gouda and its nut-and-raisin Borsalinuts, developed at a Punjabi customer's suggestion, are unheard of in Europe.

Eleftheria's Kaali Miri — laced with Kerala black pepper, crushed garlic and Himalayan salt (Rs 350 for 200 gm) — is what won over Narang's parents, who were suspicious of everything mouldy. The award-winning Brunost (Rs 375 for 150 gm), a Norwegian style whey cheese that resembles Kandi Pedha in looks and flavour notes, has 'EL and F' written in Devnagri, to give it that local edge. In Chennai, Namrata Sundaresan of Käse rubs her cheddar cheese in podi, meant to be folded straight into a dosa.

Separate from all this sits a small set of genuinely indigenous cheese that predate the artisanal movement entirely — Kalari from Jammu and Kashmir's pastoral herders; Bandel from Bengal; Churpi from the Himalayan northeast — none of them modelled on European technique, all of them shaped by climate, cattle and necessity. Raghavan describes it as fundamentally pastoral: no salt, almost no shelf life, meant to be eaten where it's made, best known today as the cheese that is folded into a Kashmiri kulcha.

The not-so cheesy bits

Farm, temperature and price — these seem to be the larger barriers that curdles the end game. "The challenge starts at the farm. People need to understand that animal health matters, what the animals eat matters and that hormonal injections should not be given. That knowledge, resulting in clean and consistent milk and then the cold transport of that milk to the facility — that's the first hurdle," says Jasani, adding that the second challenge is the cold chain.

Cheese needs to sit between 4 and 7 degrees Celsius continuously, a narrow band that Indian courier and retail infrastructure still struggles to guarantee, and India's heat, well above a cheese's own melting point, doesn't help. Third, and, perhaps, the hardest to shift is price and palate education. A kilo of paneer sells for roughly Rs 500-600. On the other hand, artisanal cheese runs four to six times that, and for defensible reasons — small batches, fresh milk, no shortcuts — but persuading a first-time buyer of that math takes time.

Mumbai-based Aditi Prabhu, a clinical and sports nutritionist, is a case in point. She was tired of the same processed cheese cubes she had grown up on. She began reading in depth about artisanal cheese about seven-eight years ago, buying it wherever she travelled. "I enjoyed Kodai Cheese (gouda 200 gm for Rs 350) in Goa, they are easily available there but not so in Mumbai," she says, adding that she started looking for brands available in supermarkets around her home in Borivali, or ones that delivered at home. "Eleftheria is my go-to," says Prabhu, who now has cheese at least five to seven days in a month. "I like mozzarella with my crackers and khakra, halloumi in stir-fries, burrata in my salads, and the fun, stretchy, yarn-ball-like Oaxaca just as it is."

She also started asking her clients to include artisanal cheese in their diet but noticed resistance. "People aren't sure about its taste, how to add it to their diet and, most importantly, its nutrition aspect," she says. Unlike paneer, cheese is seen as an indulgence. "There are certain cheese that are high in protein and easy on your gut, say halloumi, burrata and goat cheese but that aspect has almost always been overlooked," she says, adding that price is another concern for her clients.

Brands understand this too, and that's, perhaps, why they are investing time in educating people on how best to enjoy their cheese. Eleftheria, Amiksa and Käse are among those that clearly list on their websites how each cheese is best enjoyed.

From cooking videos to putting out recipes made using cheese variants, there are customer awareness campaigns these makers run on social media. The country's rising purchasing power has pushed the trend towards adopting artisanal cheese upward. Eleftheria has grown 30 per cent year-on-year since the pandemic pushed it into direct-to-consumer sales.

Many of these makers, including Eleftheria, The Cheese Collective, Amiksa, Käse and others, banded together last year to form the Indian Artisanal Cheese Association, aimed at promoting Indian-made cheese and supporting new entrants.

Asked where they see it all going, Jasani points to Japan's own decades-long adoption of European cheesemaking, of bloomy rinds wrapped in sakura leaves and string cheese brushed with soy. She believes India is somewhere near the start of the same arc: importing a technique, then slowly, unmistakably, making it its own.

SAY CHEESE (Clockwise from top left) Mansi Jasani of The Cheese Collective; a Begum Victoria cheese board; chef Manu Chandra; François Laederich of Amiksa; Sohrab Chinoy of ABC Farms with his family; (left) Mausam Narang of Eleftheria

The Things They Carry

The anthology, edited by Susan Abulhawa, brings together works by of 18 writers from Gaza to shed light on life amid destruction

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

PICKING UP THE PIECES
Destruction in Gaza

Madhurita Goswami

HOW DO you welcome children into a world that allows their killing? How do you cope with the loss of a brother in a family struggling to survive? How does a disability affect you when everyone is fleeing for their lives?

These are some of the questions that Palestinian writers grapple with in *Every Moment Is a Life: Gaza in the Time of Genocide*, an anthology edited by Palestinian-American writer Susan Abulhawa. The collection brings together the short stories by 18 writers from Gaza, shedding light on life amid destruction.

Set against the violence that is now approaching its third year, the stories insist on the humanity of the people living through it. They point to the scale of the devastation through the daily struggles of Palestinians, but do not reduce them to mere statistics or victims. Instead, they illuminate a rich tapestry of life, and a range of emotions. Some focus on moments of grace and joy — the aroma of coffee or shakshuka being cooked and shared among displaced family members in a tent.

EVERY MOMENT IS A LIFE: GAZA IN THE TIME OF GENOCIDE
SUSAN ABULHAWA
Signal Pr
224 pages
₹799

Others dwell on the daily indignities of life, such as standing in long queues outside communal toilets, water becoming a diminishing resource, or surviving on food coupons, after a lifetime of working to bring food to the table. In Fatma Asfour's *Fashionista*, the protagonist Rosa is determined to stand out in a sea of people with whom she shelters in an encampment at a school in Khan Younis. Her resistance reflects a universal desire for individuality amid strife. Other stories also reflect on the broader struggle of living through a genocide and economic uncertainty.

The anthology works on different levels: It is part testimony, part literary prose and part archival. It has an emotional range that oscillates between shared grief and alienating suffering; despair and hope.

Coffee by Old Blue by Muhammad Mu'ammar kicks off with the vivid imagery of Gaza's Mediterranean shoreline, which now marks the final frontier of a homeland slipping away. The displaced narrator, now living by the sea — a location he once coveted as a place to build a home — is torn between his fondness for its deep blue waters and the sorrows they have come to hold. The story highlights a recurring theme of the struggle of Palestinians to feel like they belong on their own land.

Ghassan Salam's *Ma'rouf*, on the other hand, evokes tenderness and fear for the children coming under Israeli bombardment. In a world determined to look away, it stands out in its refusal to provide any relief.

Also central to the storytelling are the Palestinian women. Not only are 12 of the 18 contributors women, but many of the male writers reflect on their mothers' anxieties or on losing their wives, offering a touching portrayal of their relationships with the women. Though bare of nonessential words, the stories often hit starkly lyrical notes while remaining rooted in the history of the land — a testament to the legacy of Refaat Alareer and Heba Abu Nada, among other slain Palestinian poets and writers.

The anthology feels crucial to the Palestinian narrative, large parts of which remain missing from daily news. In between its lines is a disenchantment with the world that abandoned Gaza. The writers don't intend to make it a comfortable read. Instead, they uphold the complexity of Palestinian life to demand a response to the crisis.

The Last Gamble

Josy Joseph's Birth of a Nation *is an account of the negotiations and machinations of the princely states in the weeks leading up to India's Independence*

Rohan Manoj

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

IN NATIONAL INTEREST
The entrance bridge to the city of Hyderabad, Andhra Pradesh, in 1892

FOR SARDAR Vallabhbhai Patel, the alternative to accepting Partition was something worse than Pakistan: "Raja-sthan". That is, the potential fragmentation of India as a result of princely states refusing to accede to the Union. Jawaharlal Nehru feared "balkanisation" or an "indefinite number of partitions". Choudhry Rahmat Ali once imagined, as Sunil Purushottam writes in *From Raj to Republic: Sovereignty, Violence and Democracy in India*, "a Pakistan consisting of a fragmented yet subcontinental landscape of Muslim sovereignty", including an "Osmanistan" roughly corresponding to Hyderabad State — yet with no notion of the ruling Asaf Jahi dynasty retaining their sovereignty. These imaginations of the future, national and "non-national", left little room for the princely states. Yet, some of the latter, with support from elements of the British establishment, were busy trying to carve out a niche for themselves in the run-up to Independence.

Josy Joseph's *Birth of a Nation: The Twenty-one Days that Made India*, is an account of some of the negotiations and machinations the leaders of these states engaged in over the three weeks leading up to August 15, 1947, and how India's interim government, and particularly the newly formed States Department under Patel, worked to thwart their ambitions. On the one side, the cast of characters includes the leaders of several states, such as the Nizam of Hyderabad, the Nawab of Bhopal, the Jam Saheb of Nawanagar, and the Dewan of Travancore, Sir C P Ramaswami Iyer. On the other side, there are the "giants" — Gandhi, Nehru, Patel, Mountbatten — and the "unsung heroes" working in their shadow.

One might quibble about how "unsung" a figure like V P Menon really is. Even others such as Aravamudu Aiyangar, the Nizam's minister who secretly passed on information to the leadership in Delhi, are not unknown to history. Some of the stories, including K C S Mani's assassination attempt on Sir C P and how it stopped his bid to secure independence for Travancore, are quite well known. On the other hand, tidbits such as the efforts by some of the erstwhile rajas of Malabar — who had not held political power since Tipu Sultan's invasion — to secure greater recognition amid the manoeuvres by the states are interesting.

The book's stories are "plucked from the dust of the Archives' files and several private papers and academic collections". An engaging read, it might have benefitted from incorporating more of the scholarship on that period, including recent works such as Purushottam's book cited above and Rama Sundari Mantena's *Provincial Democracy: Political Imaginaries at the End of Empire in Twentieth-Century South India*. It could also have profited from more careful proofreading — Gaekwad becomes Gaekwar, Bordoloi becomes Bardoloi, among a number of typos.

The narrative is also teleological in nature, which shifts the focus on the tactics — Nehru's idealistic, hardline republican approach to the princely states, contrasted with Patel and Menon's seemingly accommodating pragmatism, or missteps in the Northeast. At the same time, the antagonists are painted with a broad brush. Only Sir C P's proverbial intelligence survives. As stated in the introduction, the book has a lesson in mind: That "a Republic is hard-won, and that its preservation lies in knowing its roots". That is a grand project, and a vital one today. The book provides a narrative of some important political manoeuvring, but the issues surrounding the birth of the Republic — including contradictions and violence — were complex and entailed more than the heroic efforts of a few men.

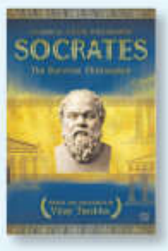
BIRTH OF A NATION: THE TWENTY-ONE DAYS THAT MADE INDIA
JOSY JOSEPH
Context
297 pages
₹799

A, perhaps, fanciful exercise might be to wonder how realistic the states' ambitions, such as Sir C P's vision of an "American-model", thorium-exporting Travancore, or the pretensions the Nizam held at one point to international Muslim leadership, were in the face of reality: The disintegration of their patron, the British Empire, and the overwhelming economic leverage and military weight of the Dominion of India. That's not to mention the rising nationalism and Congress influence among the public in the states. Maybe it was always an impossible dream, despite all the plots and conspiracies in the world, as the Nizam would find out.

But what makes the princely states interesting is precisely how they came to have these ambitions, and how these kingdoms, shaped by colonial modernity yet claiming pre-colonial legitimacy, conceived of themselves. They offered their own critiques of what was happening in British India. Hyderabad, for instance, claimed — that is not to say this reflected reality — that it was not affected by communalism, that Hindus and Muslims were the "two eyes of the state". It has been argued that a "balance" was struck between the communities through the politics of interest rather than the politics of numbers, as Purushottam puts it, with Muslims getting a disproportionate share of power and representation despite making up just 15 per cent of the population. However anti-democratic and unjust, there was a theory of politics here, perhaps, even a worldview. That, and the fact that a quarter of India's population lived under the rule of these "sovereigns", makes them deserving of far more study and popular attention.

SHELF LIFE

In Search of Socrates



SOCRATES: THE BAREFOOT PHILOSOPHER
VIJAY TANKHA
Hachette
240 pages
₹499

SOCRATES'S LIFE was as remarkable as his death. He claimed to know nothing, walked barefoot, liked being the target of comedians, mesmerised young philosophers and infuriated those in power. His ability to reason had the effect of a sting ray. He described himself as a gadfly and a midwife. He had no ideas of his own but could give birth to the ideas of others. He accepted the death sentence awarded to him by the Athenian court with equanimity. He refused to leave the prison and run away when Crito offered him the chance to do so.

Our knowledge of Socrates is circumscribed by the people who wrote about him. Our information comes from three sources: Xenophon, not a well regarded historian; Aristophanes, an acerbic satirist; and Plato, who puts his own words into Socrates' mouth. The three do not necessarily give the same information. One option might be to reconstruct Socrates' life and write a biography of him, as some have tried. The other is to present the Greek philosopher through the flowing pens of those who wrote about him.

Socrates: The Barefoot Philosopher by Vijay Tankha, former head of Department of Philosophy at St. Stephen's, uses the latter approach to great effect. It presents Socrates as how his contemporaries and later biographers saw him. The reader is presented with tracts of writing from Diogenes Laertius, Xenophon, Plato and Aristophanes, ordered by first presenting Socrates's unusual attributes — his marked ugliness, his bravery in battle, his love of Athens, his closeness to the strikingly beautiful man Alcibiades, his ironic stance — and later, by delving gently into philosophical issues. Not only does it present a livelier Socrates but it is also an entertaining introduction to the subject of Philosophy.

Socrates was confident of certain beliefs he held, received with either puzzlement or just amazement by his dazzled interlocutors: that virtue is knowledge, that doing harm is much worse than suffering harm, that we sometimes choose to act against our best interest not because passion misleads us but because we are ignorant, and that no man does wrong knowingly. Socratic argument is troublesome because it uses familiar examples to make a paradoxical belief look obvious. The book, by selecting passages from the dialogues of Plato — *Meno*, *Gorgias*, *Protagoras*, *Euthyphro* — gives us a flavour of the way Socrates argued.

Socrates's main target was to show that his interlocutors simply did not know what they were talking about. The admirers of Socrates, not a small crowd, enjoyed this cross examination but the victims did not. The book, thankfully, does not harp much on the Socratic slogan — "Know thyself" — as it can have misleading connotations. Tankha makes it clear that Socrates need not have believed in the immortality of soul, contrary to common perception. The passages from Aristophanes's *The Clouds* are delightful, with Socrates being lampooned for his interest in nature and his way with words.

The portrait of Socrates that emerges from this book is one we expected but did not know how to put into words: a Socrates that is endearing, baffling and maddening; one who taught us to love reason, control our passions, and take care of ourselves in that peculiar way that only Socrates knew.

NILANJAN BHOWMICK
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What the Bar Could Be

Through 14 powerful portraits of lawyers, Raju Ramachandran offers a quiet lesson on the law's capacity to speak truth to power

Apurva Vishwanath

THERE IS a particular kind of disillusionment that comes from watching a trusted institution slowly turn away from the people it exists to protect. As thousands of students stand in Jantar Mantar demanding accountability for a broken examination system, they are met with tear gas and batons. When a plea about police excesses reached the Delhi High Court, the police were given a comfortable four weeks to ponder and respond while the Supreme Court, famously, had no time to waste on it. A month ago, it was the Chief Justice of India who inadvertently likened the country's frustrated, unemployed young to cockroaches and parasites — a phrase the protesters are wearing, almost gleefully, as their own name. The remark and the judiciary's reaction are part of a now familiar pattern, and it points to something larger than one bad month for the institution. It is the slow hollowing of the idea that the judiciary exists to hold power to account rather than to defer to it.

It is against this backdrop that I read Raju Ramachandran's *14 Lawyers: Portraits from the Bar*, which lands with unexpected timeliness. The book is, of course, not about the present crisis — it is a set of pen-portraits of lawyers, many now dead, who shaped the Supreme Court across earlier, difficult decades. But read today, it becomes a record of what the Bar looked like when it still understood itself as a check on power rather than an ornament to it.

Ramachandran's subjects are not uniformly heroic, and the book is wiser for resisting hagiography. Frank Anthony's defence of the "Indianness" of the English language, made to counter Hindi imposition in the Constituent Assembly, feels as relevant today as it did then. About the legendary Tehmtan Andhyarujina, Ramachandran's anecdote from the Yakub Memon death penalty case is a reminder of what a stalwart of the Bar ought to be. Appearing for the Death Penalty Clinic (now the Square Circle Clinic), Andhyarujina, then an octogenarian, argued that the death warrant against Memon deserved to be quashed on procedural grounds. "I hope you know whom you are trying to save," a judge remarked. One imagines Andhyarujina did not flinch. One also imagines, sadly, that such a comment could today pass for the opening line of an opposing counsel's argument. The book also profiles Justice V M Tarakunde, a former Bombay High Court judge who, after retirement, actively defended civil liberties during the Emergency. That Tarakunde could not reconcile with an old friend, Justice Y V Chandrachud, over the latter's decision in the infamous ADM Jabalpur case, is testament to the fact that the political is, in the end, personal. Of lawyers Barry Sen and Lal Narayan Sinha, Ramachandran writes that they were so "mild-mannered" and "gentlemanly" that they would likely be overlooked today for a "senior" designation. This seemingly small, pointed detail serves as a quiet lesson for young lawyers, who might be tempted to turn a courtroom victory into an Instagram reel, that there is a difference between a better argument and a louder, or worse, viral one.

THE ORDER IN LAW
Bar Council of India

14 LAWYERS: PORTRAITS FROM THE BAR
RAJU RAMACHANDRAN
Juggernaut
248 pages
₹799

What emerges from these 14 portraits, finally, is not a lament for a golden age or a template for a good lawyer — Ramachandran is too careful a chronicler for that. The book is a reminder that the judiciary does not falter alone. It is held up or let down by the Bar that appears before it, argues before it, and, in its better moments, disciplines it by displaying sheer professional courage and competence. The silence of the Bench is often a direct consequence of the silence of the Bar. Ask around in the corridors to hear stories of not finding counsel willing to make an inconvenient argument, or the difficulty in getting a senior for an "anti-national" brief. Those who speak up risk carrying partisan labels and, in any case, are few in number and are the same dozen. There is, of course, no dearth of lawyers for farewells, felicitations and high tea events to sing praises of judges, even those accused of corruption or sexual harassment. An institution does not erode in a single dramatic collapse but in small everyday capitulation.

There is much to gain in putting together the rich oral history of the Bar. These are stories of the greats, warnings and humorous lessons that, I suppose, are ever so slightly embellished every time a senior retells them. This book does that very well, without the embellishments. It offers a glimpse of what the Bar could be.

'We wanted to tell a green-flag love story'

Writer-creator Sharanya Rajgopal, director Ruchir Arun, and the actors of Musafir Cafe *on why ordinary relationships deserve extraordinary storytelling*

Alaka Sahani

WITHIN MONTHS of acquiring the rights to Divya Prakash Dubey's novel *Musafir Cafe*, writer-creator Sharanya Rajgopal had already found her Chander. There was just one hiccup: Vikrant Massey had become one of the most sought-after actors in the country after the phenomenal success of *12th Fail* (2023). "When I approached his agent, the response was, 'You can't afford him'," Rajgopal recalls, with a laugh. Not only did Massey eventually agree to play the protagonist, he also came on board as co-producer. "I wanted to produce stories beyond the work we were already doing. *Musafir Cafe* felt like the perfect fit. It was a natural extension of what I wanted to do through Homemade Stories (his production company) — tell simple but impactful stories," says the National Award-winning actor.

Released on Netflix on Friday, the eight-episode series is an exploration of love, ambition and modern relationships. Set across Bhopal and Mussoorie, it follows Chander, a techie who dreams of opening a cafe in the hills. While working in Bhopal, he falls in love with Sudha (Vedika Pinto), a lawyer determined to build a successful career. Their friendship evolves into an unconventional live-in relationship as they struggle to balance companionship with independence. Running parallel to it is Chander's present-day life in Mussoorie, where he and Preeti (Mahima Makwana) live together and run a cafe. If his bond with Sudha is marked by passion, his relationship with Preeti is built on quiet understanding.

> Life teaches you that people are complicated. That's what makes the series feel authentic. Every character carries contradictions that we recognise in ourselves
>
> **VIKRANT MASSEY**
> *Actor*

What first drew Rajgopal to Dubey's novel was its central idea of nurturing an impossible dream. "The book was largely made up of conversations between Chander and Sudha, which felt incredibly relatable," she says. Because it wasn't plot-driven, adapting it required re-imagining its world and introducing new characters. She spent nearly five months developing the series bible and writing the first two episodes before Netflix green-lit the project in January 2025. The remaining episodes took another six months.

The script, however, continued to evolve. "Once Ruchir Arun joined as the director, the storytelling became much more layered. For almost six weeks, we sat with the script every single day, questioning every scene and asking how we could push the emotional stakes further. Even during filming, Vikrant and Ruchir would constantly encourage me to go deeper," recalls Rajgopal, who is studio head at Terribly Tiny Tales.

That collaborative process helped shape a series where every character feels layered. Massey agrees. "Life teaches you that people are far more complicated than we imagine. That's what makes the series feel authentic. Every character carries contradictions that we recognise in ourselves," says the actor, who is part of movies such as *A Death in the Gunj* (2016) and *Haseen Dillruba* (2021), as well as series *Mirzapur* (2018) and *Criminal Justice* (2019).

LOVE ALL (Clockwise from top) A still from *Musafir Cafe*; Vedika Pinto; writer Sharanya Rajgopal and director Ruchir Arun

One of the biggest challenges was casting Sudha and Preeti. Pinto went through multiple rounds of auditions. "The first audition was terrible. It happened to be the weekend *Nishaanchi* (2025) released. I had prepared, but mentally I wasn't fully there," Pinto admits. A few days later, instead of another audition, Rajgopal met her for a conversation. "We sat and spoke about books. I realised I didn't want another audition," says Rajgopal. Makwana similarly made an instant impact. "The moment I saw her, I thought, 'This girl lights up the screen.' We eventually conducted chemistry reads between all three actors because a love story lives or dies by chemistry. What fascinated us was how Chander's energy changed depending on who he was with."

For Arun, the most rewarding part was watching the story transform at every stage. "A story evolves as it passes from the writer's mind to the director's, and then to the actors. Once the cast came on board and we found the homes, the streets of Mussoorie and the spaces these characters inhabited, the world of *Musafir Cafe* slowly came alive," he says. He was equally fascinated by the actors' approach to their roles. "Vikrant tapped into his younger self to portray Chander's first love with Sudha. For his relationship with Preeti, he drew from a more mature emotional space — one that is affectionate, protective and secure," recalls the director of *Little Things* (2018-21), *Ghar Waapsi* (2022) and *Loot Kand* (2025).

Backing a relationship drama in today's streaming landscape, Massey believes, was a risk worth taking. "Thrillers, crime dramas and darker stories dominate OTT today. That's why I applaud Netflix and Terribly Tiny Tales for backing a show like *Musafir Cafe*. It takes courage to go against the tide and tell a quiet, deeply emotional story," he says. Arun agrees, "Nobody here was chasing the spectacle. No one was trying to kill anyone or solve a mystery. We were simply telling the story of ordinary people and their emotional lives. Today, we're surrounded by stories about toxic relationships. That's why I felt there was a need to tell a green-flag love story too."

> Nobody here was chasing the spectacle. No one was trying to kill anyone or solve a mystery. We were simply telling the story of ordinary people and their emotional lives
>
> **RUCHIR ARUN**
> *Director*

The experience of playing Sudha offered Pinto a chance to embrace contradiction. "Unlike *Nishaanchi*, which belonged to a world completely unfamiliar to me, Sudha felt deeply personal. As women, we're constantly trying to understand ourselves — our emotions, ambitions and desires," she says. Makwana found an equally personal connection with Preeti. "The quiet, internal characters don't often receive enough attention, but they're much harder to play. I never imagined Preeti existed within me. She gave me something I had been searching for — peace, clarity and stillness."

For everyone involved, *Musafir Cafe* is less about making a statement about live-in relationships or modern romance. It is more like a reminder about the small, often overlooked moments — the conversations, silences and compromises — that define relationships.

HEAD AND SHOULDER ABOVE A still from *Angh*; (below) co-producer and director Theja Rio

Nagaland film heads to Toronto

Kohima-based Theja Rio's debut feature, Angh, *will compete in TIFF's auteur section*

Alaka Sahani

KOHIMA-BASED filmmaker Theja Rio's debut feature, *Angh*, has been selected for the Platform Competition at the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF) 2026, making it the only Indian film in the festival's competition section. Set in 1960s Nagaland, this Konyak-language father-son drama will compete alongside 11 international titles in the festival's prestigious auteur-focused segment.

The story unfolds in the remote jungles of Nagaland near the Indo-Burma border in the early 1960s. *Angh* (which in local Konyak language means 'chief') follows Anghba, the last surviving chief of an abandoned indigenous Naga village. He lives an isolated life, with his ailing wife and speech-impaired young son after he's deserted by his people. Rooted in the oral histories and spiritual traditions of the Naga people, the film explores the disappearance of an indigenous world through their story.

"*Angh* is a story about a people navigating the fragile passage from an ancestral past to an uncertain future. I had hoped the film would travel far beyond the land where it was born, inviting audiences not only into a story but into the lives of people, their memories and their relationship with the world around them," says Rio.

The co-producer and director believes that film festivals like TIFF have the power to bring underrepresented cultures into the global conversation. "For us, presenting *Angh* on this stage is about far more than the recognition of a debut feature. It is a moment of visibility for the people, culture and storytelling traditions of Nagaland voices that deserve to be heard, seen and celebrated by audiences across the world," says Rio, who has done masters in Directing Fiction at the National Film and Television School, UK.

Angh features BAFTA Award-winning actor Douglas Henshall (of *Shetland* and *Outlander* fame) alongside an ensemble cast of indigenous actors from Nagaland. "*Angh* is shot on 16mm and performed almost entirely by non-actors from the region, in a tribal language spoken by fewer than one lakh people. This approach was not a stylistic gesture but a necessity." says Rio, who has directed other short films such as *Checkpost* (2018) and *Ade* (2024).

Platform, TIFF's auteur-driven competitive section, celebrates distinctive directorial voices. Beginning this year, the winner of the competition will automatically qualify for consideration in the Academy Awards' International Feature Film category.

Producer Nancy Nisa Beso shares that *Angh* is the result of a strong desire to tell stories that belong to Nagaland. "It is our attempt to honour our people, preserve the stories of our ancestors, and reclaim our narrative by taking it from the margins to the global stage. What made this journey particularly special was bringing together an extraordinary mix of talent from around the world to tell that story," says Nancy. The film's international crew includes Polish cinematographer Adam Pietkiewicz, Lisbon-based production designer Margarida Caetano Dias and costume designer Manisha Garg. Makeup designer Priya Lahon did an authentic depiction of traditional tattoos from Nagaland while Bendang Walling put together the ensemble of actors. Co-written by James Davis, *Angh* is produced by Winter Hymns Film and Undercover Squirrel.

Why supercops don't exist anymore

What began as the story of a cop resisting institutional decay slowly deteriorated into a cinematic universe where the institution could no longer be wrong

Anas Arif

ON A gloomy afternoon in Delhi, the country's youngest voices were met with brute force. Lathis rained down on them. Tear gas seared their eyes. Women spoke of being harassed. As these words are being written, the Internet is awash with videos of the violence, one of them showing a protester standing eye to eye with a policeman, asking him to strike again. In another clip, a man lies motionless on the road as his friends gather around him, waiting for help to arrive. Confronted with these images, one question refuses to leave: Are these the very policemen our cinema has celebrated and turned into larger-than-life heroes?

It is a troubling question to ask at a moment when *Singham* completes 15 years. A generation has grown up on Rohit Shetty's vision of the righteous cop: the incorruptible man in uniform who bends the law only to uphold justice, whose violence arrives dressed in morality, whose rage is always redemptive. But when reality unfolds in broad daylight, the distance between narrative fiction and lived fact narrows down. Perhaps this is not a moment of disillusionment. Disillusionment suggests something has been lost. This feels closer to an awakening to the widening gulf between the stories we have chosen to believe and the truths that unfold in front of our eyes.

But, for a moment, suspend the present. Forget the clips and the images that have come to define our own time. Forget because that is what every regime ultimately asks of its citizens, to remember selectively. Return instead to 15 years ago. *Singham* arrived at a moment when the single-screen action hero was finding his voice again. While Ajay Devgn's Bajirao Singham became its most prominent face, the revival had begun earlier with Salman Khan's Radhe in *Wanted* (2009) and Chulbul Pandey in *Dabangg* (2010). After years of uneven fortunes, both the films did more than restore Khan's superstardom. It resurrected a particular idea of the Hindi film hero: the larger-than-life saviour who could cut through institutional decay with the certainty of his fists.

RIGHT SIDE WRONG Ajay Devgn as the valiant policeman Bajirao Singham in *Singham*; Ranveer Singh in *Simmba*

But neither *Wanted* nor *Singham* were born out of originality. Both are remakes of successful south-Indian potboilers, both centred on policemen who step outside the law to cleanse a system portrayed as irredeemably corrupt. Their moral universe is uncomplicated: when institutions fail, the hero must become the institution. Khan and Devgn understood the grammar of the gallery. They fashioned righteous anger into mass entertainment, and gave audiences the exhilarating certainty that justice, however delayed, could still arrive with a punchline, a flying jeep, and a man in uniform.

That is perhaps why even *Singham Returns* (2014), a sequel more mechanical and far less inspired, retained a measure of its appeal. The righteous policeman is a creature of an unrighteous order. His heroism is earned in the moment he turns against the very machinery that legitimises it.

But with 2014, everything changed. The political imagination was devolving, and with it, the stories Hindi cinema chose to tell. The corrupt state, the failing institution disappeared from the mainstream narrative. The enemy was no longer the system. The system itself had become sacred. Shetty's idea of the policeman changed with it. What began as the story of a cop resisting institutional decay slowly deteriorated into a cinematic universe where the institution could no longer be wrong. With the expansion of his cop universe, and its culmination in *Singham Again*, where Devgn's *Singham* joined forces with Akshay Kumar's *Sooryavanshi* (2021) and Ranveer Singh's *Simmba* (2019), the moral centre of these films underwent a profound transformation. Violence was no longer an act of resistance against power. In fact, it became an expression of power itself.

Devgn recently unveiled the first look of his next cop drama, *Chauhaan*, set against the fraught landscape of Kashmir. The image is familiar: a cop defined by excess, introduced as "The OG Action Star," poised to unleash force upon a crowd. In the promotional asset, he casually remarks that tear gas does not do much damage to protesters. Perhaps it doesn't, in the grammar of contemporary commercial cinema, where violence passes for virtue. Reality, however, has no background score to soften its blows.

Tear gas does not dissipate with a cut to the next scene. It scorches the lungs, burns through eyes, scatters families and leaves children crying in streets that will never make it into the final edit.

Streets find their Sound

From Faiz's Hum dekhenge *and Bob Marley's* Redemption Song *to movie tunes and rap bars, songs and poetry that make up protest music*

Suanshu Khurana

Chhatro mein bhara tha junoon dekha, Dilli police pe sawar maine khoon dekha
Civil dress mein gundo ki dhun dekha, Aur vardi walo ki nameplate gum dekha...
Democracy ki huyi vahan aisi taisi par, sarkaar ko maine phir bhi chup dekha
(I saw passion-filled students, I saw blood riding on Delhi police/ I saw the tune of goons in civil dress and the lost name plate of uniform/ Democracy was in tatters but I still saw a silent government)

OVER A 1,000 kilometres from Delhi where scores of students demanding accountability from the Centre over exam paper leaks were met with tear gas and police batons, Nagpur-based musician Vinod Balakrishna Waghade, who goes by the pulpy moniker Garam Kalakar, sat down to write. The rap bars were a response to what he saw at the Jantar Mantar protests on his social media feed. He got his friend to compose it and recorded it in a studio, uploading it as *Jantar Mantar Par Kya Dekha?*. Within minutes, the track began to race across social media and by day's end, had amassed nearly four million views.

"Reading about kids ending their lives and then the ones protesting for systemic change being subjected to such brutal behaviour really shook me," said Wagahde, 40, who once aspired to crack NEET. A school topper, he recalls a period when the pressure of chasing a medical seat left him struggling with suicidal thoughts. "I even attempted once," he says. His father wasn't willing to get him coaching as he believed sending his son to school was enough. Waghade, who couldn't make it, still cannot shake off the feeling of helplessness. "I had to write," he says, in a conversation with *The Indian Express*. He believes music communicates what is often difficult to state outright, sometimes giving strangers a collective purpose.

At the protest site in Delhi, a cluster of students who have been regulars from the outset, pick up Kashif Malik's call-and-response pattern. *Yuva ghoome khaali khaali, thap karobar hai/ Netao ke naam pe gadho ki bharmaar hai, kaisi sarkaar hai ye kaisi sarkaar hai.* The new ones join in. Malik is a part of Collective Delhi, a student youth activist organisation, and wrote these lines for the ongoing protest. "Cultural movements have always been at the heart of any revolution for decades. We may not be able to reach people with books the way we can reach them with songs or plays, especially in a country like India, where democratisation of knowledge still isn't there," says 24-year-old Gowri Kolal, who has been singing alongside Malik.

• • •

"In the dark times, will there also be singing? Yes, there will also be singing. About the dark times," German poet and playwright Bertold Brecht wrote once. Few lines have captured the purpose of protest music more precisely. From the blues that once documented the exploitation of African slaves in encrypted songs that criticised Jim Crow Laws and civil rights anthems such as *We shall overcome* or musicians like Bob Dylan and Joan Baez who used music as resistance, to the Italian anti-fascist song *Bella Ciao* and the anti-colonial Progressive Writers' Movement in the subcontinent with writers such as Faiz Ahmed Faiz, Kaifi Azmi, Krishan Chander, Ali Sardar Jafri, Sahir Ludhianvi and Rajinder Singh Bedi, among others, creating a cultural vocabulary of resistance, here were musicians directly engaging with the social and political crisis of the time.

In fact, protest has always been shaped by songs and poetry. From folk to punk, hip-hop to rap and even film songs, music and poetry have almost always stood in solidarity with ordinary citizens. "Songs get memorised easily. They stay with you for a very long time," says 23-year-old music producer and hip hop artiste Chaar Diwaari aka Garv Taneja, who marched with the students on July 20. "Be it personal or political, art is deeply relevant to what goes on in an artiste's life. If something moved you, you can't help but write about it," says Taneja, who found himself revisiting an old half-written song after being compelled by the protests.

ANTHEMS OF A NATION
(Above) Protestors at Jantar Mantar, Delhi; Vedi Hashiya sang poet and lyricist Ali Sardar Jafri's *Fareb*

At Jantar Mantar, while students, parents and civil rights groups have been finding inspiration in the newly written rap verses from many artistes and viral film protest songs such as *Rang de basanti*, *Sadda haq* (*Rockstar*), *Give me some sunshine* (*3 Idiots*), *Yeh jo des hai tera* (*Swades*), Michael Jackson's *They don't care about us*, Bob Dylan's *Blowin' in the wind* and Dub Sharma and DIVINE's *Azadi* (*Gully Boy*) continue to be sung and played. Encore ABJ aka Abhijay Negi, one half of the Delhi hip-hop duo Seedhe Maut, was also spotted at the protest, where fans quickly recognised him. At one point, he was heard rapping verses from his popular track from a few years ago. The song *Red*, including the lines: *Bhoori hai khaal, bhoore kandhe pe haath... APJ, Bose, Bhagat Singh, Chandra Shekhar Azad... Main anti-government, ye bole anti-national.*

Language and melodies may be different but music in a protest helps people survive uncertainty and fear

"Hip hop was born to talk of social subjects," says Waghade of the origins of hip hop that emerged in the Black and Latino neighbourhoods of Bronx in New York, synonymous with poverty, discrimination, police violence and marginalisation once.

But some of the most popular ones are also some of the oldest. Faiz's *Hum dekhenge*, written in 1979 against General Zia-ul-Haq's military dictatorship in Pakistan, has become an almost indispensable fixture. His *Bol ke lab azaad hain tere* remains a rallying cry. Equally enduring is Shailendra's *Tu zinda hai*, which he wrote for the Indian People's Theatre Association, an organisation with artists such as Salil Chowdhury and Kaifi Azmi, among others that turned art into a means of political mobilisation.

What has been most unexpected, however, in the current wave of protests is the resurgence of famed poet and lyricist Ali Sardar Jafri's *Fareb* (Deceit). Delhi-based musician Vedi Hashiya, 33, who performs nirgun folk as part of Capital-based outfit Aahvaan Project, is seen singing *Fareb* along a ukulele. Fareb does not have the uplifted optimism of *Hum dekhenge*. It questions the illusions of liberty and questions whether the promise of freedom means anything without any tangible change. She sings, *Saans leti hui lashon ka hujoom, Beech mein unke phira karti hai bekaari bhi...* (A crowd of breathing corpses, And wandering aimlessly among them is unemployment too). Vedi found this poem during the CAA protests and it has stayed with her since. "What is interesting is that after what we saw on June 20, some of the lyrics just came alive. What some of these people were saying still holds. Understanding a truth is one thing, letting it take root in your heart is another," says Vedi, who studied sociology at JNU. She feels art can be heavily political. "Language also cuts us after a while. But we all have songs in us. We all have a form of music that we find enjoyable. Even if we disagree with each other, a musical piece may help us understand each other's pain better," says Vedi.

Outside the Indian Embassy in Berlin, actor and singer Ajitesh Gupta was heard singing Bob Marley's acoustic ballad, *Redemption Song*, with the lines *Emancipate yourself from mental slavery*, while Delhi was singing *Rozgaar ab na milega, shiksha mein hai ghotala*. The language, melodies and histories may be different, but the role of music in any protest remains remarkably constant: giving a shared vocabulary of resistance that helps people sustain their morale, survive long hours of uncertainty, even fear. "It helps you endure," says Waghade.

ADVERTORIAL

The Language You Don't Speak

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I was standing outside a tiny restaurant in Hanoi, trying to figure out what was being served. There was no English menu. No English signboard. Just a woman behind a counter, a pot of something that smelled incredible, and about fifteen locals sitting on plastic stools eating with the kind of focus that told me this was the right place. I walked in, pointed at what the man next to me was eating, held up one finger, and sat down.

What arrived was bun cha, grilled pork patties in a sweet broth with rice noodles and a plate of fresh herbs. It was, without exaggeration, one of the best things I have ever eaten. I didn't know what it was called until I looked it up later that night. I didn't know what was in the dipping sauce. I didn't know that bun cha was a Hanoi specialty and that I had accidentally walked into the kind of neighbourhood place that food writers spend weeks trying to find. None of that would have happened if I had been able to read the menu. I would have studied it, Googled reviews, maybe walked to the next place. Instead, I pointed. And the meal found me.

I have been thinking about this a lot. About what happens when you travel somewhere you don't speak the language, and how that experience is almost always better than we expect it to be.

The Fear Is the First Thing to Go

Let's be honest about what holds Indian travellers back from non-English-speaking destinations. It's not money. It's not distance. It's the language.

I hear it constantly. "I would love to go to Japan, but I don't speak Japanese." "Vietnam looks amazing, but how will I manage?" "I want to try South America, but my Spanish is zero." The assumption is that not speaking the local language makes you helpless. That you will get lost, order the wrong thing, end up on the wrong train, offend someone accidentally, or, the big one, feel stupid.

Here's what actually happens. You land. You panic slightly at the airport because every sign looks like abstract art. You fumble through your first interaction at immigration. And then, somewhere between the taxi and the hotel, the fear just... leaves. Because it turns out that human beings have been communicating without shared language for about 2,00,000 years, and we are remarkably good at it.

A smile works everywhere. Pointing works everywhere. Holding up fingers for numbers works everywhere. The Google Translate camera, where you point your phone at a menu and it translates in real time, has quietly become the most important travel tool of the decade. And the moment you accept that you won't understand everything, something loosens in your chest and you start actually seeing the place instead of trying to decode it.

What You Gain When You Lose the Words

The interesting thing about not speaking the language isn't what you lose. It's what you gain. When you can't eavesdrop on the conversation at the next table, you start observing instead. How people greet each other. How they hold their chopsticks. How the waiter interacts with a regular versus a first-timer. In Tokyo, I spent an entire evening at a counter-seat yakitori bar where I understood exactly zero of the conversation around me, and I noticed more about Japanese social dynamics in those two hours than I had in two days of sightseeing. The way the chef bowed slightly differently to each customer. The way nobody raised their voice, ever. The way a regular communicated his entire order with a nod and the chef responded with a nod back, a relationship so established that words had become unnecessary.

You eat better. This sounds counterintuitive, but it's true. When you can read a menu, you make safe choices. You pick what you recognise. You avoid the things you can't pronounce. When you can't read a menu, you surrender. You point at what someone else is having. You let the waiter decide. You say yes to the thing you would normally say no to. Some of my most fun and memorable meals have come from that surrender. A bowl of something unidentifiable in a back lane in Ho Chi Minh City that turned out to be hu tieu (a Southern Vietnamese noodle soup with Chinese-Cambodian origins), a street-side plate in Tbilisi that turned out to be adjarian khachapuri (a famous Georgian cheese bread shaped like a canoe) with a raw egg yolk staring up at me like a dare.

You connect differently. This one surprised me the most. You would think a language barrier would make human connection harder. It doesn't. It makes it more honest. When you can't hide behind small talk, you communicate with your face, your hands, your tone. The interactions become simpler but somehow more real. A shopkeeper in Kyoto who spent ten minutes wrapping a small gift for Raya with a level of care that no words could have improved. A cab driver in Kutaisi, Georgia, who didn't speak a word of English but spent the ride pointing at mountains and saying their names with such pride that I understood exactly what he was telling me. A woman in Hoi An who laughed at my attempt to order in Vietnamese, corrected my pronunciation three times, and then gave me an extra spring roll because, I think, she appreciated the effort.

These interactions don't happen when everything is smooth and translated and efficient. They happen in the gaps. In the pauses where you are both trying to figure out how to say what you mean without the words for it.

The Myth of the English-Speaking World

There is a comfortable illusion that many travellers carry, which is that English will get you through most places. And sure, in airports, international hotels, and tourist centres, it usually does. But step one lane off the main street in almost any country, and English disappears.

Japan is the most striking example of this. Tokyo is one of the most sophisticated cities on earth, and English proficiency outside the tourist circuits is remarkably low. Train announcements are in Japanese first, English second, and the English often covers only the major stops. Restaurant menus in local neighbourhoods are entirely in Japanese. Even Google Maps behaves differently because addresses work differently. And yet, Japan is also the easiest country I have ever travelled in without speaking the language. Because the infrastructure compensates. The signage is clear even if you can't read it. The trains are so punctual that you can navigate by timing alone. And the people are so instinctively helpful that someone will walk you to your destination rather than try to explain it.

Georgia was the opposite experience. The infrastructure doesn't compensate. Signs outside Tbilisi are in Georgian script, which is beautiful but completely impenetrable if you don't read it. English is limited. Russian helps more, but I don't speak that either. What Georgia has instead is sheer human warmth. People don't just give you directions, they drive you there. They don't just recommend a restaurant, they call ahead and tell the owner you are coming. The language barrier in Georgia isn't a wall. It's a door that people on the other side keep opening for you.

Vietnam sits somewhere in between. In the cities, enough English exists to survive. In the countryside, you are on your own. And the countryside is where Vietnam is most itself, rice paddies, water buffalo, families eating lunch on the floor of their front room with the door open to the street. You wave, they wave back, someone gestures for you to sit down, and suddenly you are eating rice with strangers who are laughing at something you will never understand but will never forget.

The Real Reason to Travel Without the Words

I think the deeper truth about travelling where you don't speak the language is this: it makes you a beginner again.

At home, we are competent. We know how everything works. We read every sign, understand every conversation, navigate every system with the confidence of someone who has been doing it for decades. Travel to an English-speaking country and that competence transfers, you are a tourist, but you are still in control.

Travel to a place where you can't read, can't ask, can't decode, and that competence drops away. You are five years old again. You are looking at the world with the bewilderment and curiosity of someone who doesn't have the cheat codes. And that feeling, of being genuinely unsure what's going to happen next, is the feeling most of us are secretly travelling for in the first place. We just don't admit it because it sounds like a weakness. It's not. It's the whole point.

One Last Thing

So the next time someone tells you they would love to visit Japan or Vietnam or Georgia or Turkey or South America but the language puts them off, tell them this: the language barrier isn't the obstacle. It's the experience.

The meal you point at blindly. The train you almost miss because you couldn't read the sign. The conversation conducted entirely in gestures that somehow ends with both of you laughing. The moment you realise you haven't spoken your own language in six hours and you haven't missed it.

That's not a limitation. That's travel doing exactly what it's supposed to do, taking you somewhere your competence can't follow, and showing you that you never needed it as much as you thought.

Know the Unknown

You just read an entire article about how the world doesn't share a common language on the ground. But here's the thing: it does in the sky.

Since 2008, every pilot and every air traffic controller on the planet is required to speak English. Not optional. Not recommended. Required. The International Civil Aviation Organization made it mandatory after a series of accidents caused by miscommunication between cockpit and tower. A Korean pilot talking to a French controller in Zurich, a Brazilian crew misunderstanding an instruction in New York. The language barrier that makes travel interesting on the ground was, in the air, really dangerous.

So they fixed it. Today, a pilot taking off from Tokyo speaks to the tower in English. Landing in Sao Paulo, English. Crossing Afghan airspace, English. Every altitude call, every runway clearance, every emergency declaration on earth happens in one language. The sky solved the problem the ground never could.

And here is the small detail that got me: the system uses a stripped-down vocabulary called Aviation English, roughly 300 standardised phrases designed to eliminate ambiguity. "Roger" means received. "Wilco" means will comply. "Say again" instead of "what" because "what" sounds too much like other words at high speed. It is the most efficient common language humans have ever built, and most passengers have no idea it is happening above their heads while they sleep.

Ever since we launched flight bookings on Veena World, I have been going down these rabbit holes. And this one felt like it was made for this week's article. The ground can't agree on a single language. The sky already did. See you next week...

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